Friedrich-Alexander-Universität

Pattern Recognition Lab

# Continual Learning for Promptable Universal 3D Medical Image Segmentation in Few-Shot Settings

## Master's Thesis in Computer Science

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by

Shashank Shashank

born 25.03.1998 in India

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Lehrstuhl für Mustererkennung (Informatik 5)
Department Informatik
Friedrich-Alexander-Universität Erlangen-Nürnberg.

Advisor: Prof. Dr.-Ing. habil. Andreas Maier, Dr.-Ing. Tomás Arias Vergara

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## Übersicht

## Abstract

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# Notation

Scalars are written in italic, vectors in bold lowercase and matrices in bold uppercase letters. The section in the right column is where the symbol is first defined.

| Symbol | Meaning | Sec. |
|---|---|---|
| *Tasks and data* | | |
| $T$ | number of tasks in the task sequence ($T = 6$) | 5.1 |
| $t$; $j$ | task index; stage index ($j = 0$: pretrained model, $j = t$: after training on task $t$) | 3.2 |
| $k$ | number of labelled training volumes per task in a few-shot setting | 1.2 |
| $\mathcal{D}_t^{\mathrm{tr}}, \mathcal{D}_t^{\mathrm{val}}, \mathcal{D}_t^{\mathrm{te}}$ | training, validation and test set of task $t$ | 5.1 |
| $\mathcal{D}_c^{\mathrm{tr}}, \mathcal{D}_c^{\mathrm{te}}$ | training and test set of the control task | 5.1 |
| $p$; $p_t$; $p_c$ | text prompt; text prompt of task $t$; text prompt of the control task | 3.1.1 |
| $\boldsymbol{X}$ | image volume or patch | 3.1.1 |
| $\boldsymbol{Y}$; $\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}}$ | binary label mask; binary prediction | 3.1.1 |
| $\Omega$; $v$ | voxel set of a volume or patch; voxel | 3.1.1 |
| $y_v$; $z_v$; $\hat{y}_v$ | label, logit and predicted foreground probability of voxel $v$ | 3.1.1 |
| *Model* | | |
| $f_\theta$; $\theta$ | segmentation model with parameters $\theta$ | 3.1.1 |
| $\boldsymbol{Z}$ | output logits of the model for a volume or patch | 3.1.1 |
| $\sigma$ | logistic function | 3.1.1 |
| $\theta_0$ | pretrained parameters | 3.2 |
| $\theta_t$ | parameters after stage $t$, carried forward to the next task | 3.2 |
| $\tilde{\theta}_t$ | parameters evaluated after stage $t$ | 5.2 |

| Symbol | Meaning | Sec. |
|---|---|---|
| $P$ | number of parameters of the segmentation model | 5.5 |
| $s$ | resolution stage ($s = 0$: full resolution, $s = 5$: bottleneck) | 3.1.1 |
| $\boldsymbol{F}_s$; $C_s$ | encoder features of stage $s$; their number of channels | 3.1.1 |
| $\boldsymbol{U}$; $\boldsymbol{S}$ | query vectors and source vectors of an attention block (rows) | 3.1.2 |
| $n_q$; $n_s$; $n_h$ | number of queries, of sources and of attention heads | 3.1.2 |
| $d$; $d_h$ | model dimension; dimension per attention head | 3.1.2 |
| $\boldsymbol{W}_q, \boldsymbol{W}_k, \boldsymbol{W}_v, \boldsymbol{W}_o$ | query, key, value and output projections of an attention block | 3.1.2 |
| $\boldsymbol{x}$ | input of a linear projection $\boldsymbol{x} \mapsto \boldsymbol{W}\boldsymbol{x}$ | 3.1.2 |
| $f_{\text{text}}$; $\boldsymbol{q}$ | frozen text encoder; text query $\boldsymbol{q} = f_{\text{text}}(p)$ | 3.1.3 |
| $L_{\text{dec}}$ | number of prompt-decoder layers ($L_{\text{dec}} = 6$) | 3.1.3 |
| $G$; $\boldsymbol{E}_s$ | number of guidance vectors ($G = 32$); text-guidance matrix of stage $s$ | 3.1.3 |
| $\boldsymbol{H}_s$; $\boldsymbol{H}'_s$ | decoder features of stage $s$ after and before the fusion with the text guidance | 3.1.3 |
| *Training* | | |
| $\mathcal{S}$ | continual-learning strategy | 5.2 |
| $\phi$ | parameters trained by a strategy | 5.3 |
| $\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}$ | segmentation loss | 3.1.1 |
| $\epsilon$ | smoothing constant of the soft Dice loss | 5.3 |
| $E$; $N_t$; $U$ | epochs per task; training samples per epoch of task $t$; iterations per task, $U = E \cdot N_t$ | 5.3 |
| $\eta_0$; $\mu$; $\omega$ | initial learning rate; momentum; weight decay | 5.3 |
| $\pi_{\text{fg}}$ | probability that a training patch is centred on a voxel of the target structure | 5.3 |
| $\ell$; $\ell^*$; $\theta^{\text{best}}$ | validation loss of an epoch; lowest validation loss so far; parameters with the lowest validation loss | 5.3 |
| $\kappa$; $\kappa_{\mathcal{S}}$ | cost of one forward pass on a patch; cost of the backward pass of strategy $\mathcal{S}$ | 5.5 |
| *Strategies* | | |
| $\boldsymbol{W}_0$ | frozen pretrained weight adapted by LoRA | 3.3.1 |

| Symbol | Meaning | Sec. |
|---|---|---|
| $\boldsymbol{A}$, $\boldsymbol{B}$; $r$ | LoRA factors; rank | 3.3.1 |
| $d_{\text{in}}$; $d_{\text{out}}$ | input and output dimension of an adapted weight | 3.3.1 |
| $\alpha$; $\gamma_r$ | LoRA scaling hyperparameter; scaling factor $\gamma_r = \alpha/\sqrt{r}$ | 3.3.1 |
| $\mathcal{M}_t$; $\rho$; $M_{\max}$ | replay memory after task $t$; replay fraction; capacity of the memory | 5.4.3 |
| $\lambda$; $\mathcal{L}_{\text{KD}}$ | weight of the distillation loss; distillation loss | 3.3.3 |
| $\hat{\theta}_\nu$; $\nu$; $I_{\text{we}}$ | weight ensemble after $\nu$ updates; number of ensemble updates; interval between updates in iterations | 3.3.3 |
| $\boldsymbol{e}_g$ | $g$-th guidance vector of $\boldsymbol{E}_4$ | 5.4.4 |
| $\boldsymbol{f}_v$; $\Omega_4$ | stage-4 encoder feature at voxel $v$; voxels of stage 4 | 5.4.4 |
| $q_{g,v}$; $\bar{q}_{g,v}$ | distribution over $\Omega_4$ for guidance vector $g$ of the student; of the teacher | 5.4.4 |
| $\beta_t$; $\mathcal{C}_t$ | gradient scale of task (session) $t$ in prompt tuning; set of classes of session $t$ in CPE-CLIP | 3.3.4 |
| $\boldsymbol{V}_l$; $m$; $L_p$ | learned prompt tokens of prompt-decoder layer $l$; tokens per layer; number of prompted layers | 5.4.5 |
| $h_\psi$; $\psi$ | meta-net; its parameters | 5.4.5 |
| $\bar{\boldsymbol{f}}$ | mean of the projected stage-4 image features, input of the meta-net | 5.4.5 |
| *Evaluation* | | |
| $\text{DSC}(\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}}, \boldsymbol{Y})$ | Dice similarity coefficient | 3.4 |
| $a_{i,j}$ | entry of the evaluation matrix: mean DSC on task $i$ after stage $j$ | 3.2 |
| $c_j$ | mean DSC on the control task after stage $j$ | 3.4 |
| $N_{\text{boot}}$ | number of bootstrap draws | 6.1.4 |

# Chapter 1

# Introduction

## 1.1 Motivation

Medical image segmentation assigns every voxel of an image either to a structure, such as an organ or a tissue, or to the background. The voxels assigned to a structure form its mask. With the mask, properties of the structure, such as its volume, can be measured instead of only assessed visually. However, drawing masks by hand is laborious, because in a three-dimensional (3D) volume the structure has to be outlined on every slice in which it appears. Different readers also draw them differently [Des+21].

cite: segmentation for quantitative measurement

Automatic segmentation with deep learning has commonly meant training one model for each dataset and its target structures, for example with nnU-Net [Ise+21]. Universal segmentation models replace these per-dataset models with one network that segments many structures. For example, the developers of the universal model SAT compared it with 72 nnU-Nets, one trained on each of their datasets [Zha+25d]. The structure to segment is specified by an additional input, the prompt [Zha+25d; Rok+26]. The prompt can be spatial, such as a point or a box marked in the image [Ma+24; Che+23], or text that names the target (Section 2.1).

Text-promptable models differ in the text they accept. SAT is prompted with terms from a fixed vocabulary [Zha+25d]. In contrast, VoxTell accepts both a single anatomical term and a full clinical sentence [Rok+26]. We call models of this kind *free-text promptable*. In both models, the structure to segment is not tied to an output channel of the network. The same weights serve every structure, and the text prompt alone selects the target [Zha+25d, Sec. 4.5; Rok+26, Sec. 3] (Section 3.1.3).

This thesis adapts VoxTell, which was trained on more than 62,000 computed tomography (CT), magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) and positron emission tomography (PET) volumes. On datasets it was not trained on, it reached a mean Dice similarity coefficient (DSC) of 70.85 % [Rok+26, Table 1], where the DSC measures the overlap between the predicted and the reference mask. On knee MRI from the SKM-TEA dataset [Des+21], its mean DSC was 10.72 %, averaged over four cartilages and two menisci [Rok+26, Suppl. Table 9]. The VoxTell authors attribute this low value to the small share of knee images in the training data and to structures missing from it. As future work, they suggest adapting the model with a few labelled examples [Rok+26, Sec. 6].

Automatic segmentation of the knee cartilages and menisci is useful because quantitative biomarkers for osteoarthritis are measured within these structures [Des+21]. One example is the T2 relaxation time, which reflects the degeneration of collagen-rich tissue [Des+21]. These values can only be read out once the structures are outlined. The SKM-TEA authors name manual outlining as one obstacle to the use of quantitative MRI [Des+21].

Because manual annotation is laborious, VoxTell would have to learn the knee structures from a few labelled volumes. New structures may also become relevant over time, and the model would then have to adapt to each of them in turn [Qaz+26]. Retraining VoxTell from scratch on its full training data plus each new structure would largely preserve what it could segment before. However, training the published model took about six days on 64 NVIDIA A100 GPUs [Rok+26, p. 5].

cite: locator in Qazi et al. for new structures arriving over time; verify the survey supports this

## 1.2 Problem Statement

Instead of being retrained from scratch, the model can be adapted to one new structure at a time. We call the learning of one new structure, named by one text prompt, a *task*. Continual learning is the setting in which a model learns from a sequence of tasks, using the data of the current task and limited or no data of earlier tasks [De +22, Sec. 2]. After each task, the model has to segment the new structure while keeping both the structures learned earlier in the sequence and what it could segment before the first task, which we call its pretrained ability (Figure 1.1).

The simplest way to learn a task is to fine-tune the model on its data. However, training on later tasks can lower the performance on earlier ones, an effect known as catastrophic forgetting [De +22, Sec. 1]. For pretrained vision–language models, continual fine-tuning can also lower the zero-shot accuracy on data the model was not trained on [Zhe+23]. In our

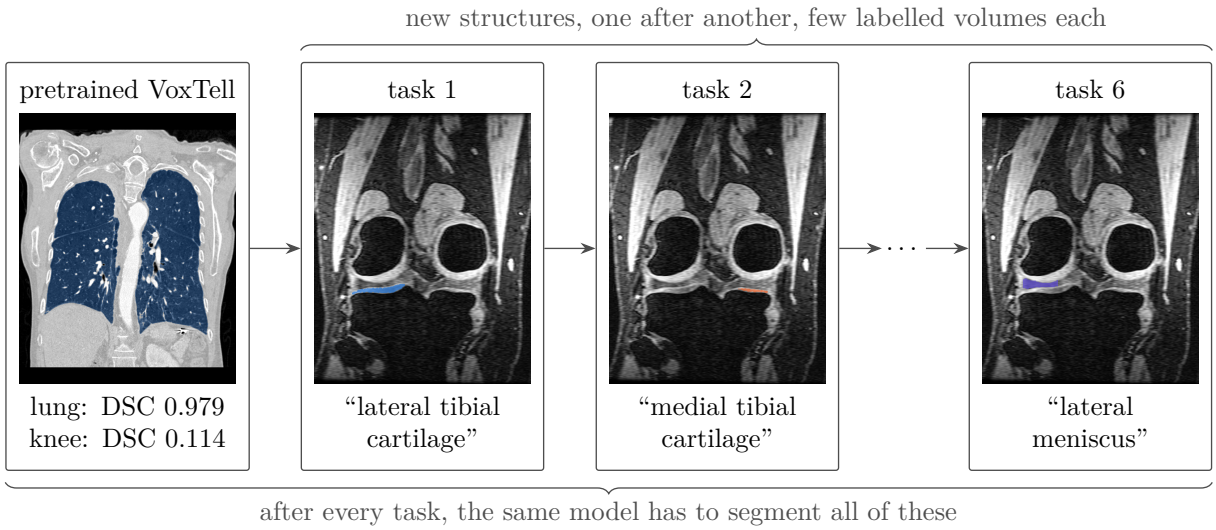



Figure 1.1: Setting of this thesis. The pretrained VoxTell segments the lung well but the knee structures poorly (DSC from our evaluation; for the knee, the mean over its six structures). It is then adapted to the six knee structures one after another, each named by a text prompt and learned from a few labelled volumes. Tasks 3 to 5 are not shown. After every task, the same model has to segment all of these structures, with the lung standing for its pretrained ability. Images: example volumes of Figure 4.2 with their reference masks.

setting, this corresponds to a loss of pretrained ability. The more the model is allowed to change, the better it can learn the new structure, but the more it may lose of what it knew. De Lange et al. call this conflict the stability–plasticity dilemma, with stability meaning the retention of previous knowledge and plasticity the integration of new knowledge [De+22, Sec. 1].

Few labelled volumes per task sharpen the stability–plasticity dilemma. With a fixed number of training epochs, fewer volumes mean far fewer updates, so the model has less opportunity to learn the new structure. Here, *few-shot* means training the model on $k$ labelled volumes per task, one shot being one labelled training volume.

Existing continual-learning results do not show how few labelled volumes shift the balance between stability and plasticity, because they were obtained in other settings. The methods for pretrained vision–language models reviewed in Section 2.3 were developed and evaluated on classification or on tasks with text output. In medical image segmentation, continual-learning methods have mostly given each new task or class components of its own, such as a decoder or an output head [Ji+23; Guo+25; Zha+23; Ye+25]. VoxTell needs no new output for a new structure, because the text prompt alone selects the target.

In our literature search, we found no work that adapts a pretrained free-text promptable 3D segmentation model to a sequence of new structures with few labelled volumes per task (Section 2.5). The closest works use a 2D model with full training sets [Gao26; Gao+26b; Gao+26a] or a 3D model without text prompts [Che+26b], and none of them measures how much of the pretrained ability is kept.

## 1.3 Research Question and Objectives

This thesis addresses the following research question:

> **How do different continual-learning strategies trade off adaptation performance and catastrophic forgetting when adapting free-text promptable universal 3D medical image segmentation models under few-shot conditions?**

By *adaptation performance* we mean how well the model segments a new structure right after it has been trained on it. We use *forgetting* for the loss on earlier tasks of the sequence as well as for the loss of pretrained ability. Few-shot conditions are $k = 5$, 10 and 20 labelled volumes per task, which we compare with the full training split of 108 volumes per task. With the training schedule of our experiments, a task with five volumes is trained with 50 updates, against 1,080 with the full training split, and further runs with five volumes and 1,080 updates separate the two (Section 6.1.2). Section 1.4 states which strategies were run with few volumes.

We pursue four objectives:

(1) Develop a few-shot continual-learning evaluation protocol for free-text promptable universal 3D medical image segmentation (Section 5.2).

(2) Compare continual-learning strategies under this protocol in terms of their adaptation and forgetting (Section 6.2).

(3) Investigate how the amount of labelled training data influences the evaluated strategies, separating the effect of fewer volumes from that of fewer updates (Section 6.5).

(4) Analyse how the task order, the LoRA rank (Section 1.4) and the components of the strategies, replay, the weight ensemble and gradient scaling, influence adaptation and forgetting (Sections 6.2, 6.3 and 6.6).

## 1.4 Approach and Scope

We study the research question with VoxTell [Rok+26] as the pretrained model and six structures of the SKM-TEA knee MRI dataset [Des+21] as tasks. The tasks are trained in two task orders, an original order chosen at random and its reverse, to see whether the results depend on the order. The lung in the chest CT volumes of AeroPath [Stø+23] serves as a control task. It is not trained on and is used only to measure how much of the pretrained ability is kept. After each task, the model is tested on all six tasks and on the control task (Section 5.2).

The baseline is sequential fine-tuning, which trains all parameters on each task without any continual-learning mechanism. Three strategies use low-rank adaptation (LoRA) [Hu+22], which keeps the pretrained weights frozen and trains a low-rank update of them, the adapter. Task-specific LoRA trains one adapter of rank $r = 4$ per task and selects it by the task identity at inference. Shared LoRA trains one adapter of rank $r = 1024$ for all tasks, and shared LoRA with replay adds a memory of training samples from earlier tasks. The distillation-based strategy (adapted from ZSCL [Zhe+23]) trains all parameters and distils the features of the frozen pretrained model into the adapted one. The prompt-tuning strategy (adapted from CPE-CLIP [DAl+23]) freezes the pretrained weights and trains learned prompt tokens. It also trains a network that shifts the encoded text prompt, our addition inspired by CoCoOp [Zho+22a]. Together, the strategies cover replay, regularisation and parameter-efficient adaptation, the three families of continual-learning methods for vision–language models [Liu+26b, Sec. 4]. All strategies except task-specific LoRA use one parameter set for all tasks (Section 5.4).

All strategies are trained with the full training split. Sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA and shared LoRA are also trained with $k = 5$, 10 and 20 volumes per task, with one draw of volumes for each $k$, and with $k = 5$ and the 1,080 updates per task of the full split (Section 6.1.2).

From the test results, we compute three primary metrics (Section 3.4). Adaptation is the DSC on each task right after training on it, averaged over the six tasks. Final Forgetting is the mean drop of the DSC on the earlier tasks from its best earlier value to its value after the last task. The control-task drop is the decrease of the DSC on the control task from the pretrained model to the model after the last task. Together, Final Forgetting and the control-task drop measure retention, the performance kept on earlier tasks and on the control task. We also report two secondary metrics. Final Performance is the mean DSC

defense: the research question names few-shot conditions, but the distillation-based and prompt-tuning

on all tasks after the last task, and Transfer is the mean DSC on each task before it is trained. The pretrained model is evaluated in the same way and serves as a reference.

The study uses one model, one dataset for the tasks, one control task, one fixed text prompt per structure and one draw of training volumes per $k$. Each configuration was trained once, so we estimate only the variability over the test volumes, using a bootstrap (Section 6.1.4). As an upper reference, joint fine-tuning trains one model on all six tasks at once, with the full training split and with each $k$ (Section 5.2). The conclusions are therefore limited to this setting (Section 7.3). Clinical deployment and studies with clinical users are outside the scope of this thesis, but we report the training cost of the strategies (Section 6.7).

## 1.5 Contributions

The contributions of this thesis are:

(1) An evaluation protocol for few-shot continual adaptation of a free-text promptable 3D segmentation model, which measures adaptation, forgetting within the task sequence and the loss of pretrained ability on a held-out control task, with the pretrained model and joint training as reference points (Sections 5.1 and 5.2).

(2) A systematic comparison of sequential fine-tuning and five strategies from the three families of continual learning for vision–language models, adapted to VoxTell (LoRA on the cross-attention of the prompt decoder, voxel-wise feature distillation, learned prompt tokens with a meta-net), under one shared training configuration, with the full training split and, for three of them, with 5, 10 and 20 labelled volumes per task (Sections 5.4, 6.2 and 6.5).

(3) An analysis of the factors that affect continual adaptation in this setting: the amount of labelled data separated from the number of updates, the task order, the LoRA rank and the components of the strategies (replay, weight ensemble, gradient scaling), together with a diagnosis of why task-specific LoRA failed on patellar cartilage (Sections 6.2 to 6.6).

Sequential fine-tuning, LoRA, replay, ZSCL and CPE-CLIP are existing methods. The work of this thesis is their application to VoxTell with the changes described in Section 5.4, the evaluation protocol and all experiments.

## 1.6 Thesis Outline

Chapter 2 reviews text-promptable medical image segmentation and few-shot adaptation of segmentation models, as well as continual learning for pretrained vision–language models and for medical image segmentation. It ends with the gap that this thesis addresses. Chapter 3 introduces VoxTell, the continual-learning problem in formal terms, the mechanisms behind the strategies and the evaluation metrics. Chapter 4 describes the SKM-TEA and AeroPath data, the tasks and the data splits. Chapter 5 defines the evaluation protocol, the adaptation of VoxTell to one task and the strategies with their complexity. Chapter 6 gives the experimental setup and the results. It compares the strategies and reports the experiments on the LoRA rank, the amount of labelled data, the task order and the strategy components, as well as the training cost. Chapter 7 discusses the results across the experiments, answers the research question and states the limitations, and Chapter 8 summarises the thesis. The appendix lists the training and test volumes (Section A.1) and gives the evaluation matrices of all runs (Section A.2).

# Chapter 2

# State of the Art

This thesis adapts a pretrained free-text promptable 3D segmentation model to a sequence of new target structures, each with few labelled volumes. The related work therefore comes from four areas: text-promptable medical image segmentation, few-shot adaptation of segmentation models, continual learning for pretrained vision–language models, and continual learning for medical image segmentation. The chapter reviews them in this order and closes with a summary of all reviewed works and the gap that this thesis addresses.

## 2.1 Text-Promptable Medical Image Segmentation

Promptable segmentation models differ in how the target is selected: either by a spatial prompt marked in the image or by a text prompt that names the target. MedSAM and SAM-Med2D, two 2D adaptations of the Segment Anything Model (SAM) [Kir+23] to medical images, take spatial prompts. MedSAM is prompted with bounding boxes [Ma+24], and SAM-Med2D with boxes, points and masks [Che+23]. SegVol, a 3D model for CT, accepts both kinds of prompt [Du+24]. Besides points and boxes, it takes category names, which it inserts into a fixed template and embeds with a frozen CLIP text encoder [Rad+21; Du+24]. It was first pretrained on about 96,000 CT volumes without using labels and then fine-tuned on about 6,000 labelled volumes covering more than 200 categories [Du+24].

In other work, the target class is fixed and text serves as additional information that compensates for scarce labels. LViT fuses radiologist-verified descriptions of lung infections with 2D chest X-rays and needs the text at inference as well [Li+24]. R-Super, in contrast, uses radiology reports only during training, as losses on the number, location and size of tumours for 3D CT segmentation [Bas+25].

Several text-promptable models select their target from a fixed vocabulary. The CLIP-Driven Universal Model feeds the CLIP embedding of a template such as "A computerized tomography of a [CLS]" to a controller that generates the output convolutions of each class [Liu+23a]. It was trained on 3,410 CT scans from 14 public datasets with 25 organs and 6 tumour types [Liu+23a]. SAT extends text prompting to CT, MRI and PET volumes: a text encoder trained on medical knowledge embeds terms from a vocabulary of 497 classes, and a query decoder matches them with the features of a 3D U-Net [Zha+25d]. Free-form input such as a radiology report has to be translated into this vocabulary by a separate language model first [Zha+25d]. On 72 datasets with 22,186 scans, SAT's larger variant, SAT-Pro, reached an average DSC of 78.81 % over all classes, which the authors report as comparable to the 80.54 % of 72 dataset-specific nnU-Nets [Zha+25d].

BiomedParse and MedSAM-3 also take text prompts, but they segment 2D images. BiomedParse was developed on about 1.1 million images from nine imaging modalities and outperformed MedSAM given oracle bounding boxes on its test set [Zha+25c]. Its authors note that cutting CT and MRI volumes into slices leaves their 3D context unused [Zha+25c]. On 3D data, SAT-Pro was better than BiomedParse on 29 of 30 categories, and the SAT authors attribute BiomedParse's false positives to its slice-wise design [Zha+25d]. MedSAM-3 fine-tunes SAM 3 [Car+26] on medical images paired with phrases of at most three words [Liu+26a]. On four 2D datasets, its DSC with text alone was much lower than with text and a bounding box [Liu+26a].

VoxTell, the model adapted in this thesis, accepts a text prompt that may be a single anatomical term or a full clinical sentence [Rok+26]. It was trained on more than 62,000 CT, MRI and PET volumes from 158 public datasets with 1,087 anatomical and pathological concepts [Rok+26, p. 4]. Unlike SAT, it fuses the text with the image features at every decoder resolution [Rok+26, p. 4] (Section 3.1.3). On eleven datasets that were not used for training, its mean zero-shot DSC was 70.85 %, against 51.23 % for SAT, but on the knee MRI of SKM-TEA [Des+21] it reached only 10.72 % [Rok+26].

The VoxTell authors report robustness to synonyms, rephrasings and typos [Rok+26]. SEER measured how five text-promptable models, four of them 3D, respond to free-text requests that a language model generated in eight clinical styles [Zha+26]. Among these models, VoxTell kept the highest DSC under free-text requests, on average and in the worst case, whereas SAT failed almost completely on the pelvic-bone dataset PENGWIN [Zha+26]. Even for VoxTell, the worst rephrasing lowered the DSC on PENGWIN from 97.59 % with the class-name prompt to 79.34 % [Zha+26].

## 2.2 Few-Shot Adaptation of Segmentation Models

Each task in this thesis comes with only a few labelled training volumes, so this section reviews how pretrained models have been adapted to a single target with few labels. In the review by Dissanayake et al., a few-shot model has to segment a new class from one or a few labelled examples, and it can do so in two ways [Dis+25, Sec. 2.2]. In the first, the model receives the labelled examples as input together with the image to segment, so a new class often needs no change to its weights [Dis+25, Sec. 2.2, 2.2.1]. UniverSeg is an example of this approach for 2D medical images [But+23]. In the second, the weights of a trained model are updated on the labelled examples, for instance by fine-tuning [Dis+25, Sec. 2.2]. This thesis follows the second approach: a pretrained model is fine-tuned on a few labelled volumes of each task, and one labelled training volume counts as one shot (Section 5.1).

Silva-Rodríguez et al. fine-tuned a Swin UNETR, pretrained on partially labelled CT scans, to one organ of TotalSegmentator at a time with 1, 5 or 10 labelled volumes [Sil+25]. This range overlaps with the 5, 10 and 20 labelled volumes per task used in this thesis (Section 6.1.2). On nine organs that were already among the pretraining classes, LoRA [Hu+22] in the encoder and full fine-tuning differed by less than one point of mean DSC at 5 and 10 shots, and only LoRA improved from 5 to 10 shots [Sil+25]. On 16 structures that were new to the model, parameter-efficient methods in the encoder alone reached at most 40.46 % at 10 shots, far below full fine-tuning (52.38 %) and fine-tuning the decoder together with LoRA in the encoder (57.39 %) [Sil+25]. SEA-PEFT uses the same pretrained model and organs and selects the type, position and rank of the adapters automatically during training [Ly+26].

For vision–language models, CLIP-LoRA adds rank-2 LoRA modules to the query, key and value projections of every layer of both CLIP encoders [Zan+24]. It uses one set of hyperparameters for eleven 2D image classification datasets with 1 to 16 shots per class [Zan+24]. With a ViT-B/16 image encoder, its average top-1 accuracy was the best of the compared methods at every number of shots, for example 72.5 % against 70.9 % at one shot [Zan+24]. In the authors' ablation, the value or output projection was the best single matrix to adapt, and adapting more matrices or using a higher rank could lower the accuracy [Zan+24]. The authors note that choosing the adapted matrices and the rank is difficult [Zan+24], and we examine the rank in our setting in Section 6.3. Our LoRA layers are adapted from the CLIP-LoRA code. Like CLIP-LoRA, we apply LoRA to attention projections, but only to the query and value projections of the cross-attention in the prompt decoder of VoxTell (Section 5.4.2).

The works above adapt a model to one target at a time, each time starting from the same pretrained weights. The two 3D studies evaluate the adapted model only on that target, so they do not show how much of its earlier ability the model loses through the adaptation [Sil+25; Ly+26]. In this thesis, the same model is trained on the tasks one after another, so each adaptation can also affect the tasks trained before it. Among the works found in our search (Section 2.5), only Chen et al. adapt a pretrained 3D medical model to a sequence of tasks with few labelled examples each, one of them a segmentation task [Che+26b] (Section 2.4.2).

## 2.3 Continual Learning for Pretrained Vision–Language Models

Continual-learning settings are commonly divided into three scenarios by what information the model receives at inference and what it must infer [vdVen+25]. In task-incremental learning, the task identity of each input is given at inference. A model can then give each task its own parameters and avoid forgetting altogether, so the open question in this scenario is how much the tasks can share [vdVen+25]. In domain-incremental learning, the set of possible outputs stays the same from task to task, while the input data changes [vdVen+25]. The model does not receive the domain identity of an input [vdVen+25]. In class-incremental learning, the model must distinguish all classes seen so far, including classes from different tasks that it never saw together in training [vdVen+25]. In a sequence of tasks, this also means inferring the task [vdVen+25]. Our setting is closest to task-incremental learning, because the text prompt specifies the target of every input at inference (Section 3.2).

De Lange et al. sort continual-learning methods into three families by the way they keep information about earlier tasks [De +22, Sec. 3]. Replay methods reuse stored or generated samples of earlier tasks while learning a new one [De +22, Sec. 3.1]. Regularisation methods add a loss term, either distillation from an earlier model or a penalty on changes to important parameters [De +22, Sec. 3.2]. Parameter-isolation methods assign different parameters to different tasks, which typically requires the task identity at prediction time [De +22, Sec. 3.3]. For vision–language models, Liu et al. refine these families into multimodal replay, cross-modal regularisation and parameter-efficient adaptation, and note that many methods combine them [Liu+26b, Sec. 4]. The following subsections follow these three families, and we assign the works that the survey does not list to a family ourselves.

Three evaluation ideas from this literature are used in this thesis. Chaudhry et al. separate forgetting from intransigence [Cha+18]. Forgetting is the drop in accuracy on a task after it has been learned [Cha+18]. Intransigence is the gap between the accuracy on a task right after training on it and that of a reference model trained on all data so far [Cha+18]. ZSCL showed that continual fine-tuning of CLIP [Rad+21] also lowers its zero-shot accuracy on datasets that it has not yet been trained on [Zhe+23]. Its benchmark trains eleven classification datasets as tasks, in two task orders called Order I and Order II [Zhe+23]. On this benchmark, ZSCL reports two metrics [Zhe+23]. Transfer is the mean accuracy on each task before the task is trained, and Last accuracy is the mean accuracy on all tasks after the last one [Zhe+23]. SPU measures the loss of pretrained knowledge on a control set [Zha+24]. It compares the zero-shot accuracy of the adapted model on the ImageNet validation set with that of the frozen pretrained model [Zha+24]. Section 3.4 defines the metrics that this thesis derives from these ideas.

### 2.3.1 Multimodal Replay

The two replay methods reviewed here avoid storing real images by generating the replayed data. GIFT fine-tunes all parameters of CLIP on each task together with 1,000 images that Stable Diffusion generates from class names of earlier tasks and of ImageNet [Wu+25]. On these images, it distils the image–text similarities of the model from before the task [Wu+25]. On the ZSCL benchmark (Order I), it reached a Transfer of 69.3 % and a Last accuracy of 86.0 %, against 68.1 and 83.6 % for ZSCL and a zero-shot Transfer of 69.4 % for CLIP [Wu+25]. CGIL keeps both CLIP encoders frozen, stores a small generator of visual embeddings per class, and uses generated embeddings to train class-specific learned prompt tokens on the text side [Fra+24]. Its mean final accuracy over five class-incremental benchmarks, one of them the skin-lesion dataset ISIC, was 86.20 %, close to the 86.29 % of prompt tuning on all tasks jointly, but its memory grows with the number of classes [Fra+24].

### 2.3.2 Cross-Modal Regularisation

ZSCL fine-tunes all parameters of CLIP and distils the image–text similarity distributions of the frozen initial model on a reference dataset, by default 100,000 ImageNet images [Zhe+23]. It also averages the weights during training and penalises their distance to a reference set of parameters [Zhe+23]. On its benchmark (Order I), this raised Transfer from 44.6 %

for sequential fine-tuning to 68.1 %, close to the 69.4 % of the zero-shot model, and Last accuracy from 77.3 to 83.6 % [Zhe+23]. In the authors' ablation, distilling on the images of the current task instead of a reference dataset kept Transfer at the same level (56.7 against 56.8 %) but lowered Last accuracy from 83.0 to 80.2 % [Zhe+23]. The authors name the need for a reference dataset as the limitation of ZSCL [Zhe+23]. The distillation-based strategy of this thesis is adapted from ZSCL (Section 5.4.4).

RAPF keeps both encoders frozen and trains a single linear adapter on the image features [Hua+24]. It replays features of old classes, sampled from stored Gaussian distributions [Hua+24]. When the text feature of a new class lies close to that of an old class, RAPF pushes the replayed features of the old class away from the text feature of the new class [Hua+24]. It merges the adapter weights of successive tasks so that their number does not grow [Hua+24]. On ImageNet with 100 new classes per step, its final accuracy was 72.58 % against 69.79 % for DualPrompt [Hua+24]. Since RAPF trains only an adapter, it could also count as parameter-efficient adaptation. We follow Liu et al., who place it under cross-modal regularisation, the family of methods in which text features guide the training of the visual side [Liu+26b, Sec. 4.2].

PRIMED transfers the distillation on reference data of ZSCL to medical 2D image classification with BiomedCLIP [Che+26c]. It was evaluated on two task sequences that include X-ray, pathology, fundus, skin, cell and endoscopy images, with the task identity given at inference [Che+26c]. Instead of a fixed reference dataset, it retrieves image–caption pairs related to the tasks from 18 million PubMed figures and distils on them [Che+26c]. On its nine-dataset sequence (Order I), it reached a Transfer of 58.3 % and a Last accuracy of 82.1 %, against 57.7 and 77.6 % for ZSCL [Che+26c]. Unlike ZSCL, PRIMED distils from the model of the previous task, and in its ablation this teacher gave a higher Last accuracy than the initial model as teacher (82.1 against 78.2 %) [Che+26c].

### 2.3.3 Parameter-Efficient Adaptation

Parameter-efficient methods freeze most of the pretrained model and train a small set of added parameters [Liu+26b, Sec. 4.3]. Liu et al. note that tasks sharing the low-rank space of one LoRA (Section 3.3.1) can still interfere [Liu+26b, Sec. 4.3]. Some methods therefore keep the updates of new tasks orthogonal to the subspaces of earlier tasks [Liu+26b, Sec. 4.3]. LiLoRA, for continual instruction tuning of the multimodal language model LLaVA, shares one LoRA factor across tasks and splits the other into a shared and a task-specific part [Che+26a]. In its Single-type setting, one LoRA trained sequentially

on all tasks reached an average accuracy of only 46.21 %, against 88.13 % for a separate LoRA per task [Che+26a]. The backward transfer of the sequentially trained LoRA, the mean change in accuracy on earlier tasks between training on them and the end of the sequence, was −48.10 [Che+26a]. LiLoRA reached 84.88 % with less than half the added parameters of the separate LoRAs [Che+26a]. MSLoRA-CR adds a LoRA branch per task to the frozen medical model LLaVA-Med and sums all branches learned so far [Zha+25a]. It was evaluated on 2D question answering, classification and report generation, with the task identity given at inference [Zha+25a]. Its summed score over all task metrics was 995.21, against 970.29 for data-specific fine-tuning with a separate LoRA [Zha+25a]. A separate LoRA per task and one LoRA shared by all tasks are the two LoRA strategies compared in this thesis (Section 5.4.2).

Other methods train learned prompt tokens, which are vectors added to the input of a frozen model. S-Prompts learns separate prompt tokens for each domain and selects them at inference through the nearest of the image-feature centroids stored per domain [Wan+22]. On the deepfake-detection benchmark CDDB-Hard, it reached an average accuracy of 88.65 %, against 61.28 % for L2P, and still 80.12 % when the domain was chosen at random [Wan+22]. Its authors report that the approach does not carry over well to class-incremental learning [Wan+22]. CoLeCLIP learns one prompt token per task in the frozen image encoder and keeps a single vocabulary of class text embeddings for all tasks [Li+25]. In its open-domain class-incremental setting (ODCL-CIL), without task identity, its Last accuracy on the ZSCL benchmark (Order I) was 79.95 % against 77.38 % for ZSCL, with 0.13 million instead of 149.62 million trained parameters [Li+25]. In the task-incremental setting (ODCL-TIL), its Transfer of 69.04 % stayed close to the 69.27 % of zero-shot CLIP [Li+25].

CPE-CLIP targets few-shot class-incremental learning, in which a base session is followed by sessions with five examples per new class [DAl+23]. It learns prompt tokens in both CLIP encoders, couples them through a learned projection and scales their gradients down as more classes have been seen, training about 400,000 parameters [DAl+23]. On CIFAR100, its average accuracy over the sessions was 83.42 %, against 70.58 % for zero-shot CLIP [DAl+23]. In its ablation on CUB200, removing the gradient scaling lowered the accuracy more than removing any other component [DAl+23, Sec. 5.5, Fig. 2]. The prompt-tuning strategy of this thesis is adapted from CPE-CLIP (Section 5.4.5).

MoE-Adapters adds a mixture of 22 LoRA experts to every block of a frozen CLIP, with one router per task, and freezes the most used experts after each task [Yu+24]. At inference, one autoencoder per task selects the router, and inputs that fit no task go to the

frozen CLIP [Yu+24]. On the ZSCL benchmark (Order I), it reached a Transfer of 68.9 % and a Last accuracy of 85.0 %, and in a 5-shot variant of the benchmark a Last accuracy of 76.1 % [Yu+24]. The selection step is a source of error in itself: the authors observed samples of the ninth task that the selector wrongly classed as fitting no task, and expect the single selection threshold to cause more errors as the number of tasks grows [Yu+24].

All methods reviewed in this section are evaluated on image classification or on tasks with text output; none of them predicts a segmentation mask.

## 2.4 Continual Learning for Medical Image Segmentation

In continual segmentation, the masks of one task may label as background a structure that another task labels as foreground [Cer+20]. In the multi-organ CT sequences of Liu et al., for example, the liver is foreground in the first dataset and background in the later ones [Liu+22b]. Since a CT or MRI volume usually shows a whole anatomical region, we expect most scans in such a sequence to contain structures that their masks leave unlabelled. In our setting the conflict does not reach the output, because the masks of each task label one structure and VoxTell predicts one binary mask per text prompt (Section 3.1.3). Section 2.4.1 reviews networks trained for the tasks, Section 2.4.2 the adaptation of pretrained segmentation foundation models, and Section 2.4.3 continual learning of text-promptable segmentation models.

### 2.4.1 Networks Trained for the Tasks

Early work applied regularisation, including distillation, to segmentation. Baweja et al. trained a 3D network on brain MRI from UK Biobank [Mil+16a], first on three tissue classes and then on white-matter lesions [Baw+18]. Plain fine-tuning lowered the DSC of cerebrospinal fluid from the first task to 0.9 % [Baw+18]. With EWC [Kir+17], the first-task classes kept 79.2 to 94.4 %, but the lesion DSC fell to 44.5 %, against 63.8 % for joint training on both tasks [Baw+18]. Ozdemir et al. distilled the predictions of the previous model and added a small set of selected stored examples [Ozd+18]. On nine shoulder MRI volumes, the stored examples raised the DSC of the old class from 66.0 to 94.8 % compared with distillation alone when the new data came from a different MR sequence [Ozd+18]. Two methods from natural-image segmentation are frequent baselines: ILT distils the output

and the encoder features of the previous model [Mic+19], and MiB counts the background of a new task as possibly containing old classes [Cer+20]. Liu et al. used a marginal loss for partially labelled multi-organ CT [Liu+22b] and complementary pseudo-labels for structures added one after another in 2D brain-tumour MRI [Liu+23b].

Replay methods for segmentation either store selected parts of earlier data or generate the replayed data. Bera et al. keep crops around the target instead of full volumes and select them by the fraction of target voxels and by training difficulty [Ber+23]. On a sequence of prostate, spleen and hippocampus segmentation, twelve such crops gave an average DSC of $83.3 \pm 1.3\,\%$, against $78.3 \pm 1.3\,\%$ for three randomly chosen full volumes [Ber+23]. SegGAN generates image–mask pairs of 2D abdominal CT slices for earlier classes and keeps only pairs whose generated mask agrees with the model's prediction [Liu+22a]. On the 8-2 class split of BTCV, its mean DSC was 0.4930, against 0.3840 for MiB with a Dice loss and 0.7219 for joint training [Liu+22a]. C$^2$GR trains a universal segmentation network from scratch on 20 tasks from eight modalities, all as 2D images or slices, and replays image–mask pairs generated by a diffusion model [Li+26]. Each task is specified by a fixed text template that names the modality, the region and the target [Li+26]. After the last task, the mean DSC over all tasks was $83.62\,\%$, against $86.06\,\%$ for joint training and $25.23\,\%$ for sequential fine-tuning [Li+26].

Parameter-isolation methods keep separate parts of the model for different tasks or structures. González et al. save one nnU-Net per stage, each fine-tuned from the previous one, and select a model at test time with one autoencoder per stage [Gon+25]. On prostate MRI from five sites, the mean DSC was $87.0 \pm 6.5\,\%$ with this selection and $89.6 \pm 2.0\,\%$ with the true domain [Gon+25]. Continual Segment freezes an encoder trained on TotalSegmentator, adds one pruned decoder per later dataset and merges the outputs of all decoders [Ji+23]. On 143 structures from four CT datasets, its mean DSC was $88.74\,\%$, against $89.02\,\%$ for four separately trained nnU-Nets [Ji+23]. Its extension CL-Net adds decoders for new anatomies and updates existing decoders by a moving average when an anatomy reappears [Guo+25]. On 235 anatomies from 36 datasets learned in sequence, CL-Net reached a mean DSC of $85.7\,\%$, against $83.9\,\%$ for an ensemble of dataset-specific nnU-Nets [Guo+25]. A low-rank mixture-of-experts method adds one LoRA expert per dataset to a frozen transformer and chooses the expert either with a classifier on CLIP image features or with a gate driven by the CLIP embedding of a dataset description [Che+24]. After BTCV and LiTS, the mean DSC on the BTCV organs was $80.6\,\%$, against $78.5\,\%$ for the method of Zhang et al. in the authors' own comparison [Che+24].

Zhang et al. condition a continual segmentation model on language [Zha+23], and Liu et al. report the same benchmark with identical results in a journal extension of the CLIP-Driven Universal Model [Liu+24]. A Swin UNETR is followed by one head per class, whose weights an MLP generates from the pooled image features and a fixed CLIP embedding of the template "A computerized tomography of a [CLS]" [Zha+23; Liu+24]. For earlier classes, the predictions of the previous model serve as pseudo-labels [Zha+23; Liu+24]. After learning 13 BTCV organs and then the LiTS liver tumour, the mean DSC was 0.817 on the organs and 0.466 on the tumour, against 0.799 and 0.362 for PLOP [Dou+21], as reported by Zhang et al. [Zha+23]. The class names have to be known in advance, and each new class needs its own head [Zha+23; Liu+24].

Three studies compare strategies on the same data. Lifelong nnU-Net trains an nnU-Net through sequences of hippocampus, prostate and cardiac MRI datasets [Gon+23]. Rehearsal forgot least, whereas EWC and MiB kept old tasks at the cost of the new ones [Gon+23]. On the last hippocampus dataset, for example, they reached a DSC of 31.93 and 20.75 %, against 90.92 % for sequential training [Gon+23]. The authors also found the results to depend on the task order and recommend comparing methods over several orders [Gon+23]. Ranem et al. found that a U-Net with a vision transformer forgot less than nnU-Net in plain sequential training on hippocampus MRI, but not consistently once continual-learning methods were added [Ran+22]. The Beyond Forgetting benchmark covers new domains, new structures in the same images and new organs in new images, with 2D slices [Wan+26a]. It reports plasticity and forward transfer besides forgetting and finds, for the new-domain sequences, that the task order affects the results [Wan+26a]. In its conclusions, no single strategy met every requirement [Wan+26a]. Replay gave the best trade-off between keeping old tasks and learning new ones, and parameter isolation avoided forgetting but let the model grow [Wan+26a].

### 2.4.2 Pretrained Segmentation Foundation Models

Several methods add knowledge to SAM-based models, which are prompted with points or boxes. SAM-Med3D-MoE fine-tunes a copy of the mask decoder of SAM-Med3D separately for each downstream task or weak category, not in a sequence [Wan+24]. A gate picks the best-matching expert, whose mask is blended with that of the original decoder, or keeps the original decoder alone when the gate score is low [Wan+24]. With box prompts, the mean DSC on 15 weak categories rose from 0.532 to 0.564, whereas on the other categories it fell from 0.541 to 0.400 [Wan+24]. CA-SAM inserts one small alignment network per dataset

between the frozen image encoder and the mask decoder of SAM [Wan+26b]. It chooses the network with one variational autoencoder per task and falls back to the frozen SAM for unfamiliar inputs [Wan+26b]. On nine 2D datasets learned in sequence, its final mean intersection over union (IoU) was 76.12 %, against 78.43 % for joint training and 53.81 % for zero-shot SAM [Wan+26b]. RegCL keeps a single adapter in the image encoder of SAM and merges the adapter of each new domain into it in closed form [Shu+26]. On five 2D domains, two of them medical, its mean IoU after the last domain was 0.775, against 0.820 for a separate adapter per domain [Shu+26]. Outside SAM, CLoPA adapts the normalisation and a few convolution parameters of the 3D interactive model nnInteractive repeatedly as annotations of one task accumulate, without a sequence of tasks [Esm+26].

Two works adapt pretrained 3D models without spatial prompts. MedSeqFT fine-tunes a self-supervised CT model through five segmentation tasks in sequence, with a new head per task [Ye+25]. It adds distillation on stored samples, which are chosen by their pretraining loss, and a LoRA-based refinement that is merged into the weights [Ye+25]. Its mean DSC over the five tasks was 68.3 %, against 65.3 % for fine-tuning a separate copy of the pretrained model per task [Ye+25]. The paper reports no results on earlier tasks after later ones and no measure of forgetting [Ye+25]. Chen et al. freeze a 3D brain-MRI foundation model and train one LoRA module and one head per task, selected by the task identity at inference [Che+26b]. The two tasks, tumour segmentation and brain-age regression, each have 16 or 32 labelled samples [Che+26b]. With 32 samples, the tumour DSC of this design was $0.60 \pm 0.08$ and unaffected by the second task, whereas sequential fine-tuning reached $0.80 \pm 0.02$ and fell to $0.16 \pm 0.19$ after the second task [Che+26b].

Most of the parameter-isolation and foundation-model methods above hold what is added for a task in components of its own, reached through the task identity, through a learned selector or by merging the outputs of all components. RegCL and CLoPA instead change shared parameters, as do MedSeqFT apart from its task heads and the regularisation and replay methods of Section 2.4.1.

### 2.4.3 Continual Learning of Text-Promptable Segmentation Models

Three recent works by Gao and colleagues are the closest to this thesis: they train a text-promptable segmentation model on a sequence of medical segmentation tasks [Gao26; Gao+26b; Gao+26a]. All three use the 2D model CLIPSeg, treat each dataset or dataset subset as a task, mix endoscopy, dermoscopy, ultrasound and X-ray images, and train on the

full training sets [Gao26; Gao+26b; Gao+26a]. MedCRP-CL and MedPEFT-CL take their text prompts from earlier work on medical vision–language segmentation, which includes descriptive sentences per image [Gao26; Gao+26a]. PA-EWC uses templated phrases that range from class names to combinations of visual, spatial and medical descriptions [Gao+26b].

MedCRP-CL clusters the tasks by the CLIP embeddings of their text prompts and trains one LoRA module per cluster, with EWC within each cluster [Gao26]. On 16 tasks, its mean DSC after the sequence was 73.3 % with 4.1 % forgetting, against 65.3 and 7.1 % for MoE-Adapters and 48.0 and 28.3 % for sequential fine-tuning [Gao26]. PA-EWC weights the EWC penalty of different parameter groups by the complexity of the text prompts [Gao+26b]. On five tasks, it reports a higher mean DSC and less forgetting than ZSCL and MoE-Adapters, although the averages in its summary table do not match its per-task results [Gao+26b]. MedPEFT-CL adds LoRA to both CLIPSeg encoders, reuses the adapter of an earlier task when the text embeddings of the two tasks are similar, and replays the hardest 15 % of each task's training samples [Gao+26a]. On a sequence of ten tasks, its mean DSC was 78.19 %, against 74.15 % for MoE-Adapters and 81.02 % for one model per task [Gao+26a].

For MedCRP-CL and MedPEFT-CL, the papers describe how an adapter is assigned to a task during training but not which adapter is used at test time [Gao26; Gao+26a]. None of the three evaluates the model on data outside the task sequence after training, so the loss of the pretrained model's ability is not measured [Gao26; Gao+26b; Gao+26a].

## 2.5 Summary and Research Gap

Table 2.1 summarises the data, approach and best reported result of the works reviewed in this chapter. Text-promptable 3D models such as SAT and VoxTell segment many structures from a text prompt, but they are trained once, and VoxTell's zero-shot DSC of 10.72 % on the knee MRI of SKM-TEA shows that its generalisation does not cover every body region (Section 2.1). Few-shot fine-tuning adapts 3D segmentation models to one new target with a handful of labelled volumes, but evaluates only that target (Section 2.2). Continual-learning methods for pretrained vision–language models protect the pretrained representation while tasks are added, but they were evaluated on classification or on tasks with text output (Section 2.3). Continual learning for medical image segmentation handles dense prediction, but among its works only Chen et al. adapt with few labelled samples, and those conditioned on text are either 2D or limited to a fixed set of class names (Section 2.4).

In our search[1] we found no work that adapts a pretrained free-text promptable 3D segmentation model to a sequence of new structures with few labelled volumes per task. The closest works each lack part of this setting: MedCRP-CL, PA-EWC and MedPEFT-CL adapt the 2D model CLIPSeg with full training sets (Section 2.4.3), and Chen et al. adapt a 3D model with few samples but without text prompts and with the task identity given at inference (Section 2.4.2). None of these four works measures how much of the pretrained model's ability outside the task sequence is kept at the end of the sequence. The setting matters in practice when a universal model has to learn structures that it handles poorly from a few annotated volumes each, adding them one after another as annotations become available, without losing what it could do before.

This thesis does not propose a new method. It adapts existing continual-learning strategies to VoxTell and compares them on six target structures of the SKM-TEA knee MRI dataset, measuring adaptation, forgetting within the sequence and the loss of pretrained ability on a control task (Section 5.2). All strategies are compared with the full training data, and sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA and shared LoRA also with 5, 10 and 20 labelled volumes per task and with 5 volumes and the number of updates of the full data; joint fine-tuning on all tasks at once serves as the upper reference. The strategies are chosen to cover the three families of Section 2.3, and all except task-specific LoRA use one parameter set for all tasks (Section 5.4). Table 2.2 contrasts this setting with the closest works.

Table 2.1: Works reviewed in this chapter, grouped by section. Works cited only for a definition, a mechanism or a single finding are not listed. Results are given as reported by the authors, in the paper's metric, with the main comparison in parentheses; settings are named in the paper's own terms. FT: fine-tuning; seq.: sequential; TIL, DIL, CIL: task-, domain- and class-incremental learning; MTIL: the eleven-dataset benchmark of ZSCL; ODCL-CIL, ODCL-TIL: open-domain class- and task-incremental learning; CSS: continual semantic segmentation; FSCIL: few-shot class-incremental learning.

| Work | Data | Approach and setting | Metric: best reported result |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Text-promptable medical image segmentation (Section 2.1)* | | | |
| SegVol [Du+24] | 25 CT datasets; 3D | Points, boxes, class names in a template; not continual | Median DSC, AMOS22: 0.8593, box + text (SAM-Med2D 0.6668) |

*continued on next page*

[1] Keyword queries in OpenAlex, PubMed and arXiv and a search of the works citing VoxTell and SAT, run on 23 October 2026; of 461 hits, 66 were screened by title or abstract.

Table 2.1 (continued)

| Work | Data | Approach and setting | Metric: best reported result |
|---|---|---|---|
| LViT [Li+24] | QaTa-COV19, MosMedData+; 2D | Text descriptions, also at inference; not continual | DSC, QaTa-COV19: 83.66 %, all labels |
| R-Super [Bas+25] | AbdomenAtlas, private CT with reports; 3D | Reports as training losses only, 50 to 1.7K masks; not continual | F1, pancreatic tumour detection: +16.0 points, 344 masks |
| CLIP-Driven Universal Model [Liu+23a] | 14 CT datasets; 3D | Fixed class names in a CLIP template; not continual | DSC, BTCV: 86.13 % (Swin UNETR 82.06 %) |
| SAT [Zha+25d] | 72 CT, MRI, PET datasets; 3D | Terms from a fixed vocabulary; not continual | Mean DSC, all classes: 78.81 % (72 nnU-Nets 80.54 %) |
| BiomedParse [Zha+25c] | 45 datasets, 9 modalities; 2D | Templated object-type prompts; not continual | DSC above MedSAM with oracle boxes |
| MedSAM-3 [Liu+26a] | BUSI, RIM-ONE, ISIC 2018, Kvasir-SEG; 2D | Phrases of up to three words, optionally with a box; not continual | DSC: 0.7772–0.9058 text + box; 0.0826–0.5687 text only |
| VoxTell [Rok+26] | >62,000 CT, MRI, PET volumes; 3D | Free text; not continual | Mean zero-shot DSC, 11 unseen datasets: 70.85 % (SAT 51.23 %); SKM-TEA 10.72 % |
| *Few-shot adaptation of segmentation models (Section 2.2)* | | | |
| Dissanayake et al. [Dis+25] | About 90 articles reviewed | Segmentation of unseen classes from a few examples; one-shot re-runs on abdominal CT | No single best method |
| UniverSeg [But+23] | MegaMedical, 53 datasets; 2D | Labelled example images as input, no weight updates | Mean DSC, held-out datasets: 71.8 % (nnU-Nets 84.4 %) |
| Silva-Rodríguez et al. [Sil+25] | TotalSegmentator, FLARE'22; 3D | Parameter-efficient vs. full FT; one target at a time; 1, 5, 10 (30) volumes | Mean DSC, 9 organs, 10 shots: 77.79 %, LoRA (full FT 76.93 %) |
| SEA-PEFT [Ly+26] | TotalSegmentator, FLARE'22; 3D | Adapters chosen during training; one target at a time; 1, 5, 10 volumes | Mean DSC, 9 organs, 10 shots: 80.29 % |
| CLIP-LoRA [Zan+24] | 11 classification datasets; 2D | Rank-2 LoRA in both CLIP encoders; 1–16 shots per class; not continual | Top-1 accuracy, mean: 72.5 % (1 shot), 83.0 % (16 shots) |
| *Continual learning for pretrained vision–language models (Section 2.3)* | | | |
| GIFT [Wu+25] | MTIL; 2D | Replay of generated images, full FT; MTIL, CIL | Transfer / Last, Order I: 69.3 / 86.0 % (ZSCL 68.1 / 83.6 %) |

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Table 2.1 (continued)

| Work | Data | Approach and setting | Metric: best reported result |
|---|---|---|---|
| CGIL [Fra+24] | Five benchmarks incl. ISIC; 2D | Generated visual embeddings, frozen encoders; CIL | Final accuracy, mean: 86.20 % (joint prompt tuning 86.29 %) |
| ZSCL [Zhe+23] | MTIL; 2D | Distillation on reference data, weight averaging, full FT; MTIL | Transfer / Last, Order I: 68.1 / 83.6 % (seq. FT 44.6 / 77.3 %) |
| RAPF [Hua+24] | CIFAR100, ImageNet, ImageNet-R, CUB200; 2D | Linear adapter, text-guided feature replay, adapter fusion; CIL | Last, ImageNet, 100 classes per step: 72.58 % (DualPrompt 69.79 %) |
| PRIMED [Che+26c] | HieraMedTransfer, MedXtreme; 2D | Distillation on retrieved image–caption pairs; TIL, DIL | Transfer / Last, Order I: 58.3 / 82.1 % (ZSCL 57.7 / 77.6 %) |
| LiLoRA [Che+26a] | CVIT benchmark; 2D | Shared and task-specific LoRA parts; continual instruction tuning | Average accuracy, Single-type: 84.88 % (separate LoRAs 88.13 %, seq. LoRA 46.21 %) |
| MSLoRA-CR [Zha+25a] | Nine medical datasets; 2D | One LoRA per task, branches summed; TIL | Sum of task metrics: 995.21 (separate LoRAs 970.29) |
| S-Prompts [Wan+22] | CDDB-Hard, CORe50, DomainNet; 2D | Prompt tokens per domain, chosen by nearest centroid; DIL | Average accuracy, CDDB-Hard: 88.65 % (L2P 61.28 %) |
| CoLeCLIP [Li+25] | MTIL; 2D | Prompt token per task, shared class vocabulary; ODCL-CIL, ODCL-TIL | Last, ODCL-CIL, Order I: 79.95 % (ZSCL 77.38 %) |
| CPE-CLIP [DAl+23] | CIFAR100, miniImageNet, CUB200; 2D | Prompt tokens in both encoders, gradient scaling; FSCIL | Average accuracy, CIFAR100: 83.42 % (zero-shot 70.58 %) |
| MoE-Adapters [Yu+24] | MTIL, CIFAR100, TinyImageNet; 2D | LoRA experts with routers, autoencoder selector; MTIL, CIL | Transfer / Last, Order I: 68.9 / 85.0 % (ZSCL 68.1 / 83.6 %) |
| *Continual learning for medical image segmentation (Section 2.4)* | | | |
| Baweja et al. [Baw+18] | UK Biobank brain MRI; 3D | EWC; two tasks | DSC: Lesions 44.5 % (joint 63.8 %) |
| Bera et al. [Ber+23] | Prostate, spleen, hippocampus datasets; 3D | Replay of selected crops; DIL, "task incremental" | Average DSC, three organs: 83.3 ± 1.3 % (random replay 78.3 ± 1.3 %) |
| SegGAN [Liu+22a] | BTCV slices; 2D | Generative replay of image–mask pairs; class-incremental | Mean DSC, 8-2 split: 0.4930 (MiB + Dice 0.3840, joint 0.7219) |

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Table 2.1 (continued)

| Work | Data | Approach and setting | Metric: best reported result |
|---|---|---|---|
| $C^2$GR [Li+26] | 20 tasks, 8 modalities; 2D | Diffusion replay, fixed task template, trained from scratch; TIL | Mean DSC, final: 83.62 % (joint 86.06 %) |
| González et al. [Gon+25] | Prostate, hippocampus, cardiac MRI; 3D | One model per stage, autoencoder selection; DIL | Mean DSC, prostate: $87.0 \pm 6.5$ % (true domain $89.6 \pm 2.0$ %) |
| Continual Segment [Ji+23] | TotalSegmentator, 3 private CT datasets; 3D | Frozen encoder, pruned decoder per dataset; CSS | Mean DSC: 88.74 % (4 nnU-Nets 89.02 %) |
| CL-Net [Guo+25] | 36 CT datasets; 3D | Frozen encoder, decoders per anatomy; CSS | Mean DSC: 85.7 % (nnU-Net ensemble 83.9 %) |
| Low-rank MoE [Che+24] | ACDC, ISIC, COVID-19 (2D); BTCV, LiTS (3D) | LoRA expert per dataset, CLIP-based selection; task and class level | Mean DSC, BTCV after LiTS: 80.6 % (Zhang et al. 78.5 %) |
| Zhang et al., Liu et al. [Zha+23; Liu+24] | Private CT, BTCV, LiTS; 3D | Fixed CLIP class names, head per class, pseudo-labels; class-incremental | DSC, BTCV organs / LiTS tumour: 0.817 / 0.466 (PLOP 0.799 / 0.362) |
| Lifelong nnU-Net [Gon+23] | Hippocampus, prostate, cardiac MRI; 3D | Five strategies compared; DIL | Rehearsal forgets least (DSC) |
| Ranem et al. [Ran+22] | HarP, Dryad, DecathHip; 2D | ViT U-Net vs. nnU-Net, six strategies; DIL | BWT, seq. training, HarP: −81.03 % (nnU-Net −83.47 %) |
| Beyond Forgetting [Wan+26a] | Prostate MRI, MMWHS, four organs; 2D | 16 strategies; Domain-, Class-, Organ-CL | Mean final DSC, Domain-CL: 0.789, PNN (joint 0.830) |
| SAM-Med3D-MoE [Wan+24] | SPPIN2023, weak categories; 3D | Points or boxes; decoder experts with a gate; not sequential | DSC, box prompts: Weak 0.564 (0.532); other 0.400 (0.541) |
| CA-SAM [Wan+26b] | Nine datasets; 2D | Boxes; alignment layer per task, autoencoder router | Final IoU: 76.12 % (joint 78.43 %) |
| RegCL [Shu+26] | Kvasir, CAMO, ISTD, ISIC, COD; 2D | Points; one merged adapter; DIL | Mean IoU, final: 0.775 (separate adapters 0.820) |
| CLoPA [Esm+26] | Eight MSD tasks; 3D | Clicks; repeated adaptation on one task | DSC, hepatic vessels: 0.698 (base model 0.165) |
| MedSeqFT [Ye+25] | Five CT, five MRI tasks; 3D | Seq. FT with distillation and LoRA refinement | Mean DSC, CT tasks: 68.3 % (parallel FT 65.3 %) |

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Table 2.1 (continued)

| Work | Data | Approach and setting | Metric: best reported result |
|---|---|---|---|
| Chen et al. [Che+26b] | BraTS, IXI; 3D | LoRA and head per task, task identity given; 16, 32, 64 samples per task; task-incremental | DSC, tumour, 32 samples: $0.60 \pm 0.08$ (seq. FT $0.16 \pm 0.19$ after task 2) |
| MedCRP-CL [Gao26] | 16 tasks, four modalities; 2D | CLIPSeg; LoRA per prompt cluster, EWC | Mean DSC / forgetting: 73.3 / 4.1 % (MoE-Adapters 65.3 / 7.1 %) |
| PA-EWC [Gao+26b] | Kvasir, ISIC, CheXlocalize, BUSI, CAMUS; 2D | CLIPSeg; EWC weighted by prompt complexity | Mean DSC: 75.34 % (ZSCL 73.02 %)[a] |
| MedPEFT-CL [Gao+26a] | Ten datasets; 2D | CLIPSeg; LoRA reused by prompt similarity, replay, EWC | Mean DSC: 78.19 % (MoE-Adapters 74.15 %) |

[a] Summary-table value; it does not match the paper's own per-task results.

Table 2.2: Position of this thesis relative to the closest works. Pretrained model: the continual sequence starts from a model pretrained on other data; few-shot: number of labelled samples per task; task identity: whether the task identity selects parameters at inference; pretrained ability: whether the ability of the pretrained model outside the task sequence is measured after the sequence.

| **Work** | **Text prompt** | **3D** | **Pretrained model** | **Few-shot** | **Task identity** | **Pretrained ability** | **Strategies compared** |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Zhang et al., Liu et al. [Zha+23; Liu+24] | Fixed CLIP class names | yes | not stated | no | no | no | Proposed, LwF, ILT, PLOP |
| MedSeqFT [Ye+25] | none | yes | yes | no | head per task | no | Proposed, parallel FT, parameter-efficient FT, multi-task |
| Chen et al. [Che+26b] | none | yes | yes | 16, 32, 64 | yes | no | Proposed, seq. FT, EWC, LwF, replay |
| MedCRP-CL [Gao26] | Descriptive sentences | no | yes | no | not stated | no | Proposed, seq. FT, EWC, RAPF, CL-LoRA, MoE-Adapters |
| PA-EWC [Gao+26b] | Templated phrases | no | yes | no | not stated | no | Proposed, seq. FT, EWC, LwF, LoRA, ZSCL, MoE-Adapters and others |
| MedPEFT-CL [Gao+26a] | Descriptive sentences | no | yes | no | not stated | no | Proposed, seq. FT, EWC, DER, low-rank MoE, MoE-Adapters |
| This thesis | Free text, one fixed prompt per task | yes | yes (VoxTell) | 5, 10, 20 for three strategies | task-specific LoRA only | yes (control task) | Seq. FT, task-specific LoRA, shared LoRA, shared LoRA + replay, distillation-based, prompt tuning; joint FT as reference |

# Chapter 3

# Theoretical Background

This chapter introduces the concepts on which the method of Chapter 5 builds. Section 3.1 describes volumetric segmentation networks, attention and the free-text promptable model VoxTell. Section 3.2 states the continual-learning problem in the notation used throughout the thesis. Section 3.3 describes the published methods from which our strategies are adapted, and Section 3.4 the metrics with which we measure adaptation and forgetting.

## 3.1 Free-Text Promptable Volumetric Segmentation

### 3.1.1 Encoder–Decoder Networks for Volumetric Segmentation

We consider the segmentation of one target structure in a 3D image volume. A volume $\boldsymbol{X}$ assigns an intensity to every voxel $v$ of its voxel set $\Omega$, and the label mask $\boldsymbol{Y}$ assigns $y_v = 1$ to the voxels of the structure and $y_v = 0$ to all others. A segmentation network predicts one logit $z_v$ per voxel, the logistic function $\sigma$ turns it into a foreground probability $\hat{y}_v = \sigma(z_v)$, and a threshold gives the binary prediction $\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}}$. In a free-text promptable model, the target is not fixed by the output channels of the network but named by a text prompt $p$, so one network with parameters $\theta$ computes the logits $\boldsymbol{Z} = f_\theta(\boldsymbol{X}, p)$ for any pair of volume and prompt. We write $\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}$ for the segmentation loss that compares $\boldsymbol{Z}$ with $\boldsymbol{Y}$. VoxTell uses the sum of the binary cross-entropy and the soft Dice loss [Rok+26, Sec. 3]; the soft Dice term is computed over the whole patch and therefore does not let the many background voxels dominate the loss as a voxel-wise average does [Mil+16b]. The form used in this thesis is given in Equation (5.1).

VoxTell builds on the U-Net design in its 3D form [Çiç+16], which its authors regard as still the strongest architecture for 3D medical image segmentation [Rok+26, p. 4]. An encoder computes features at successively lower resolutions in a sequence of stages, and a decoder upsamples them back to the input resolution. Skip connections pass the encoder features of every stage to the decoder stage of the same resolution, so the decoder can use spatial detail that was lost by downsampling. We write $\boldsymbol{F}_s$ for the encoder features of stage $s$ and $C_s$ for their number of channels, with $s = 0$ at the full resolution and larger $s$ at coarser resolutions. Because a whole volume and its intermediate features do not fit into the memory of a GPU, such networks are trained on patches cut from the volumes and applied at inference with a sliding window, whose overlapping patch predictions are combined into one prediction per volume. VoxTell is built on the nnU-Net framework [Rok+26, Suppl. p. 1], which configures these steps automatically for a given dataset [Ise+21], and uses its residual-encoder configuration ResEnc L [Ise+24, Sec. 3.1].

### 3.1.2 Attention

Attention lets a set of query vectors collect information from a set of source vectors, weighted by how well each query matches each source [Vas+17]. Let the rows of $\boldsymbol{U} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_q \times d}$ be $n_q$ query vectors and the rows of $\boldsymbol{S} \in \mathbb{R}^{n_s \times d}$ be $n_s$ source vectors of dimension $d$. Multi-head attention projects them with learned matrices $\boldsymbol{W}_q, \boldsymbol{W}_k, \boldsymbol{W}_v \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ to queries, keys and values and splits each projection into $n_h$ heads of dimension $d_h = d/n_h$. With $\boldsymbol{W}_q^{(i)}, \boldsymbol{W}_k^{(i)}, \boldsymbol{W}_v^{(i)} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_h \times d}$ the rows of the projections that belong to head $i$,

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{head}_i &= \mathrm{softmax}\left( \frac{\boldsymbol{U}\boldsymbol{W}_q^{(i)\top} \left(\boldsymbol{S}\boldsymbol{W}_k^{(i)\top}\right)^\top}{\sqrt{d_h}} \right) \boldsymbol{S}\boldsymbol{W}_v^{(i)\top}, \\ \mathrm{MHA}(\boldsymbol{U}, \boldsymbol{S}) &= \left[ \mathrm{head}_1, \ldots, \mathrm{head}_{n_h} \right] \boldsymbol{W}_o^\top, \end{aligned} \tag{3.1}$$

where the softmax runs over the $n_s$ sources for each query, $[\cdot]$ concatenates the heads along the feature dimension and $\boldsymbol{W}_o \in \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ is the output projection. We write all projections as maps $\boldsymbol{x} \mapsto \boldsymbol{W}\boldsymbol{x}$ of column vectors, which for row-wise inputs gives the transposes in Equation (3.1). Each query thus receives a weighted mean of the values, with weights given by the similarity of its query to every key. Attention itself does not depend on the order or position of the sources, so a positional encoding is usually added to them [Vas+17].

In self-attention, the queries and the sources are the same vectors ($\boldsymbol{S} = \boldsymbol{U}$); in cross-attention, they come from different inputs, for example a text embedding and image

features. Keys and values are computed from each source vector separately, so further rows appended to $\boldsymbol{S}$ give every query additional positions to attend to without any change to the projections, the mechanism that the prompt-tuning strategy of Section 5.4.5 relies on. A transformer decoder layer combines attention blocks with a feed-forward network of two linear layers applied to every query separately, and wraps each block in a residual connection and a layer normalisation [Vas+17]. In the original design, each decoder layer applies self-attention to its queries and then cross-attention to the encoder output; VoxTell's prompt decoder uses the same building blocks, with the text embedding as query and image features as sources [Rok+26, Eq. 3], of which the released implementation executes only the cross-attention (Section 5.3).

### 3.1.3 VoxTell

VoxTell is a vision–language model that maps a 3D volume and a free-text prompt, from a single word to a clinical sentence, to a segmentation mask of the described structure [Rok+26, p. 1]. The model has four parts (Figure 3.1): a frozen text encoder, a convolutional image encoder, a transformer prompt decoder that relates the text to the image, and a convolutional decoder into which the text is fused at every resolution [Rok+26, Sec. 3].

The text encoder is the embedding model Qwen3-Embedding-4B [Zha+25b], which maps the text prompt $p$, preceded by a fixed instruction to retrieve the anatomical entity and location it describes, to an embedding $\boldsymbol{q} = f_{\text{text}}(p)$ [Rok+26, Eq. 2, Suppl. p. 1]. The image encoder is the residual encoder of nnU-Net with six stages, $s = 0, \ldots, 5$, of 32, 64, 128, 256, 320 and 320 channels [Rok+26, Suppl. p. 1]; for a patch of $192^3$ voxels, the coarsest stage has $6^3$ voxels.

The prompt decoder consists of $L_{\text{dec}} = 6$ transformer decoder layers with eight heads and dimension $d = 2048$ [Rok+26, Sec. 3]. Its query is the text embedding $\boldsymbol{q}$, and its keys and values are image features: according to the paper the features of the bottleneck [Rok+26, Eq. 3], in the released implementation used in this thesis those of stage 4 (Section 5.3). One two-layer perceptron per decoder stage maps the output of the prompt decoder to a text-guidance matrix $\boldsymbol{E}_s \in \mathbb{R}^{G \times C_s}$, that is, $G = 32$ guidance vectors with the channel number of that stage [Rok+26, Sec. 3, Suppl. p. 1]. Because the query has attended to the image before it is mapped to the guidance, the guidance depends on both the prompt and the image.

The decoder upsamples the features stage by stage and fuses the guidance into every stage [Rok+26, Eqs. 4–6]. Starting from $\boldsymbol{H}_5 = \boldsymbol{F}_5$, it computes for $s = 4, \dots, 1$

$$\boldsymbol{H}'_s = \mathrm{ConvBlock}\left(\left[\mathrm{Up}(\boldsymbol{H}_{s+1});\, \boldsymbol{F}_s\right]\right), \qquad \boldsymbol{H}_s = \left[\boldsymbol{H}'_s;\, \boldsymbol{E}_s \odot \boldsymbol{H}'_s\right], \tag{3.2}$$

where Up upsamples to the resolution of stage $s$, $[\cdot\,;\cdot]$ concatenates along the channel dimension, and $\boldsymbol{E}_s \odot \boldsymbol{H}'_s$ denotes the $G$ maps of dot products between each guidance vector and the $C_s$-dimensional feature vector at every voxel. Each guidance vector thus marks the voxels whose features match it, and these $G$ maps are available as additional channels to all following convolutions. At the full resolution, $s = 0$, the implementation used in this thesis computes the output logits directly, as the dot product of the features with a single guidance vector (Section 5.3). The authors contrast this multi-stage fusion with the single late fusion of earlier text-promptable models such as SAT [Zha+25d], in which the text meets the image features only once, at the end of the decoder. They argue that late fusion forces the image features to be computed without knowledge of the prompt and that prompts naming a location need repeated interaction between text and image [Rok+26, p. 4].

VoxTell was trained with this loss on the outputs of all five decoder stages, weighted from 1 at the full resolution down to 1/16 as in nnU-Net (deep supervision) [Rok+26, Eq. 7, Suppl. p. 1]. Training used patches of $192^3$ voxels, 85 % of them centred on foreground, the data augmentation of nnU-Net without left–right mirroring, and SGD with an initial learning rate of $10^{-4}$ and polynomial decay [Rok+26, Suppl. p. 1]. Each training image was paired with three prompts, two naming structures present in the image and one naming an absent structure, so that the model also learns to return an empty mask; a prompt was the default name of its concept with probability 0.25 and a rephrased variant otherwise [Rok+26, Suppl. p. 1]. Figure 3.1 shows the model as it is used in this thesis; Section 5.3 describes where the released implementation differs from the paper.

## 3.2 Continual Learning

In continual learning, a model is trained on a sequence of tasks $t = 1, \dots, T$, one after the other. Training on task $t$ starts from the parameters $\theta_{t-1}$ reached after the previous task and uses the training data $\mathcal{D}_t$ of task $t$, which yields the parameters $\theta_t$; the data of earlier tasks are not available again unless a strategy keeps part of them. In our setting, the sequence starts from the pretrained parameters $\theta_0$, and each task comes with its own text

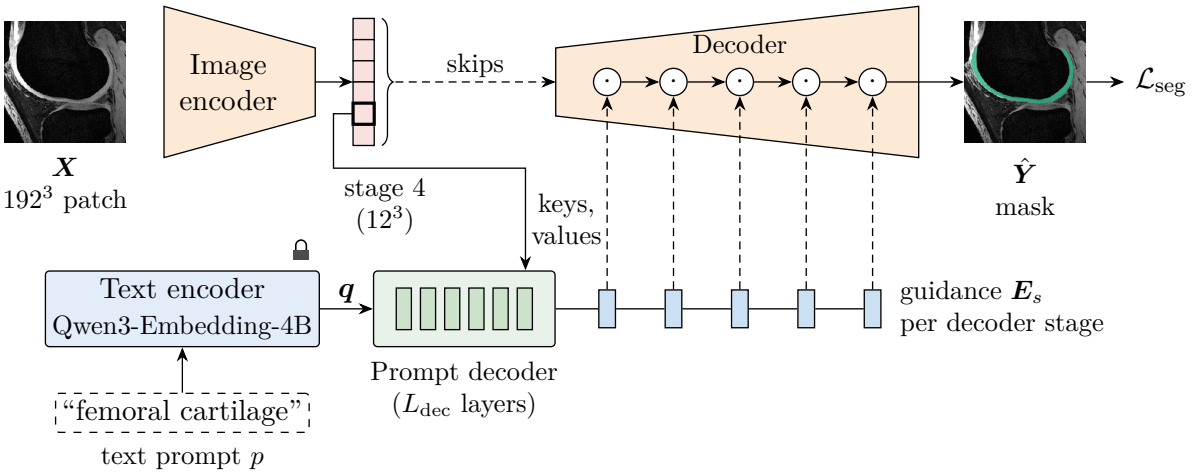



Figure 3.1: Architecture of VoxTell (adapted from [Rok+26, Fig. 2]). The image encoder computes features at six stages and passes them to the decoder stage of the same resolution. The frozen text encoder (lock) embeds the text prompt into the query $\boldsymbol{q}$, which the prompt decoder relates to the image features; its output is mapped to the guidance $\boldsymbol{E}_s$, which is fused into each of the five decoder stages (circles, Equation (3.2)). Drawn as used in this thesis: the prompt decoder attends to the stage-4 features and only the full-resolution output enters the loss, whereas the paper describes attention to the bottleneck and deep supervision. Input: a patch of SKM-TEA volume MTR_005 (test split) with the text prompt "femoral cartilage"; the output panel shows the reference mask for illustration.

prompt $p_t$. We call the training on one task a stage, so stage $j = 0$ denotes the pretrained model and stage $j = t$ the model after training on task $t$.

To see how training on later tasks affects earlier ones, the model is evaluated on every task after every stage [Zhe+23, Fig. 4b]. We write $a_{i,j}$ for the performance on task $i$ after stage $j$, here the mean DSC on the test set of task $i$, with $i = 1, \ldots, T$ and $j = 0, \ldots, T$; together, these values form the evaluation matrix. Its diagonal entries $a_{i,i}$ measure how well a task is learned when it is trained, the entries $a_{i,j}$ with $j > i$ how much of it is kept afterwards, and the entries with $j < i$ how the model performs on a task before training on it. In this matrix, catastrophic forgetting (Section 1.2) appears as $a_{i,j} < a_{i,i}$ for $j > i$. The loss of abilities that the pretrained model had before the first task does not appear in the matrix, because its rows cover only the tasks of the sequence; Section 3.4 measures it on a control task and defines the metrics that summarise the matrix.

Of the three continual-learning scenarios of Section 2.3, our setting is closest to task-incremental learning. All tasks share the same images, and each task adds a new target structure with its own masks. At inference, the text prompt names the structure to segment, so the model never has to infer which of the learned targets is wanted, the difficulty that

defines class-incremental learning. Since each task has one fixed text prompt, the prompt also identifies the task. The strategies differ in whether they use the task identity to select task-specific parameters: task-specific LoRA does, which we call task-aware inference, whereas all other strategies use one parameter set for all tasks.

## 3.3 Methods Adapted by the Strategies

This section describes the published mechanisms on which our strategies build, each in the form in which it was proposed. How we adapted them to VoxTell, and where our versions differ, is described in Section 5.4.

### 3.3.1 Low-Rank Adaptation

Low-rank adaptation (LoRA) keeps a pretrained weight matrix $\boldsymbol{W}_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{out}} \times d_{\text{in}}}$ frozen and learns an additive update of low rank [Hu+22, Sec. 4.1],

$$\boldsymbol{W} = \boldsymbol{W}_0 + \gamma_r \, \boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{A}, \qquad \boldsymbol{B} \in \mathbb{R}^{d_{\text{out}} \times r}, \quad \boldsymbol{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{r \times d_{\text{in}}}, \quad r \ll \min(d_{\text{in}}, d_{\text{out}}), \tag{3.3}$$

where only $\boldsymbol{A}$ and $\boldsymbol{B}$ are trained and $\gamma_r$ is a scaling factor. $\boldsymbol{A}$ is initialised randomly and $\boldsymbol{B}$ with zeros, so the update is zero at the start and training begins from the pretrained model. After training, $\gamma_r \boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{A}$ can be added to $\boldsymbol{W}_0$, so the adapted model has no additional inference cost, and switching to another task only requires exchanging the update [Hu+22, Sec. 4.1]. Hu et al. applied LoRA to the projection matrices of self-attention (Equation (3.1)) and, comparing choices under a fixed number of trainable parameters, found that adapting the query and value projections together gave the best performance overall [Hu+22, Sec. 4.2, 7.1, Table 5].

In the original formulation, $\gamma_r = \alpha / r$ with a constant hyperparameter $\alpha$ [Hu+22, Sec. 4.1]. Kalajdzievski showed that this factor makes the gradients of the adapter collapse as the rank grows, so that large ranks learn no better than small ones, and proved that only a factor proportional to $1/\sqrt{r}$ keeps the outputs and gradients of the adapter stable for all ranks [Kal23, Sec. 2.1, 3]. The resulting rank-stabilised LoRA (rsLoRA) sets

$$\gamma_r = \frac{\alpha}{\sqrt{r}}. \tag{3.4}$$

In fine-tuning experiments with a large language model and ranks up to 2048, rsLoRA improved with increasing rank while standard LoRA did not, and the gradient norms showed the same pattern with SGD as with AdamW [Kal23, Sec. 4].

### 3.3.2 Replay

Replay methods store samples of earlier tasks, or generate pseudo-samples, and train on them again while learning a new task [De +22, Sec. 3.1]. In the simplest form, rehearsal, a limited subset of stored training samples is added to the training data of each new task. Methods differ in which samples they keep and how they divide a fixed memory among the tasks; iCaRL, for example, keeps per class the exemplars that best approximate the class mean in feature space [De +22, Sec. 3.1]. Because rehearsal trains on a subset of the data of all tasks seen so far, its performance is bounded by joint training on all tasks, and it can overfit the few stored samples [De +22, Sec. 3.1]. Storing data also conflicts with storage limits and privacy constraints [De +22, Sec. 1], which in medical imaging restrict what may be kept from earlier patients.

### 3.3.3 Knowledge Distillation and ZSCL

In knowledge distillation, a student model is trained to reproduce the output distribution of a teacher model, softened by a temperature in the softmax [Hin+15, Sec. 2]. Continual learning uses distillation as a regulariser: Learning without Forgetting (LwF) trains on the data of the new task only and uses the outputs of the model from before this task as soft labels for the earlier tasks [Li+18] [De +22, Sec. 3.2.1]. The teacher is thus the previous model, and the distillation data are those of the current task.

ZSCL addresses the loss of CLIP's zero-shot transfer during continual learning (Section 1.2) [Zhe+23, Sec. 1] and changes two choices of LwF. The teacher is the initial pretrained model instead of the previous one, and the distillation data are a separate reference dataset of unlabelled public images and arbitrary texts instead of the current task's data [Zhe+23, Sec. 3.2]. For each image, CLIP's similarities to a set of texts are turned into a distribution by a softmax, and the loss compares these distributions of student and teacher by a cross-entropy; the same is done in the other direction, for each text over the images of a batch, and both terms are added to the task loss with a weight $\lambda$ [Zhe+23, Sec. 3.2, Eqs. 2–4]. In addition, ZSCL limits the change of the parameters themselves. Every $I_{\text{we}}$ iterations it updates a weight ensemble, the running mean of the parameters

along the training trajectory, starting from $\theta_0$,

$$\hat{\theta}_\nu = \frac{1}{\nu+1}\,\theta + \frac{\nu}{\nu+1}\,\hat{\theta}_{\nu-1}, \qquad \hat{\theta}_0 = \theta_0, \tag{3.5}$$

where $\theta$ are the current parameters and $\nu$ counts the ensemble updates [Zhe+23, Sec. 3.3, Eq. 7]. The full method further adds a penalty on the squared distance between the parameters and a reference set of parameters [Zhe+23, Sec. 3.3, Eq. 5, Table 2].

### 3.3.4 Prompt Learning and CPE-CLIP

Prompt learning adapts a frozen vision–language model by training a few input vectors instead of its weights. CoOp replaces the hand-written context words of a text prompt, such as “a photo of a”, by learnable context vectors in front of the class name, while all parameters of CLIP stay fixed [Zho+22b] [Zho+22a, Sec. 3.2]. CoCoOp adds a small network, the meta-net, that computes a token from the image features and adds it to every context vector, so the prompt depends on the input image; its authors report that this generalises better to classes not seen in training [Zho+22a, Sec. 3.3, 4.1].

CPE-CLIP applies prompt learning to few-shot class-incremental learning, in which a base session with many classes and examples is followed by sessions that each add a few classes with few examples, and no task identity is given at evaluation [DAl+23, Sec. 1, 3]. It keeps CLIP frozen and learns prompt tokens in the layers of the language encoder up to a given depth, replacing the prompt tokens of each layer by new learned ones; the prompts of the vision encoder are derived from the language prompts by a learned linear projection [DAl+23, Sec. 4, Eqs. 2–8]. To limit forgetting, it scales the gradients of the prompts and of the projection in session $t$ by

$$\beta_t = \frac{|\mathcal{C}_t|}{\sum_{\tau=0}^{t} |\mathcal{C}_\tau|}, \tag{3.6}$$

where $\mathcal{C}_t$ is the set of classes of session $t$, so that the prompts change less as more classes have been learned [DAl+23, Sec. 4, Eqs. 11–13].

## 3.4 Evaluation Metrics

The overlap between a binary prediction $\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}}$ and the label mask $\boldsymbol{Y}$ is measured with the DSC [Dic45],

$$\mathrm{DSC}(\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}}, \boldsymbol{Y}) = \frac{2\,|\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}} \cap \boldsymbol{Y}|}{|\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}}| + |\boldsymbol{Y}|}, \tag{3.7}$$

where $|\cdot|$ counts the foreground voxels of a mask and $\hat{\boldsymbol{Y}} \cap \boldsymbol{Y}$ denotes the voxels that are foreground in both. The DSC is 0 for disjoint masks and 1 for identical ones. Because it is normalised by the sizes of the two masks and not by the size of the volume, the many background voxels do not inflate it, which matters for structures as small as the knee cartilages and menisci (Table 4.2). Each entry $a_{i,j}$ of the evaluation matrix (Section 3.2) is the mean DSC over the test volumes of task $i$. The continual-learning metrics below were defined for classification accuracy, but Chaudhry et al. note that a task-specific measure such as the intersection over union of a segmentation can take the place of accuracy without changing the definitions [Cha+18, Sec. 3].

We summarise the evaluation matrix with four metrics from the literature and add a fifth for the control task, a task that is not part of the sequence and whose mean DSC after stage $j$ we write as $c_j$. Figure 3.2 shows which entries each metric uses.

$$\text{Adaptation} = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{i=1}^{T} a_{i,i}, \tag{3.8}$$

$$\text{Final Forgetting} = \frac{1}{T-1}\sum_{i=1}^{T-1}\Big(\max_{j\in\{1,\dots,T-1\}} a_{i,j} - a_{i,T}\Big), \tag{3.9}$$

$$\text{Control-task drop} = c_0 - c_T, \tag{3.10}$$

$$\text{Final Performance} = \frac{1}{T}\sum_{i=1}^{T} a_{i,T}, \tag{3.11}$$

$$\text{Transfer} = \frac{1}{T-1}\sum_{i=2}^{T}\frac{1}{i-1}\sum_{j=1}^{i-1} a_{i,j}. \tag{3.12}$$

Lower values are better for Final Forgetting and the control-task drop, higher values for the other three metrics.

Adaptation measures how well each task is learned when it is trained. It is the term $a_{k,k}$ of the intransigence measure of Chaudhry et al., which subtracts it from the performance on task $k$ of a reference model trained on the data of tasks $1, \dots, k$ together [Cha+18, Sec. 3, Eq. 4]; Adaptation reports this term without the reference.

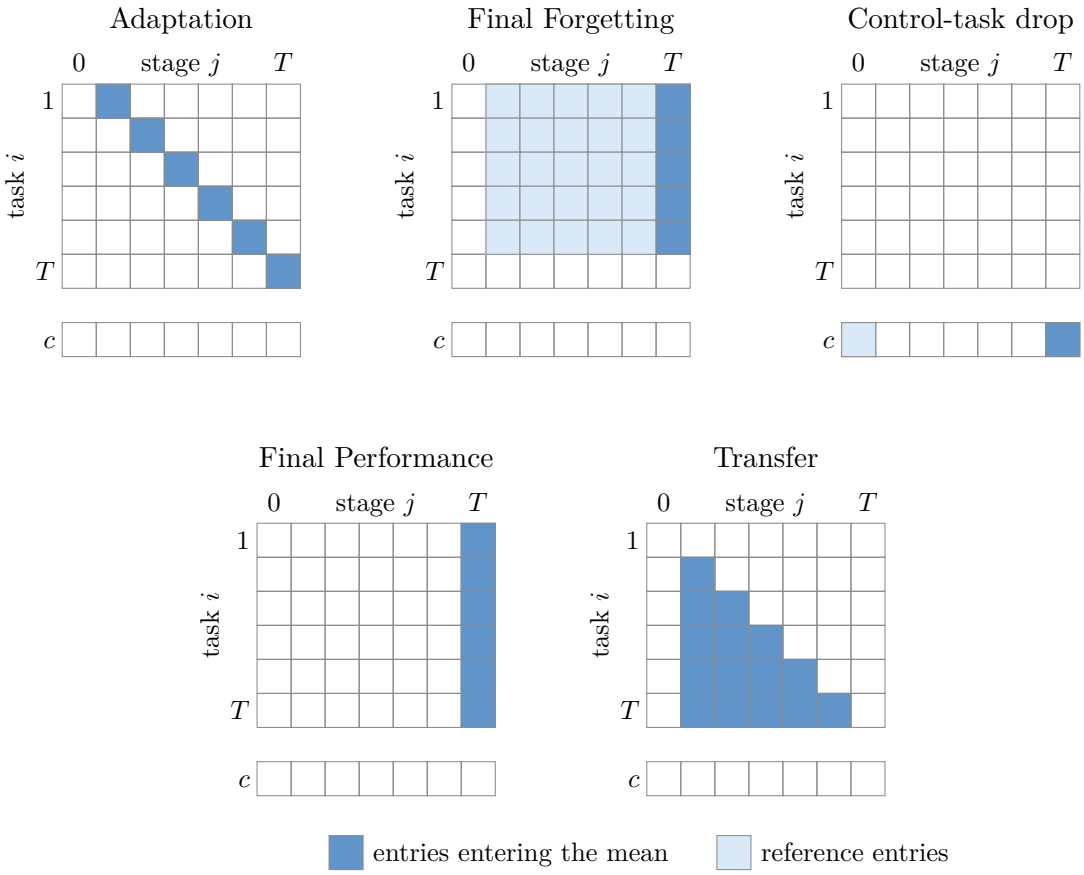



Figure 3.2: Entries of the evaluation matrix used by each metric (Equations (3.8) to (3.12)). Rows are the tasks $i = 1, \ldots, T$, columns the stages $j = 0, \ldots, T$, with stage 0 the pretrained model; the separate row $c$ is the control task. Dark cells enter the mean of a metric; light cells are the reference from which the dark cell of the same row is subtracted: the maximum over the light cells for Final Forgetting and the pretrained value $c_0$ for the control-task drop.

Final Forgetting is the average forgetting of Chaudhry et al. after the last task: for each earlier task, the best performance at any previous stage minus the performance at the end [Cha+18, Sec. 3, Eq. 3]. Chaudhry et al. index the matrix by stage first; Equation (3.9) is written in our convention. Taking the maximum over all previous stages, instead of the value right after training, also counts a loss of gains that a task made while later tasks were trained [Cha+18, Sec. 3]. As in their definition, the maximum runs over all stages $1, \ldots, T-1$; in our matrix this includes stages before task $i$ was trained, because every task is evaluated at every stage. A negative value means that training on later tasks improved earlier ones, which Chaudhry et al. call positive backward transfer [Cha+18, Sec. 3].

The control-task drop follows the control set of SPU, which measures how much of a pretrained model's general ability is lost during continual learning as the accuracy of the frozen pretrained model on the control set minus that of the continually trained model [Zha+24, Sec. 5.1, Eq. 6]. We compute it with the DSC for one task sequence, between the pretrained model and the model after the last stage, so a positive value is a loss. SPU samples its control set from the pretraining distribution [Zha+24, Sec. 3]; our control task instead comes from a dataset that VoxTell was not trained on, with a concept that is well represented in its training data (Section 4.2).

Final Performance is the metric Last of ZSCL, the mean performance on all tasks after the last stage [Zhe+23, Sec. 4, Fig. 4b]; it describes the model that a continual-learning run delivers. Transfer is the metric of the same name in ZSCL: the mean performance on each task at the stages after the first and before the task is trained, averaged first per task [Zhe+23, Sec. 4, Fig. 4b]. As in ZSCL, whose evaluation matrix has no row for the model before the first training step, stage $j = 0$ is not included, so the first task does not enter Transfer. For a pretrained model, it combines the ability that the model brings to a structure before seeing its labels with the effect that training on other structures has on it.

# Chapter 4

# Data Description

This chapter describes the two public datasets used in this thesis. SKM-TEA [Des+21] provides the knee MRI volumes from which the six continual-learning tasks are built, and AeroPath [Stø+23] provides the chest CT volumes of the control task. Table 4.1 summarises both datasets. The chapter then describes how the volumes are split, how the few-shot training subsets are drawn, how the data are preprocessed, and which properties of the data limit the conclusions that can be drawn from them.

## 4.1 SKM-TEA

### 4.1.1 Acquisition and Annotation

The Stanford Knee MRI with Multi-Task Evaluation (SKM-TEA) dataset contains knee MRI scans of 155 patients acquired at Stanford Healthcare [Des+21]. All scans were acquired with the 3D quantitative double-echo steady-state (qDESS) sequence on one of two 3 T GE MR750 scanners, with patient consent and approval of the Stanford University Institutional Review Board [Des+21]. qDESS acquires two inherently registered 3D echoes with different contrasts [Des+21]. The shared acquisition parameters are a matrix of $416 \times 512$ (readout $\times$ phase encoding), an in-plane resolution of $0.38 \times 0.31\,\mathrm{mm}^2$, echo times of 5.7 ms and 30.1 ms, a repetition time of 17.9 ms, a flip angle of 20° and 80 to 88 slices depending on knee size [Des+21, Table 5, App. A.1].

SKM-TEA is distributed in two benchmark tracks, one based on raw k-space data and one based on the scanner-generated Digital Imaging and Communications in Medicine (DICOM) images [Des+21]. We use the DICOM track, which stores the images and

Table 4.1: Datasets used in this thesis. Values computed from the data and the official SKM-TEA annotation files (version 1.0.0), except imaging, source and access, which are taken from the dataset publications [Des+21; Stø+23].

| | SKM-TEA | AeroPath |
|---|---|---|
| Role in this thesis | six continual-learning tasks | control task |
| Imaging | MRI, 3D qDESS, echo 1 | CT angiography |
| Source | Stanford Healthcare | St. Olavs hospital |
| Volumes used (patients) | 155 (155) | 27 (27) |
| With pathology label[a] | 130 of 155 | – |
| Split (train/val/test) | 108/23/24 | 19/4/4 |
| Volume size (voxels) | 512 × 512 × 144–168 | 487–512 × 407–512 × 241–843 |
| Voxel size (mm) | 0.3125 × 0.3125 × 0.8[b] | 0.56–0.82 × 0.56–0.82 × 0.50–1.25 |
| Structures used | 6 (Table 4.2) | lung |
| Access | github.com/StanfordMIMI/skm-tea | github.com/raidionics/AeroPath |

[a] At least one pathology bounding box in the official SKM-TEA annotation files (cartilage lesion, effusion, meniscal tear, ligament tear).
[b] From the official annotation files; the NIfTI files used in this thesis store an identity affine (1 mm).

segmentations of each scan in one Hierarchical Data Format version 5 (HDF5) file[1]. Of the two echoes, we use only the first, as the dataset authors do in the segmentation part of their tutorial [Sta]. According to the official annotation files, all 155 volumes have a voxel size of 0.3125 × 0.3125 × 0.8 mm and a matrix of 512 × 512 voxels with 160 slices, except four volumes with 144, 152, 156 and 168 slices.

Six tissues were segmented manually on all DICOM images: patellar cartilage, femoral cartilage, medial and lateral tibial cartilage, and medial and lateral meniscus [Des+21]. The segmentations were drawn slice by slice in the sagittal plane by two researchers with three to four years of experience in knee MRI interpretation, supervised by two board-certified musculoskeletal radiologists, and corrected for volumetric consistency in the axial and coronal planes [Des+21, App. A.4]. Each scan was labelled by a single annotator [Des+21, App. A.4]. The dataset also provides bounding boxes for sixteen pathology categories [Des+21]. According to the annotation files, 130 of the 155 scans contain at least one pathology: 99 a cartilage lesion, 88 an effusion, 68 a meniscal tear and 36 a ligament tear. These bounding boxes are not used for training or evaluation in this thesis.

[1] https://github.com/StanfordMIMI/skm-tea/blob/main/DATASET.md, accessed 19 October 2026.

Table 4.2: Structures of the six continual-learning tasks and of the control task, with the text prompt, the label value in the converted label maps (Section 4.4) and the structure volume over all volumes of the dataset. SKM-TEA volumes are computed from the voxel counts and the voxel size of the official annotation files; AeroPath volumes from the voxel size stored in each file.

| Task | Text prompt | Label | Volume ($cm^3$), median [IQR] |
|---|---|---|---|
| Lateral tibial cartilage | “lateral tibial cartilage” | 4 | 2.32 [1.82, 2.96] |
| Medial tibial cartilage | “medial tibial cartilage” | 3 | 2.13 [1.75, 2.56] |
| Femoral cartilage | “femoral cartilage” | 2 | 10.99 [8.73, 13.50] |
| Patellar cartilage | “patellar cartilage” | 1 | 3.14 [2.35, 3.77] |
| Medial meniscus | “medial meniscus” | 5 | 2.20 [1.81, 2.69] |
| Lateral meniscus | “lateral meniscus” | 6 | 1.90 [1.50, 2.37] |
| Control task (AeroPath) | “lung” | – | 4 858 [3 732, 6 231] |

SKM-TEA is distributed under the terms of the Stanford University School of Medicine and of the Lower Extremity Radiographs dataset [Des+21, App. A.5], and we signed the Stanford AIMI research-use agreement before downloading the data.

### 4.1.2 Continual-Learning Tasks

Each of the six segmented structures defines one task, with a fixed text prompt that names the structure (Table 4.2). The same text prompt is used for training and evaluation, and its wording is not varied. Since all six structures are labelled in every volume, the six tasks share the same 155 volumes and differ only in the target structure. The order in which the tasks are trained is part of the experimental setup and is given in Section 6.1.2.

The structures differ in size (Figure 4.1). Femoral cartilage is the largest structure, with a median volume of 10.99 $cm^3$, while the medians of the other five structures lie between 1.90 $cm^3$ (lateral meniscus) and 3.14 $cm^3$ (patellar cartilage). The six structures lie next to each other in the knee joint, as the example in Figure 4.2 shows.

We chose SKM-TEA because VoxTell performs poorly on it (Section 1.1). In the zero-shot evaluation of its authors, VoxTell reaches a mean DSC of 10.72 % over the six SKM-TEA structures, with 46.45 % for femoral cartilage and at most 14.78 % for the other structures [Rok+26, Suppl. Table 9]. The knee is not entirely absent from VoxTell’s training data: its label vocabulary contains femoral, patellar, and medial and lateral tibial cartilage from two knee MRI datasets, but no meniscus [Rok+26, Suppl. Tables 4, 5 and 10]. According to this vocabulary, SKM-TEA therefore combines structures that VoxTell has

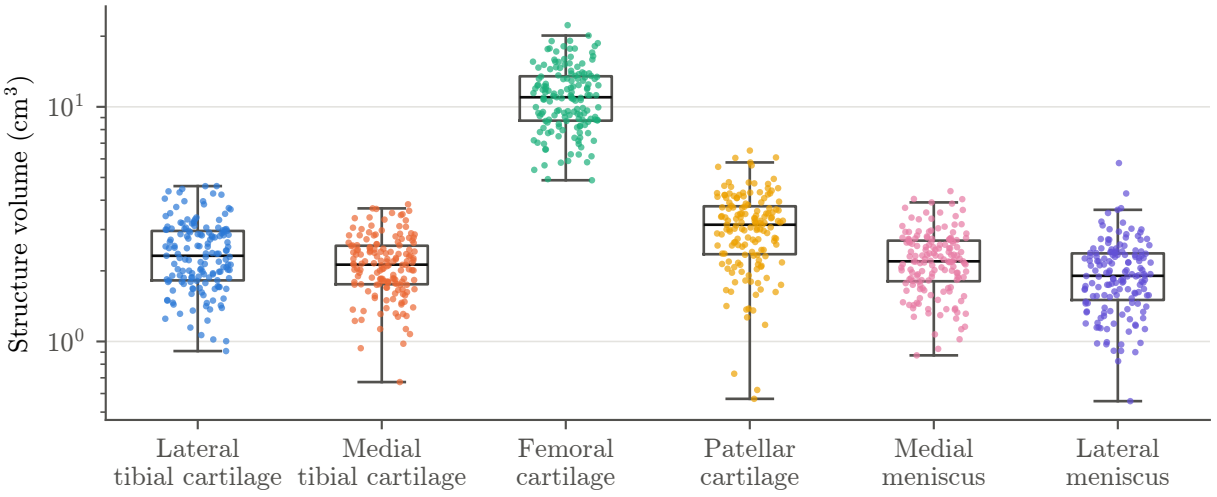



Figure 4.1: Volume of each SKM-TEA structure over all 155 volumes (logarithmic axis). Boxes show the median and the interquartile range, whiskers extend to 1.5 times the interquartile range, and each point is one volume.

rarely seen with structures it has never seen, although the authors describe the knee structures as absent from training [Rok+26, Sec. 6].

## 4.2 AeroPath

AeroPath contains 27 contrast-enhanced chest CT scans (computed tomography angiography (CTA)), acquired with a thorax lung protocol at St. Olavs hospital in Trondheim, Norway [Stø+23]. The 27 patients, nine of them women, were aged 52 to 84 years (median 70) and were all undergoing diagnostic tests for lung cancer, with pathologies including malignant tumours, sarcoidosis and emphysema [Stø+23]. Data collection was approved by the Norwegian regional ethics committee (REK Sør-Øst A, reference 2010/3385a), and written informed consent was obtained from the patients [Stø+23]. The dataset is distributed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 licence[2].

In the files used here, the volumes have 487 to 512 by 407 to 512 voxels in-plane and 241 to 843 slices, with an in-plane voxel size of 0.56 to 0.82 mm and a slice spacing of 0.50 to 1.25 mm. These ranges are wider than those stated in the dataset publication [Stø+23]; we report the values of the files. Each volume comes with an airway label and a lung label. The publication describes how the airway labels were created, by region growing or grow-cut, an

[2]Zenodo record https://zenodo.org/records/10069289, DOI 10.5281/zenodo.10069289, accessed 19 October 2026.

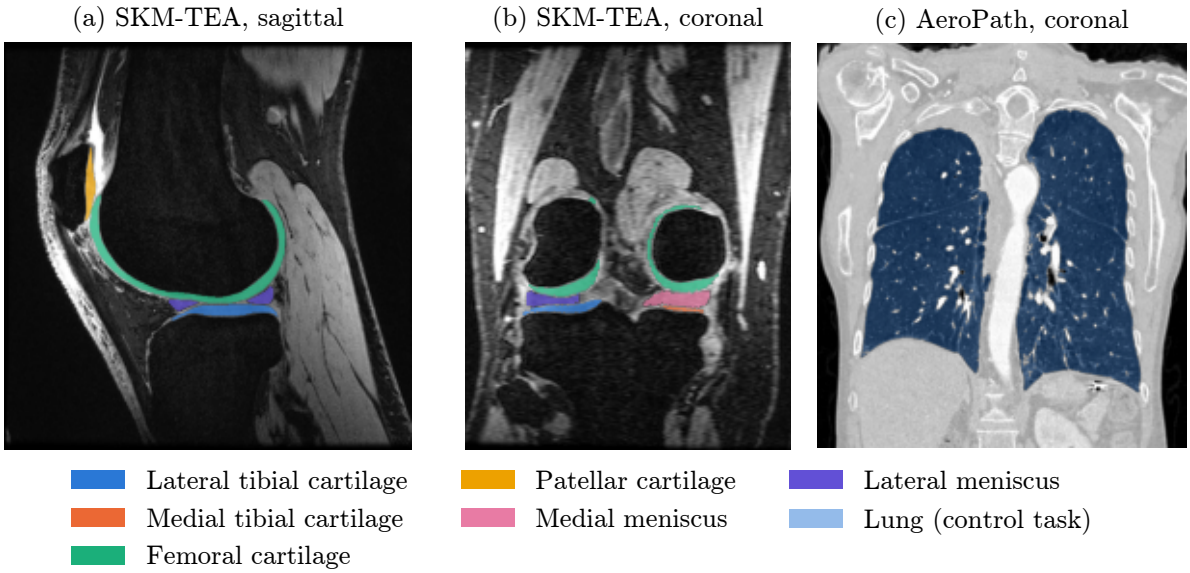



Figure 4.2: Example volumes with their labels. (a) Sagittal slice of SKM-TEA volume MTR_005 through the lateral compartment, showing patellar, femoral and lateral tibial cartilage and the lateral meniscus. (b) Coronal slice of the same volume through the tibial plateau, showing femoral cartilage, both tibial cartilages and both menisci. (c) Coronal slice of AeroPath volume 1 with the lung label of the control task. Both example volumes belong to the test split.

airway segmentation network and manual refinement verified by a pulmonologist [Stø+23]. How the lung labels were created is documented neither in the publication nor in the dataset repository or the Zenodo record. We use only the lung label, with the text prompt "lung".

AeroPath provides the control task, whose role and selection are described in Section 5.1. AeroPath is not part of VoxTell's training data: its authors use it as a held-out test set for a known concept, on which VoxTell reaches a lung DSC of 96.99 % [Rok+26, Suppl. Table 7]. The concept itself is well represented in VoxTell's training data, where "lung" is among the most frequent labels [Rok+26, Suppl. Table 10].

## 4.3 Data Splits and Few-Shot Subsets

We split each dataset once, at random, into 70 % training, 15 % validation and 15 % test volumes. The volumes are shuffled with a fixed random seed (42), the first 70 % of the shuffled list form the training split and the next 15 % the validation split, and the remaining volumes form the test split. This gives 108 training, 23 validation and 24 test volumes for

Table 4.3: Number of SKM-TEA volumes in each split of this thesis (rows) and of the official SKM-TEA split [Des+21] (columns).

| | Official SKM-TEA split | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| This thesis | Train | Val. | Test[a] | Total |
| Training | 63 | 22 | 23 | 108 |
| Validation | 10 | 7 | 6 | 23 |
| Test | 13 | 4 | 7 | 24 |
| Total | 86 | 33 | 36 | 155 |

[a] Patients with additional arthroscopic surgery.

SKM-TEA and 19, 4 and 4 volumes for AeroPath. Because the six tasks share the same volumes, every task uses the same split, and every experiment in this thesis uses the same split. Each SKM-TEA patient contributes exactly one scan, so no patient appears in more than one split. The validation volumes are used to monitor training and, for three of the strategies, to select the checkpoint that is evaluated (Section 5.3); all reported results are computed on the test volumes.

SKM-TEA also defines an official split of 86 training, 33 validation and 36 test scans, in which the test scans are those of the 36 patients who received additional arthroscopic surgery [Des+21]. We do not use this split, for two reasons. First, the aim of this thesis is to compare continual-learning strategies with each other, not to compare results with published SKM-TEA benchmarks, which is the purpose of the official split; the comparison only requires that all strategies use the same split. Second, the official test set consists of a selected group of patients, so a model trained on the official training split is tested under a shift between training and test data. A random split keeps training and test volumes from the same distribution, so that differences in adaptation and forgetting are not mixed with the effect of such a shift. Table 4.3 shows how the official splits are distributed over our splits: 7 of our 24 test volumes belong to the official test set. The results of this thesis are therefore not comparable with results reported on the official SKM-TEA test set.

For the few-shot experiments, the training split of each task is reduced to its first $k$ volumes, with $k \in \{5, 10, 20\}$ labelled training volumes per task, in the order of the shuffled list. The subsets are therefore nested, the 5 volumes being part of the 10 and the 10 part of the 20, and the same volumes are used for all six tasks. For each $k$, one subset is drawn, so the results do not show how they vary with the choice of training volumes. The full-data

setting uses all 108 training volumes, and the validation and test volumes are the same in all settings.

Of AeroPath, only the 4 test volumes are used, for evaluation; its 19 training and 4 validation volumes are not used.

## 4.4 Preprocessing

We convert each SKM-TEA HDF5 file into two Neuroimaging Informatics Technology Initiative (NIfTI) files, one for the first echo and one for the labels. The segmentation is stored as six binary channels, one per tissue; we convert it into a single label map in which each labelled voxel takes the index of its channel plus one and unlabelled voxels take the value zero. Following the channel order of the official documentation, the label values are 1 for patellar cartilage, 2 for femoral cartilage, 3 for medial tibial cartilage, 4 for lateral tibial cartilage, 5 for medial meniscus and 6 for lateral meniscus. For each task, the binary target mask consists of the voxels with the task's label value. The NIfTI files are written with an identity affine, so they store neither the voxel size nor the orientation of the scan. Images and labels come from the same voxel grid and therefore stay aligned, which we checked visually in ITK-SNAP [Yus+06]. The AeroPath volumes and labels are used in their original NIfTI format.

When a volume is loaded, it is reoriented according to its affine, which leaves the SKM-TEA volumes unchanged, and cropped to the bounding box of its non-zero voxels. Its intensities are then normalised to zero mean and unit standard deviation over the cropped volume, using the z-score normalisation of nnU-Net [Ise+21]. The same normalisation is applied to the MRI and the CT volumes. The volumes are not resampled, so the network operates on the voxel grid of each volume and the voxel size stored in the affine does not change its input. This preprocessing follows the configuration distributed with the VoxTell checkpoint, which uses the z-score normalisation for all inputs, including CT, and a preprocessing plan without resampling.[3] How patches are sampled during training and how predictions are assembled during evaluation is described in Section 5.3.

[3] File `plans.json` of the checkpoint `voxtell_v1.1` in the Hugging Face repository `mrokuss/VoxTell`: normalisation scheme `ZScoreNormalization`, data identifier `nnUNetResEncUNetLPlans_noResampling_3d_fullres`, no target spacing, image reader `NibabelIOWithReorient`.

## 4.5 Data Quality and Limitations

Several properties of the data limit the conclusions of this thesis. Because neither VoxTell nor our pipeline resamples the volumes (Section 4.4), the identity affine of the SKM-TEA files does not change the scale at which they reach the model: a voxel of $0.3125 \times 0.3125 \times 0.8$ mm is one voxel of the input with or without its true voxel size. Whether VoxTell saw knee MRI at this resolution during pretraining cannot be checked from its publication [Rok+26]. The identity affine does remove the orientation, which the reader of VoxTell uses to reorient every volume: the SKM-TEA volumes reach the model in their stored axis order, which may differ from the orientation of the knee volumes in its training data, and 18 of the 155 SKM-TEA scans are stored with the left–right axis reversed relative to the other 137. On our test volumes, the pretrained model segmented femoral cartilage with a DSC of 0.684 and none of the other five structures (Section 6.2), whereas its authors report 46.45 % for femoral cartilage and up to 14.78 % for the other structures [Rok+26, Suppl. Table 9]. The test volumes, the orientation and possibly the checkpoint version differ between the two evaluations, and we did not test which of these causes the difference.

The model sees only the first qDESS echo, although the annotators used both echoes to separate neighbouring cartilage and meniscus voxels [Des+21, App. A.4]. Each SKM-TEA scan was labelled by one annotator, so the data contain no information on the agreement between annotators. For AeroPath, the origin of the lung labels is not documented, so it is unknown whether they are manual or automatic references. The control task is evaluated on only four test volumes, which makes its results less certain than those of the SKM-TEA tasks with 24 test volumes. The CT volumes are normalised per volume like the MRI volumes, as in the configuration distributed with VoxTell (Section 4.4); its publication does not describe the normalisation itself. Finally, every result depends on one random split of each dataset and on one subset per number of training volumes.

defense: pre-trained DSC differs from VoxTell Suppl. Table 9; orientation (identity affine), test volumes and checkpoint version are candidate causes, none tested

# Chapter 5

# Method

This chapter describes what we built to answer the research question and why. Section 5.1 defines the continual-learning setting, Section 5.2 the protocol that measures adaptation and forgetting, Section 5.3 how VoxTell is adapted to a single task, Section 5.4 the strategies built on this procedure, and Section 5.5 their computational cost. The concepts are introduced in Chapter 3; the values of all parameters and the experiments follow in Chapter 6.

## 5.1 Continual-Learning Setting

We consider a sequence of $T = 6$ tasks built from SKM-TEA. Each task $t \in \{1, \dots, T\}$ is defined by one knee structure, its text prompt $p_t$ and the binary masks of that structure (Table 4.2). We write $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{tr}}$, $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{val}}$ and $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{te}}$ for the training, validation and test sets of task $t$, each consisting of the volumes of the corresponding split (Section 4.3) paired with the masks of structure $t$. The model is trained on task 1, then on task 2, and so on, and after training on task $t$ it should still segment the structures of tasks $1, \dots, t-1$ when given their text prompts. Because all six tasks share the same volumes, the images do not change from one task to the next. What changes is the target: every task introduces a new structure, with its own masks and its own text prompt. Catastrophic forgetting therefore shows up here as a loss of segmentation performance on earlier structures in the same images.

In every strategy, the text prompt names the target structure during training and at inference. Only task-specific LoRA (Section 5.4.2) additionally receives the task identity $t$ at inference and uses it to select parameters trained for that task (task-aware inference, Section 3.2); all other strategies use one parameter set for all tasks.

The protocol has two variables that are set per run. The first is the task order: a run trains all tasks in one fixed order, and comparing runs that differ only in the task order shows whether the results depend on the order in which the structures are learned.

The second variable is the amount of labelled data. In a few-shot setting, every task is trained on the first $k$ volumes of its training split (Section 4.3) instead of on the full split, and we refer to $k$ as the number of shots, that is, the number of labelled training volumes per task. Within a run, $k$ is the same for all tasks, and the validation and test sets do not depend on $k$. The task orders and values of $k$ that we used, and the reasons for them, are given with the experiments in Section 6.1.2.

In addition to the six tasks, we evaluate a control task that is not part of the task sequence and is never trained on: segmentation of the lung in the AeroPath test volumes $\mathcal{D}_c^{\text{te}}$ with the text prompt $p_c =$ "lung". It measures how much of VoxTell's pretrained ability on structures outside the task sequence is lost during adaptation, following the control set of SPU [Zha+24]. We chose this task for two reasons. Lung is a concept that VoxTell knows well from its training data, while AeroPath itself was not used for training (Section 4.2), and the pretrained model segments it with a mean DSC of 0.979 on our four test volumes (Figure 6.3), so a loss of ability is clearly visible. In addition, AeroPath is publicly available.

## 5.2 Evaluation Protocol

The protocol trains a strategy on the $T$ tasks in sequence and evaluates the model after every training stage on every task and on the control task (Algorithm 1). Stage $j = 0$ is the pretrained model with parameters $\theta_0$, and stage $j = t$ is the model after training on task $t$. After each stage $j$, we record the mean DSC $a_{i,j}$ on the test set $\mathcal{D}_i^{\text{te}}$ of every task $i \in \{1, \ldots, T\}$ and the mean DSC $c_j$ on the control task. The values $a_{i,j}$ form the evaluation matrix with $T$ rows and $T + 1$ columns (Section 3.2), and the values $c_j$ form an additional control row. We evaluate all tasks at every stage, including tasks that have not been trained yet ($i > j$), because these entries show how training on one structure affects the segmentation of structures that come later in the sequence. All metrics of this thesis are computed from these two quantities; their definitions are given in Section 3.4, and Section 6.1.4 explains which of them we report and why.

Each entry is the mean over the volumes of one test set of the per-volume DSC between the binary prediction and the label mask, with the prediction obtained by sliding-window inference (Section 5.3). Every entry of every run uses the same test volumes: the 24

SKM-TEA test volumes for the tasks and the 4 AeroPath test volumes for the control task (Section 4.3). Differences between entries, and between runs, therefore never come from different test data. We also keep the per-volume values, from which Section 6.1.4 estimates the variability of the metrics over test volumes.

Which parameters are evaluated at stage $j$ depends on the strategy. All strategies except task-specific LoRA evaluate one parameter set, obtained after training on task $j$, on every task and on the control task. Task-specific LoRA holds one adapter per trained task and uses the task identity to choose among them (Section 5.4.2): a task $i \leq j$ is evaluated with the adapter trained on task $i$, a task $i > j$ with the adapter of the current task $j$, and the control task with the pretrained model without any adapter. As a consequence, the entries of an earlier task do not change once its adapter is trained, and the control task always gives the pretrained result. Low forgetting and the absence of a control-task drop are thus properties of this evaluation for task-specific LoRA, not measured effects.

defense: task-specific LoRA's forgetting and control-task drop are zero by construction; state this wherever its results are compared

As a reference, we apply the same metrics to the pretrained model itself, treating it as if it had been evaluated unchanged after every stage, that is, with $a_{i,j} = a_{i,0}$ and $c_j = c_0$ for all $j$. This pretrained-model reference shows whether a strategy moved away from the pretrained model at all and in which direction. Because the order of the columns matters for some metrics, we compute it once for each task order.

As an upper reference, we train joint fine-tuning, which trains one model on the training sets of all six tasks at once, in a single stage. Each training sample keeps the text prompt of its own structure, and all other settings are those of sequential fine-tuning (Section 5.3), so the joint model receives the same number of updates as sequential fine-tuning over the whole sequence. It is evaluated on the test set of every task and on the control task after its single stage. Without a task sequence, Adaptation, Final Forgetting and Transfer are not defined for it, so we compare it with the strategies on Final Performance, per structure and on the control-task drop. We do not compute the intransigence measure of Chaudhry et al. [Cha+18], because its reference for task $k$ is a model trained jointly on tasks $1, \ldots, k$, and our joint model, trained on all six tasks, provides this reference only for $k = T$.

Algorithm 1 distinguishes the parameters $\theta_j$ that are carried forward to the next task from the parameters $\tilde{\theta}_j$ that are evaluated. In the main evaluation, both are the parameters after the last epoch of task $j$; the distinction matters for the two additional evaluations of Section 5.3, which evaluate the checkpoint with the lowest validation loss and, for the distillation-based strategy, the weight ensemble.

**Algorithm 1** Continual adaptation and evaluation protocol. ADAPT adapts the model to one task (Algorithm 2); SELECT returns the parameters a strategy evaluates on a given task (the parameters of the stage for all strategies except task-specific LoRA, see text); EVALUATE returns the mean DSC over a test set.

**Input:** pretrained parameters $\theta_0$; strategy $\mathcal{S}$; tasks $t = 1, \ldots, T$ in the chosen task order, each with text prompt $p_t$ and sets $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{tr}}, \mathcal{D}_t^{\text{val}}, \mathcal{D}_t^{\text{te}}$; control task with $p_c$ and $\mathcal{D}_c^{\text{te}}$
**Output:** evaluation matrix $(a_{i,j})$ with $i = 1, \ldots, T$, $j = 0, \ldots, T$; control row $(c_j)$

$\tilde{\theta}_0 \leftarrow \theta_0$
**for** $j = 0$ **to** $T$ **do**
  **if** $j > 0$ **then**
    $(\theta_j, \tilde{\theta}_j) \leftarrow \text{ADAPT}(\theta_{j-1}, j, \mathcal{S})$ {carried-forward and evaluated parameters}
  **end if**
  **for** $i = 1$ **to** $T$ **do**
    $a_{i,j} \leftarrow \text{EVALUATE}(\text{SELECT}(\mathcal{S}, \tilde{\theta}_{0:j}, i), p_i, \mathcal{D}_i^{\text{te}})$
  **end for**
  $c_j \leftarrow \text{EVALUATE}(\text{SELECT}(\mathcal{S}, \tilde{\theta}_{0:j}, c), p_c, \mathcal{D}_c^{\text{te}})$
**end for**

The cost of the protocol consists of $T$ calls of ADAPT, whose cost is given in Section 5.3, and of the evaluations. With $T + 1$ stages, each evaluated on $T$ task test sets and the control test set, the protocol runs sliding-window inference on $(T + 1)\,(T\,|\mathcal{D}^{\text{te}}| + |\mathcal{D}_c^{\text{te}}|)$ volumes, where $|\mathcal{D}^{\text{te}}|$ is the size of a task test set; for our sets this is $7 \cdot (6 \cdot 24 + 4) = 1036$ volume inferences per run, and the same number again for each additional evaluation. The evaluation time thus grows quadratically with the number of tasks, while the training time grows linearly. Evaluation needs memory for one parameter set and the prediction of one volume at a time; the stored results are the $(T + 1)^2$ means plus the per-volume values. The measured evaluation time per volume and per run is reported in Section 6.7.

## 5.3 Adapting VoxTell to One Task

All strategies adapt VoxTell to a task with the same procedure, ADAPT in Algorithm 2. A strategy changes this procedure at three defined points, which we describe in Section 5.4; this section describes the procedure itself.

We start every run from the released VoxTell checkpoint (version 1.1) [Rok+26], whose architecture is introduced in Section 3.1.3. We use VoxTell because it accepts free-text prompts and reached the highest mean zero-shot DSC in the comparison of its authors, ahead of SAT (Section 2.1). Figure 5.1 shows the model as it is used here, together with

the parts that the strategies change. Two properties of the implementation matter for what follows and differ from the description in the VoxTell paper. First, the prompt decoder takes its keys and values from the output of encoder stage 4, which has $12^3$ voxels for a $192^3$ input patch, and not from the bottleneck. Second, each of the $L_{\text{dec}}$ prompt-decoder layers applies only a cross-attention block and a feed-forward block, each preceded by layer normalisation and followed by a residual connection. Every layer also contains a self-attention module, but the configuration of the released model never executes it, so its parameters are never updated. Before the first layer, the text embedding and the stage-4 features are projected to the model dimension $d$ of the prompt decoder, and after the last layer one multilayer perceptron per decoder stage maps the output to the guidance $\boldsymbol{E}_s$ of that stage, $s = 0, \ldots, 4$. At stages 4 to 1, the guidance is split into $G$ vectors whose dot products with the decoder features at every voxel are appended as $G$ new channels; at stage 0, the full resolution, a single dot product yields the output logits. The text query $\boldsymbol{q}$ that enters the prompt decoder is the embedding of the text prompt computed by the text encoder Qwen3-Embedding-4B [Zha+25b], which stays frozen in every strategy.

Training uses patches of $192^3$ voxels, the patch size of VoxTell. In every epoch, each training volume contributes one patch: with probability $\pi_{\text{fg}}$ the patch is centred on a voxel drawn at random from the target structure, otherwise it is placed uniformly at random in the volume, and volumes smaller than the patch are padded with zeros. Each patch is trained with the text prompt of its task only, and the batch size is one, so that a training step fits into the memory of one GPU and a full-data run fits into the 24-hour job limit of the cluster; the same time limit bounds the number of epochs $E$ per task (Tables 6.2 and 6.10). Unlike the pretraining of VoxTell (Section 3.1.3), we add neither prompts of absent structures nor data augmentation, to keep the experiments simple, and we compute the loss on the full-resolution output only, without deep supervision.

author: check the reason; full-data training took 19 to 37 hours, so several runs needed a second 24-hour job

The loss is the sum of the binary cross-entropy and the soft Dice loss, the combination VoxTell was pretrained with [Rok+26]. For the output logits $\boldsymbol{Z}$ of a patch with voxel set $\Omega$, label mask $\boldsymbol{Y}$ and $\hat{y}_v = \sigma(z_v)$, where $\sigma$ is the logistic function,

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}(\boldsymbol{Z}, \boldsymbol{Y}) = -\frac{1}{|\Omega|} \sum_{v \in \Omega} \Big[ y_v \log \hat{y}_v + (1 - y_v) \log(1 - \hat{y}_v) \Big] + 1 - \frac{2 \sum_{v \in \Omega} \hat{y}_v y_v + \epsilon}{\sum_{v \in \Omega} \hat{y}_v + \sum_{v \in \Omega} y_v + \epsilon}, \quad (5.1)$$

with a small constant $\epsilon = 10^{-5}$ that keeps the Dice term defined for empty masks.

The trainable parameters are optimised with stochastic gradient descent with Nesterov momentum $\mu$ and weight decay $\omega$. The learning rate follows a polynomial schedule with

defense: no augmenta-

exponent one, that is, it decays linearly from $\eta_0$ to zero over the $U = E \cdot N_t$ iterations of a task, where $E$ is the number of epochs and $N_t$ the number of training samples of task $t$ per epoch, and is updated after every iteration. The optimiser, its momentum and the learning-rate schedule are created anew for every task. Optimiser, initial learning rate and the polynomial form of the schedule follow the pretraining of VoxTell [Rok+26]; the values of all parameters are listed in Tables 6.2 and 6.3. All strategies are trained with these same settings, and neither the learning rate nor the number of epochs was tuned per strategy, so our results compare the strategies under one shared training configuration, not each strategy at its best setting.

defense: no per-strategy tuning of learning rate and epochs; Only-Patellar diagnosis runs (lr 3e-4, longer training) as evidence of LoRA's sensitivity, Ch. 6/7

After every epoch, we compute the loss $\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}$ on the validation set, with one patch per validation volume drawn in the same way as the training patches. The patches are drawn anew for every validation, so the validation loss of two epochs is computed on different patches. In the equal-updates runs of Section 6.5, which have many short epochs per task, only every 24th epoch is validated, the last epoch included. All strategies are evaluated with the parameters after the last epoch, which are also the parameters that the next task starts from, so the evaluated model is the model that continues through the sequence. An additional evaluation uses the checkpoint of the epoch with the lowest validation loss, for all strategies except the LoRA strategies, for which only the adapter after the last epoch is stored. Algorithm 2 therefore returns both parameter sets, and Section 6.1.3 compares the two evaluations. Because the validation loss of an epoch is computed on one random patch per volume, it is a noisy criterion for selecting a checkpoint.

For evaluation, each test volume is cropped and normalised as described in Section 4.4 and segmented with sliding-window inference: patches of $192^3$ voxels are placed with a step of half the patch size, their logits are weighted with a Gaussian of standard deviation one eighth of the patch size and averaged, as in nnU-Net [Ise+21]. The averaged logits are passed through the logistic function and thresholded at 0.5, and the DSC between the binary prediction and the label mask is computed on the cropped volume. No test-time augmentation is used.

defense: best-validation checkpoint selected with a noisy validation loss (one random patch

Each iteration of Algorithm 2 costs one forward pass through the model and one backward pass through the part of the network that lies between the loss and the trainable parameters, so a task costs $E \cdot |\mathcal{D}|$ such iterations plus $E \cdot |\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{val}}|$ forward passes for validation. The time is therefore linear in the number of epochs and in the number of training volumes. The memory consists of the model parameters, one momentum buffer per trainable parameter and the activations of one $192^3$ patch; it does not depend on the number of training volumes,

**Algorithm 2** ADAPT: adapting VoxTell to task $t$. The steps with subscript $\mathcal{S}$ are where the strategies differ (Section 5.4).

**Input:** parameters $\theta_{t-1}$ carried forward from the previous task; task $t$ with text prompt $p_t$, $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{tr}}$ and $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{val}}$; strategy $\mathcal{S}$; $E$, $\eta_0$, $\mu$, $\omega$, $\pi_{\text{fg}}$
**Output:** parameters $\theta_t$ after the last epoch; evaluated parameters $\tilde{\theta}_t$

$(\theta, \phi) \leftarrow \textsc{Init}_{\mathcal{S}}(\theta_{t-1}, t)$ {model and trainable parameters $\phi$}
$\mathcal{D} \leftarrow \mathcal{D}_t^{\text{tr}} \cup \textsc{ExtraData}_{\mathcal{S}}(t)$; $U \leftarrow E \cdot |\mathcal{D}|$; $u \leftarrow 0$; $\ell^* \leftarrow \infty$
**for** $e = 1$ **to** $E$ **do**
  **for** each volume $(\boldsymbol{X}, \boldsymbol{Y}, p)$ of $\mathcal{D}$ in random order **do**
    $(\boldsymbol{X}', \boldsymbol{Y}') \leftarrow \textsc{SamplePatch}(\boldsymbol{X}, \boldsymbol{Y}, \pi_{\text{fg}})$
    $\mathcal{L} \leftarrow \mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}(f_\theta(\boldsymbol{X}', p), \boldsymbol{Y}') + \textsc{ExtraLoss}_{\mathcal{S}}(\boldsymbol{X}', p, \theta)$
    update $\phi$ by one SGD step on $\nabla_\phi \mathcal{L}$ with learning rate $\eta_0(1 - u/U)$, momentum $\mu$, weight decay $\omega$; $u \leftarrow u + 1$
  **end for**
  $\ell \leftarrow$ mean of $\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}$ over one sampled patch per volume of $\mathcal{D}_t^{\text{val}}$
  **if** $\ell < \ell^*$ **then**
    $\ell^* \leftarrow \ell$; $\theta^{\text{best}} \leftarrow \theta$
  **end if**
**end for**
$\theta_t \leftarrow \theta$; $\tilde{\theta}_t \leftarrow \theta_t$ {additional evaluation: $\tilde{\theta}_t \leftarrow \theta^{\text{best}}$}
**return** $(\theta_t, \tilde{\theta}_t)$

because one patch is processed at a time. How these costs differ between the strategies is summarised in Section 5.5, and the measured runtime and memory are reported in Table 6.10.

## 5.4 Continual-Learning Strategies

We compare sequential fine-tuning, a strategy without any continual-learning mechanism that serves as the baseline, with five continual-learning strategies, one of which combines shared LoRA with replay. They were selected to cover the three families of continual learning for vision–language models distinguished by Liu et al. [Liu+26b, Sec. 4]. Replay represents multimodal replay. The distillation-based strategy represents cross-modal regularisation; its template ZSCL is one of the survey's examples of preserving the structure of the pretrained image–text embedding space. Parameter-efficient adaptation is represented by two of its mechanisms, low-rank adaptation (task-specific and shared LoRA) and prompt-based methods (the prompt-tuning strategy, adapted from CPE-CLIP, which the survey lists among them). Shared LoRA with replay combines two families, a combination the survey

Table 5.1: Overview of the continual-learning strategies as instances of Algorithm 2. All strategies are evaluated with the parameters after the last epoch, from which the next task also starts (Section 5.3).

| Strategy | Trained parameters $\phi$ | Start of task $t$ (Init) | Added data / loss |
|---|---|---|---|
| Sequential fine-tuning | all parameters except the text encoder | parameters of task $t-1$ | – |
| Task-specific LoRA | low-rank factors $\boldsymbol{B}, \boldsymbol{A}$ in $\boldsymbol{W}_q, \boldsymbol{W}_v$ of the cross-attention of all layers | pretrained model with a new adapter | – |
| Shared LoRA | as task-specific LoRA | adapter of task $t-1$ | – |
| Shared LoRA + replay | as task-specific LoRA | adapter of task $t-1$ | replay memory $\mathcal{M}_{t-1}$ |
| Distillation-based | all parameters except the text encoder | parameters of task $t-1$ | $\lambda \mathcal{L}_{\text{KD}}$ |
| Prompt tuning | tokens $\boldsymbol{V}_l$ and meta-net $h_\psi$ in layers $l \leq L_p$ | tokens and meta-net of task $t-1$ | – |

describes as common. Within each family, we started with the method that best fitted a pretrained vision–language model or the few-shot setting. Other methods, such as adapter-based or mixture-of-experts adaptation, constraints to orthogonal subspaces [Liu+26b, Sec. 4] or elastic weight consolidation [Kir+17], were not evaluated.

defense: alternatives within each family not evaluated

Every strategy is a version of Algorithm 2, defined by the parameters it trains, by how it starts each task and by data or loss terms it adds. Table 5.1 summarises these choices, and Figure 5.1 shows where in the model each strategy acts.

### 5.4.1 Sequential Fine-Tuning

Sequential fine-tuning trains all parameters of the model except the frozen text encoder on each task in turn, starting each task from the parameters after the last epoch of the previous one. It adds no data, no loss term and no restriction of the parameters: it is the usual way of adapting a pretrained model to a new task, applied to each task in turn, and comparing the other strategies with it shows what their continual-learning mechanisms change. Of the 440,029,541 parameters it trains, 100,737,024 belong to the unused self-attention modules of the prompt decoder and the layer normalisations before them (Section 5.3) and never

receive a gradient, so 339,292,517 parameters are actually updated. Its cost per iteration is one forward and one full backward pass, and it needs a momentum buffer for every trained parameter, which makes it the most memory-intensive strategy apart from the distillation-based one (Section 5.5).

### 5.4.2 Task-Specific and Shared LoRA

Both LoRA strategies keep all pretrained weights frozen and train a low-rank update $\gamma_r \boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{A}$ (Equation (3.3)) of selected projection matrices $\boldsymbol{W}_0 \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times d}$ of the prompt decoder [Hu+22]. The rank $r$ and the hyperparameter $\alpha$ are set per configuration, and the scaling factor is the rank-stabilised $\gamma_r = \alpha/\sqrt{r}$ of rsLoRA (Equation (3.4)) [Kal23]. We use it instead of $\alpha/r$ because the shared adapter is trained with high ranks (Section 6.3), at which rsLoRA showed $\alpha/r$ to slow learning (Section 3.3.1). Unlike in the original LoRA, $\boldsymbol{A}$ is initialised with the Kaiming-uniform scheme instead of a Gaussian; $\boldsymbol{B}$ starts at zero, so the update is zero at the start and training begins from the pretrained model. Dropout is applied to the input of the low-rank path only.

We apply LoRA to the query and value projections $\boldsymbol{W}_q$ and $\boldsymbol{W}_v$ of the cross-attention in all $L_{\text{dec}}$ prompt-decoder layers (Figure 5.1). The cross-attention is where the text query attends to the image features, the step through which the text prompt steers the segmentation in VoxTell, and LoRA has been applied to attention projections of vision–language models before, for instance in CLIP-LoRA [Zan+24]. Our LoRA layers are adapted from the `loralib` module of the public CLIP-LoRA code[1], including the split of the joint input projection of the attention into separate query, key and value projections, to which the low-rank updates are added. The restriction to the query and value projections follows the finding of Hu et al. for the self-attention of GPT-3 [Hu+22, Sec. 7.1, Table 5] (Section 3.3.1); whether it also holds for the cross-attention of VoxTell was not tested here. The image encoder, the convolutional decoder, the guidance projections and the self-attention, key and output projections stay unchanged. With two adapted projections per layer and $2dr$ parameters each, a LoRA adapter has $4L_{\text{dec}}\, d\, r = 49{,}152\, r$ trainable parameters for $d = 2048$ and $L_{\text{dec}} = 6$.

The two strategies differ in how the adapters are used across tasks. Task-specific LoRA starts every task from the pretrained model with a new adapter, so each adapter is trained only on its own task and independently of all others. After each task, the adapter is stored, and at inference the task identity selects the adapter (Section 5.2); after $T$ tasks, $T$ adapters

[1] https://github.com/MaxZanella/CLIP-LoRA/tree/main/loralib

are kept. Shared LoRA creates one adapter before the first task and continues training it on every following task, so all tasks and the control task are evaluated with the same adapter. The two strategies were run with different values of $\alpha$ and of the dropout rate, which are listed in Table 6.3; their comparison is therefore one between configurations, not only between a task-specific and a shared adapter.

defense: alpha and dropout differ between the two LoRA variants

For both strategies, an iteration still needs a forward pass through the whole model, but the backward pass only has to reach the adapted projections, through the convolutional decoder, the guidance projections and the prompt decoder; no gradient is needed in the image encoder or the text encoder. Only the adapter parameters need momentum buffers. In our implementation, the update is formed as the full matrix $\gamma_r \boldsymbol{BA}$ in every training forward pass, which costs $\mathcal{O}(d^2 r)$ operations, and is then applied like a second projection, so the two adapted projections cost about twice as much as without LoRA; both are small compared with the convolutions of the image network. For evaluation, the update is merged into $\boldsymbol{W}_0$ once, so inference costs the same as for the pretrained model.

### 5.4.3 Replay

Replay keeps a memory $\mathcal{M}$ of earlier training samples and adds it to the training data of each new task. We combine it with shared LoRA, so that the two can be compared directly. Because the six tasks share the same volumes, a memory entry is not just a volume but a triple of volume, text prompt and mask of the task it was drawn from.

The memory starts empty and contains only samples of earlier tasks, so the control task stays held out and nothing from the pretraining of VoxTell is replayed. After each task $t$, $\max(1, \mathrm{round}(\rho\,|\mathcal{D}_t^{\mathrm{tr}}|))$ samples drawn at random from its training set are added, where $\rho$ is the replay fraction, up to a capacity of $M_{\max}$ entries. During task $t$, the memory $\mathcal{M}_{t-1}$ is appended to the training set (ExtraData in Algorithm 2), and its entries are sampled and trained like the task's own volumes, each with its own text prompt, so an epoch has $N_t = |\mathcal{D}_t^{\mathrm{tr}}| + |\mathcal{M}_{t-1}|$ iterations. The memory is stored with the state of the run, so a run that is interrupted and resumed continues with the same memory. The value of $\rho$ was set once and not tuned; it and $M_{\max}$ are listed in Table 6.3.

Replay changes only the data, so the cost of an iteration is that of shared LoRA, and the number of iterations per epoch grows by $|\mathcal{M}_{t-1}|$. The memory stores references to volumes and masks, not copies, so it needs no additional GPU memory.

### 5.4.4 Distillation-Based Strategy

The distillation-based strategy is adapted from ZSCL [Zhe+23], which protects the zero-shot ability of CLIP by distilling the similarity distributions of the frozen initial model on a reference dataset, by averaging the weights during training and, in the full method, by a weight-consolidation loss (Section 3.3.3).

Our strategy trains all parameters except the text encoder, like sequential fine-tuning, and adds a distillation loss $\lambda \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{KD}}$ on each training patch (ExtraLoss in Algorithm 2). The teacher is a frozen copy of the pretrained model $f_{\theta_0}$, which is not updated during the whole task sequence and receives the same patch and text prompt as the student. The loss compares how the stage-4 guidance relates to the stage-4 image features (Figure 5.1). Let $\boldsymbol{e}_g$, $g = 1, \ldots, G$, be the $G$ guidance vectors of $\boldsymbol{E}_4$ and $\boldsymbol{f}_v$ the encoder features of stage 4 at voxel $v$ of the $12^3$ voxels $\Omega_4$ of that stage. For each guidance vector, the student defines a distribution over the voxels,

$$q_{g,v} = \frac{\exp\left(\langle \boldsymbol{e}_g/\|\boldsymbol{e}_g\|, \boldsymbol{f}_v \rangle\right)}{\sum_{v' \in \Omega_4} \exp\left(\langle \boldsymbol{e}_g/\|\boldsymbol{e}_g\|, \boldsymbol{f}_{v'} \rangle\right)}, \qquad \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{KD}} = \sum_{g=1}^{G} \sum_{v \in \Omega_4} \bar{q}_{g,v} \log \frac{\bar{q}_{g,v}}{q_{g,v}}, \tag{5.2}$$

where $\bar{q}_{g,v}$ is the same distribution computed by the teacher, so $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{KD}}$ is the Kullback–Leibler divergence of the student's distributions from the teacher's. The gradient of $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{KD}}$ reaches the image encoder up to stage 4, the prompt decoder and the stage-4 guidance projection.

From ZSCL, the strategy keeps the frozen initial model as teacher, which ZSCL found to work better than the model of the previous task [Zhe+23, Table 1d], and the idea of distilling a similarity distribution between text-derived and image representations, added to the task loss with a weight $\lambda$. It differs from ZSCL in six points. First, it distils on the patches of the current task instead of a reference dataset, so it needs no data beyond the task data; in ZSCL's ablation, this choice kept the transfer to unseen tasks at the level of a reference dataset but lowered the average and final accuracy [Zhe+23, Table 1b, p. 7]. Second, the distribution runs over voxels for each guidance vector, not over texts for each image, and only in this one direction; ZSCL additionally distils a text-side distribution. Third, it uses stage 4, the level at which text and image interact in the prompt decoder, which is also the coarsest and cheapest level, with $12^3$ voxels per patch. In the segmentation itself, $\boldsymbol{E}_4$ is fused with the decoder features of that resolution, whereas $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{KD}}$ pairs it with the encoder features. Fourth, $\lambda$ is much smaller than ZSCL's $\lambda = 1$ and was not tuned (Table 6.3). Fifth, it has no weight-consolidation loss. Sixth, its task loss is the segmentation loss of Equation (5.1), optimised with SGD instead of AdamW.

The strategy also maintains ZSCL's weight ensemble, Eq. 7 of ZSCL [Zhe+23]: after every $I_{\text{we}}$-th iteration of an epoch, the current parameters are added to a running mean that starts from $\theta_0$ and is continued across tasks, so the ensemble is the equally weighted mean of $\theta_0$ and all parameter snapshots taken so far. Iterations at the end of an epoch that do not complete an interval of $I_{\text{we}}$ are not included, and $I_{\text{we}} = 10$ is smaller than the interval of 100 used by ZSCL (Table 6.3). Training continues from the student, so the ensemble is not carried forward to the next task. We evaluate it after every task as an additional evaluation, next to the student, and the strategy in the main comparison is fine-tuning with feature distillation, after which we name it.

Each iteration adds one forward pass of the teacher without a backward pass. The teacher is kept in CPU memory and copied to the GPU for this forward pass, which adds transfer time, and the weight ensemble is a further copy of all parameters on the GPU, so this strategy needs the most memory of all (Table 6.10).

### 5.4.5 Prompt-Tuning Strategy

The prompt-tuning strategy is adapted from CPE-CLIP [DAl+23], which learns prompt tokens in a frozen CLIP model for few-shot class-incremental learning and scales their gradients down as more classes have been seen (Section 3.3.4).

Our strategy keeps every VoxTell parameter frozen and trains two components in the first $L_p$ of the $L_{\text{dec}}$ prompt-decoder layers (Figure 5.1). The first are learned prompt tokens $\boldsymbol{V}_l \in \mathbb{R}^{m \times d}$, $l = 1, \ldots, L_p$: in layer $l$, the $m$ tokens are appended to the keys and values of the cross-attention, with a positional encoding of zero, and each layer has its own tokens. The second is a meta-net $h_\psi$, a two-layer perceptron with a GELU activation, which adds an offset to the text query before each of these layers,

$$\boldsymbol{q} \leftarrow \boldsymbol{q} + h_\psi\Big([\boldsymbol{q}; \bar{\boldsymbol{f}}\,]\Big), \tag{5.3}$$

where $\bar{\boldsymbol{f}}$ is the mean of the stage-4 image features over all voxels after their projection to dimension $d$, and $[\cdot\,;\cdot]$ denotes concatenation. The design of the meta-net was inspired by the conditional prompt learning of CoCoOp [Zho+22a]. The tokens are initialised with the Xavier-uniform scheme. With $L_p \cdot m \cdot d$ token parameters and the meta-net, the strategy has 12,599,296 trainable parameters, of which 12,587,008 belong to the meta-net; the name prompt tuning therefore understates the share of the meta-net. The values of $m$ and $L_p$ were set once and not tuned (Table 6.3).

One set of tokens and one meta-net are trained through all tasks and used for every task at inference, so the strategy needs no task identity. Because the tokens and the meta-net change the keys, values and query for every text prompt, freezing the backbone does not keep the outputs for other text prompts unchanged. The gradients of the tokens and of the meta-net in task $t$ are multiplied by $\beta_t = \max(0.25, 1/t)$, which for one new structure per task and no base session equals the scaling of CPE-CLIP apart from the lower bound of 0.25. CPE-CLIP applies its scale to the language prompts and to the projection that derives the vision prompts from them [DAl+23, p. 5, Eqs. 12–13]; we correspondingly apply it to the tokens and to the meta-net, which holds almost all of our trainable parameters. In CPE-CLIP's ablation, removing this scaling degraded performance more than removing any other component (Section 2.3). An earlier run in which the scale was not activated, so that $\beta_t = 1$ for all tasks, serves as an ablation; it was evaluated only with the checkpoint of the lowest validation loss, so the two runs are compared with that checkpoint (Section 6.2).

The strategy differs from CPE-CLIP in that the tokens act on the cross-attention of the prompt decoder instead of on the inputs of a language and a vision encoder, that there is no projection between two sets of prompts, that the meta-net is added, and that the task loss is the segmentation loss of Equation (5.1) without a base session; we therefore name it after its mechanism, prompt tuning, rather than after CPE-CLIP. An iteration needs a forward pass through the whole model and a backward pass through the convolutional decoder, the guidance projections and the prompt decoder down to its first layer, but not through the encoders; the momentum buffers cover only the 12.6 M trainable parameters, and the $m$ additional keys and values per prompted layer cost little compared with the $12^3$ image positions.

## 5.5 Computational Complexity

All strategies share the forward pass through the whole model and the evaluation of Algorithm 1; they differ in how far the backward pass reaches, in how many parameters need optimiser state, in additional forward passes and in the amount of data per epoch (Table 5.2). Let $\kappa$ be the cost of one forward pass on a patch and $\kappa_{\mathcal{S}}$ the cost of the backward pass of strategy $\mathcal{S}$. Adapting to task $t$ then costs $\mathcal{O}\big(E\,N_t\,(\kappa + \kappa_{\mathcal{S}}) + E\,|\mathcal{D}_t^{\mathrm{val}}|\,\kappa\big)$, and the distillation-based strategy adds $E\,N_t\,\kappa$ for the teacher. The time is thus linear in the number of epochs and of training samples for every strategy, and replay increases $N_t$ by the size of the memory.

For memory, the main difference is whether the backward pass reaches the image encoder: sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy store its activations and keep momentum buffers for all parameters, whereas the LoRA strategies and the prompt-tuning strategy need neither, and the distillation-based strategy additionally holds the teacher and the weight ensemble. After $T$ tasks, task-specific LoRA stores one adapter per task, so its storage grows linearly with the number of tasks; all other strategies store one parameter set. At inference, all strategies cost about the same sliding-window forward passes (Sections 5.4.2 and 5.4.5). The measured training time per epoch, the peak GPU memory and the evaluation time per volume on the NVIDIA A100 used in this work are reported in Table 6.10.

Table 5.2: Computational cost of the strategies relative to sequential fine-tuning. $P$: parameters of the segmentation model (440,029,541, of which 339,292,517 receive gradients, Section 5.4.1); $d$, $L_{\text{dec}}$: dimension and number of prompt-decoder layers; $r$: LoRA rank; $m$, $L_p$: tokens per layer and prompted layers; $|\psi|$: parameters of the meta-net. The frozen text encoder is not counted. Measured runtime and memory: Table 6.10.

| Strategy | Trained parameters $\lvert\phi\rvert$ | Additional cost per training iteration | Additional training memory | Stored after $T$ tasks |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sequential fine-tuning | $P$ | – (reference: full backward pass) | momentum for $P$ | $P$ |
| Task-specific LoRA | $4L_{\text{dec}}\,d\,r$ | backward pass only down to the prompt decoder; forming and applying $\gamma_r \boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{A}$, $\mathcal{O}(d^2 r)$ per projection | momentum for $\lvert\phi\rvert$ | $P + T \cdot 4L_{\text{dec}}\,d\,r$ |
| Shared LoRA | $4L_{\text{dec}}\,d\,r$ | as task-specific LoRA | momentum for $\lvert\phi\rvert$ | $P + 4L_{\text{dec}}\,d\,r$ |
| Shared LoRA + replay | $4L_{\text{dec}}\,d\,r$ | as shared LoRA; $\lvert\mathcal{M}_{t-1}\rvert$ more iterations per epoch | momentum for $\lvert\phi\rvert$; memory holds references only | $P + 4L_{\text{dec}}\,d\,r$ |
| Distillation-based | $P$ | one forward pass of the teacher, copied from CPU to GPU; $\mathcal{L}_{\text{KD}}$ on $G \cdot 12^3$ similarities | momentum for $P$; teacher ($P$, CPU); weight ensemble ($P$, GPU) | $P$ |
| Prompt tuning | $L_p\,m\,d + \lvert\psi\rvert$ | backward pass only down to the prompt decoder; $m$ more keys and values in $L_p$ layers | momentum for $\lvert\phi\rvert$ | $P + L_p\,m\,d + \lvert\psi\rvert$ |

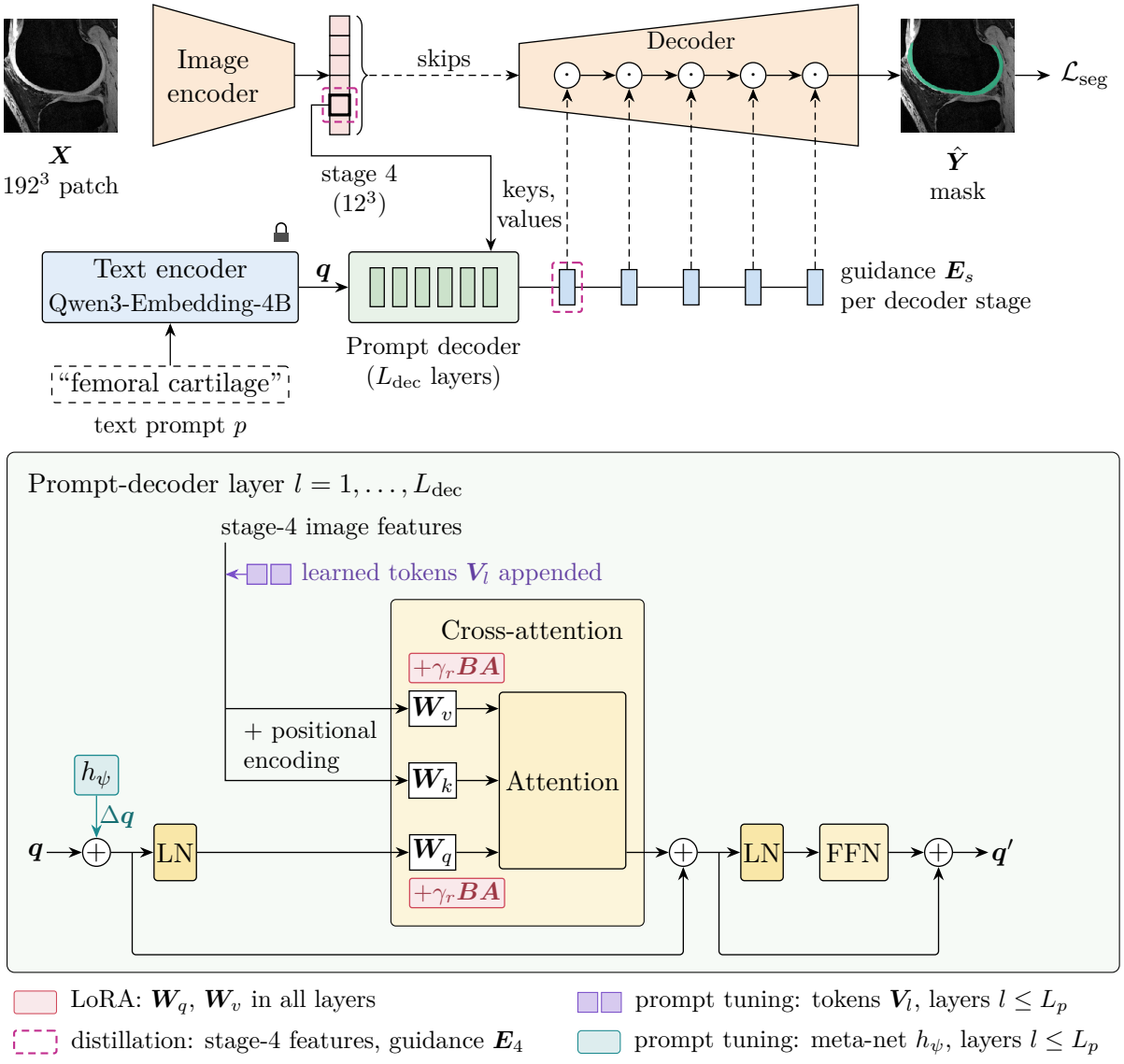



Figure 5.1: VoxTell as used in this thesis and the parts that the continual-learning strategies change (layout adapted from [Rok+26, Fig. 2]). Top: all encoder stages feed the decoder stage of the same resolution; the prompt decoder attends to the stage-4 features, and its output is mapped to the guidance $\boldsymbol{E}_s$ of the five fusion points. The lock marks the frozen text encoder; the output panel shows the reference mask of femoral cartilage (test volume MTR_005) for illustration. Bottom: one prompt-decoder layer as executed; the attention block includes the output projection. The coloured marks are explained in Section 5.4. Sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy update all parameters except the text encoder; replay changes only the training data.

# Chapter 6

# Experiments and Results

This chapter reports the experiments with which we answer the research question. Section 6.1 gives the setup: the experiments, the data settings, the values of all parameters and the metrics. Each of the following sections presents one experiment with its result and its conclusion.

## 6.1 Experimental Setup

### 6.1.1 Overview of the Experiments

Table 6.1 lists the experiments. Each consists of runs of the protocol of Algorithm 1 that differ in one factor: the strategy, the LoRA rank, the number of training volumes or of updates per task, the task order, the use of replay or of gradient scaling. Joint fine-tuning, trained on all six tasks at once, is the upper reference for the comparison of the strategies and for the amount of labelled data. The comparison of the strategies addresses the second objective of Section 1.3, the experiment on the amount of labelled data the third, and the experiments on rank, task order, replay and gradient scaling the fourth. A diagnostic experiment with task-specific LoRA trained on patellar cartilage alone tests why this strategy did not learn that structure in the task sequence (Section 6.4). In total, we report 38 runs, each trained once; the evaluation matrices of all of them are given in Section A.2. The pretrained model serves as a reference in every experiment (Section 5.2).

Some factors were not varied. We trained two task orders, one draw of training volumes per few-shot setting and one text prompt per structure, and we did not tune the learning

rate or the number of epochs per strategy. How these choices limit the conclusions is discussed in Section 7.3.

### 6.1.2 Data, Task Orders and Few-Shot Settings

All runs use the splits of Section 4.3: for each of the six tasks, 108 training, 23 validation and 24 test volumes of SKM-TEA, and for the control task the 4 AeroPath test volumes.

In the original task order, the structures are trained in the sequence lateral tibial cartilage, medial tibial cartilage, femoral cartilage, patellar cartilage, medial meniscus and lateral meniscus; this order was chosen at random. The reverse order serves as a second task order, to check whether the results depend on the order in which the structures are learned. Sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA and shared LoRA were trained in both orders (Table 6.1). We did not train further orders, because every additional order requires a complete run of each strategy, which our time and compute budget did not allow.

In the few-shot settings, every task is trained on the first $k \in \{5, 10, 20\}$ volumes of its training split instead of all 108 (Section 4.3). These values correspond to about 5, 10 and 20 % of the training split (exactly 4.6, 9.3 and 18.5 %). The sets are nested and drawn once; Section A.1 lists the volumes of each set and the test volumes. The number of epochs stays $E = 10$ in all settings, so a task is trained with $10k$ updates, that is 50, 100 or 200, instead of 1,080 with the full split. The few-shot settings therefore reduce both the amount of labelled data and the number of updates. To separate the two, sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA and shared LoRA were also trained with $k = 5$ and $E = 216$ epochs, which gives the 1,080 updates per task of the full split (equal-updates runs), and only every 24th epoch is validated in these runs (Section 5.3). We ran this ablation for $k = 5$ only, the setting with the largest difference in updates, because of the compute it needs; for $k = 10$ and $k = 20$, data and updates remain confounded. Joint fine-tuning was trained with the same $k$ volumes per structure, that is, with $6k$ volumes in its single stage.

### 6.1.3 Training and Evaluation Configuration

Table 6.2 lists the settings that all runs share, and Table 6.3 the parameters of each strategy. Both tables are generated from the configuration files of the runs; the few values that are defaults of the code, such as the fraction of foreground-centred patches, are checked against the code by the same script. Each run was trained on one NVIDIA A100 GPU with 40 GB of memory on the TinyGPU cluster, where a job may run for at most 24 hours.

The software environment comprises PyTorch 2.8.0 with CUDA 12.6 and cuDNN 9.10.2, MONAI 1.5.2, nnU-Net 2.7.0, Transformers 4.57.6, NumPy 2.4.3 and NiBabel 5.4.2. The runs did not log these versions; they were read from the environment on 22 October 2026, and we cannot rule out that packages were updated between the earlier runs and this date. Training is deterministic for a given configuration, and a run that was continued at a task boundary reproduces an uninterrupted one exactly: evaluated at the same checkpoint, the reruns of sequential fine-tuning with 5, 10 and 20 volumes and in the reverse order reproduce the evaluation matrices of the earlier runs with the same configuration in every entry. A run that was continued inside a task, however, draws its training samples and patches in a different order from that point on, so it is valid but not reproducible from its configuration alone; this concerns five runs of the comparison of the strategies and of the few-shot experiment, in each case from the task in which the job was resumed. Training a full-data run took between 18.1 and 26.4 hours, and 37.1 hours for the distillation-based strategy; runs that reached the 24-hour limit were continued in a second job, and the peak GPU memory was between 20.3 and 37.9 GiB (Section 6.7). These numbers are why we train with a batch size of one and $E = 10$ epochs per task (Section 5.3).

defense: software versions not logged per run; read from the environment on 2026-10-22

For the comparison of the strategies, we use rank $r = 4$ for task-specific LoRA and $r = 1024$ for shared LoRA. We chose these ranks after comparing the runs of the rank experiment, whose results are computed on the same test volumes as all other results; Section 6.3 gives the reasons. The choice therefore favours the two LoRA configurations in the comparison, and we report the run with $r = 8$ for task-specific LoRA as well, so that the alternative is visible.

author: same reason as in Sec. 5.3; with the reruns, several full-data runs needed a second job

All runs are evaluated with the parameters after the last epoch (Section 5.3). In the additional evaluation with the checkpoint of the lowest validation loss, this checkpoint came from the last epoch in only 8 of the 46 trained tasks of the 11 runs with ten epochs per task, and in none of the six tasks of the equal-updates run of sequential fine-tuning. The selected epoch was epoch 8 in 28 tasks, and the same few epochs (2, 6, 8, 9 and 10) recur across runs and tasks. Since the validation patches are drawn with the same seed in every task (Section 5.3), this pattern suggests that the selected epoch depends on which patches are drawn as much as on the model; we did not test this.

defense: main-comparison ranks chosen on test-split results (optimistic bias)

### 6.1.4 Metrics and Statistical Analysis

We report the five metrics of Section 3.4. Three of them are primary, because the research question asks how strategies trade adaptation against forgetting: Adaptation, Final For-

defense: selected

getting and the control-task drop. The control-task drop matters for a universal model, whose value lies in the many structures it can segment beyond the tasks it is adapted to. Final Forgetting and the control-task drop together measure retention, within and outside the task sequence; retention is therefore a property we measure with these two metrics, not a metric of its own. Final Performance, the quality of the model that the sequence delivers, and Transfer are secondary. Because the structures that come first differ between task orders, we compare Transfer only within one task order. Backward transfer appears as negative Final Forgetting (Section 3.4) and needs no metric of its own. We do not report the Average Performance of ZSCL, the mean over all entries of stages 1 to $T$, because it mixes adaptation, retention and transfer into one number that none of our questions asks for.

For task-specific LoRA, Final Forgetting and the control-task drop are zero by construction, because each task is evaluated with its own adapter and the control task with the unchanged pretrained model (Section 5.2). For this strategy, the comparison rests on Adaptation and Final Performance. For joint fine-tuning, which has no task sequence, only Final Performance and the control-task drop are defined (Section 5.2). Every table also contains the pretrained-model reference row of Section 5.2. All values are mean DSC fractions, reported with three decimals.

Each configuration was trained once, so we cannot estimate how results vary with the training randomness or with the choice of training volumes. The only variability we can estimate is that over the test volumes, and we do so with a bootstrap [Efr+93]. In each of $N_{\text{boot}} = 2000$ draws, the 24 SKM-TEA test volumes are resampled with replacement, the same draw is used for all tasks and all stages, and the 4 control-task volumes are resampled separately; every metric is then recomputed from the resampled means. We report the 2.5 and 97.5 percentiles of the resampled values as a 95 % interval [Efr+93] in the figures; the tables show the values on the full test set. With only 4 control-task volumes, the intervals of the control-task drop are coarse.

Two runs are evaluated on the same test volumes, so their errors are correlated, and two overlapping intervals do not show that the runs perform alike. For the difference between two runs, we therefore apply the same draws to both runs and compute the interval of the difference (paired bootstrap). We read these intervals only for comparisons that follow from the design of the experiments in Table 6.1: each strategy against sequential fine-tuning, each few-shot setting against the full training split of the same strategy, each equal-updates run against the same strategy with $k = 5$ and with the full split, the reverse against the

original task order of the same strategy, a strategy with a component against the same strategy without it, each additional evaluation against the main evaluation of the same run, and joint fine-tuning against each strategy in Final Performance and the control-task drop. For the LoRA rank, we describe the trend over the ranks instead of comparing pairs of ranks, and differences between two continual-learning strategies are reported only descriptively. With the runs of this chapter, this gives 34 pairs and 152 comparisons. The intervals are not adjusted for this number of comparisons and describe the uncertainty due to the choice of test volumes only, so we do not use them as significance tests and do not call any difference significant. How large the variation between training runs can be compared with these intervals is shown by two runs of task-specific LoRA that differ only in their random initialisation (Section 6.6).

## 6.2 Comparison of the Strategies

This experiment asks how the strategies trade adaptation against forgetting when each task is trained on the full training split. We trained sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$), shared LoRA ($r = 1024$), the prompt-tuning strategy and the distillation-based strategy in the original task order, and shared LoRA with replay as a sixth configuration (Table 6.1). Joint fine-tuning, trained on all six tasks at once, serves as the upper reference (Section 5.2). All runs are evaluated with the parameters after the last epoch of each task. Table 6.4 gives all metrics, Figure 6.1 shows them with their bootstrap intervals, and Figure 6.2 shows the evaluation matrices from which they are computed.

In the primary metrics, the strategies fall into two groups, with the prompt-tuning strategy between them. Sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy reached the highest Adaptation, 0.781 and 0.747, but forgot most of what they had learned: their Final Forgetting is 0.782 and 0.734, and the DSC on the control task fell from 0.979 to at most 0.0003, a control-task drop of 0.979 for both. The two LoRA strategies adapted less, with 0.485 for task-specific and 0.471 for shared LoRA, and retained much more: task-specific LoRA forgets nothing by construction, and shared LoRA reached a Final Forgetting of 0.289 and a control-task drop of 0.237. Against sequential fine-tuning, the paired differences in Adaptation are $-0.296$ $[-0.319, -0.273]$ for task-specific and $-0.311$ $[-0.324, -0.295]$ for shared LoRA, and the difference in Final Forgetting is $-0.492$ $[-0.509, -0.474]$ for shared LoRA. The prompt-tuning strategy reached an Adaptation of 0.580, a Final Forgetting of 0.510 and a control-task drop of 0.865.

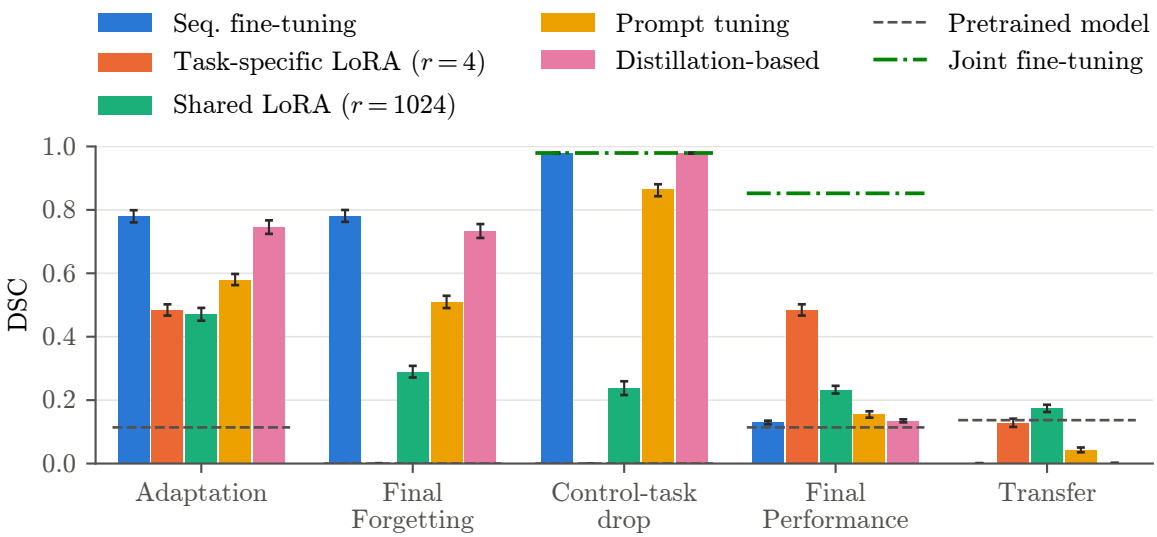



Figure 6.1: Metrics of the five strategies of Table 6.4 without replay, with 95 % bootstrap intervals over the test volumes (Section 6.1.4). Dashed line: pretrained model; dash-dotted line: joint fine-tuning, shown for the two metrics defined for it.

After the last task, sequential fine-tuning, the distillation-based and the prompt-tuning strategy segment little beyond the structure trained last. Their Final Performance of 0.130, 0.135 and 0.155 is only slightly above the 0.114 of the pretrained model, and they lost femoral cartilage, which the pretrained model already segmented with a DSC of 0.684 and which ends at 0.010 or less (Figure 6.2). Outside the diagonal, the matrices of sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy are close to zero; the only entry above 0.2 is femoral cartilage after the patellar task in the distillation-based strategy (0.25). The prompt-tuning strategy keeps more outside the diagonal, with seven entries between 0.20 and 0.49, the highest of them femoral cartilage after the patellar task. Among the strategies without replay, task-specific LoRA reached the highest Final Performance, 0.485, because each task keeps its own adapter, and shared LoRA reached 0.233.

Figure 6.3 shows when the control task was lost. For sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy, the DSC on the lung fell to 0.002 or less after the first task and did not recover. The prompt-tuning strategy fell to 0.04 after the first task and then stayed between 0.04 and 0.23. Shared LoRA kept the control task between 0.955 and 0.980 up to the fifth task, and most of its control-task drop arose in the last step (Section 6.6).

The distillation-based strategy forgot slightly less than sequential fine-tuning. Its Final Forgetting was 0.048 lower $[0.039, 0.055]$ at an Adaptation lower by 0.035 $[0.027, 0.041]$, its Final Performance was 0.005 higher $[0.001, 0.009]$, and its control-task drop was the same.

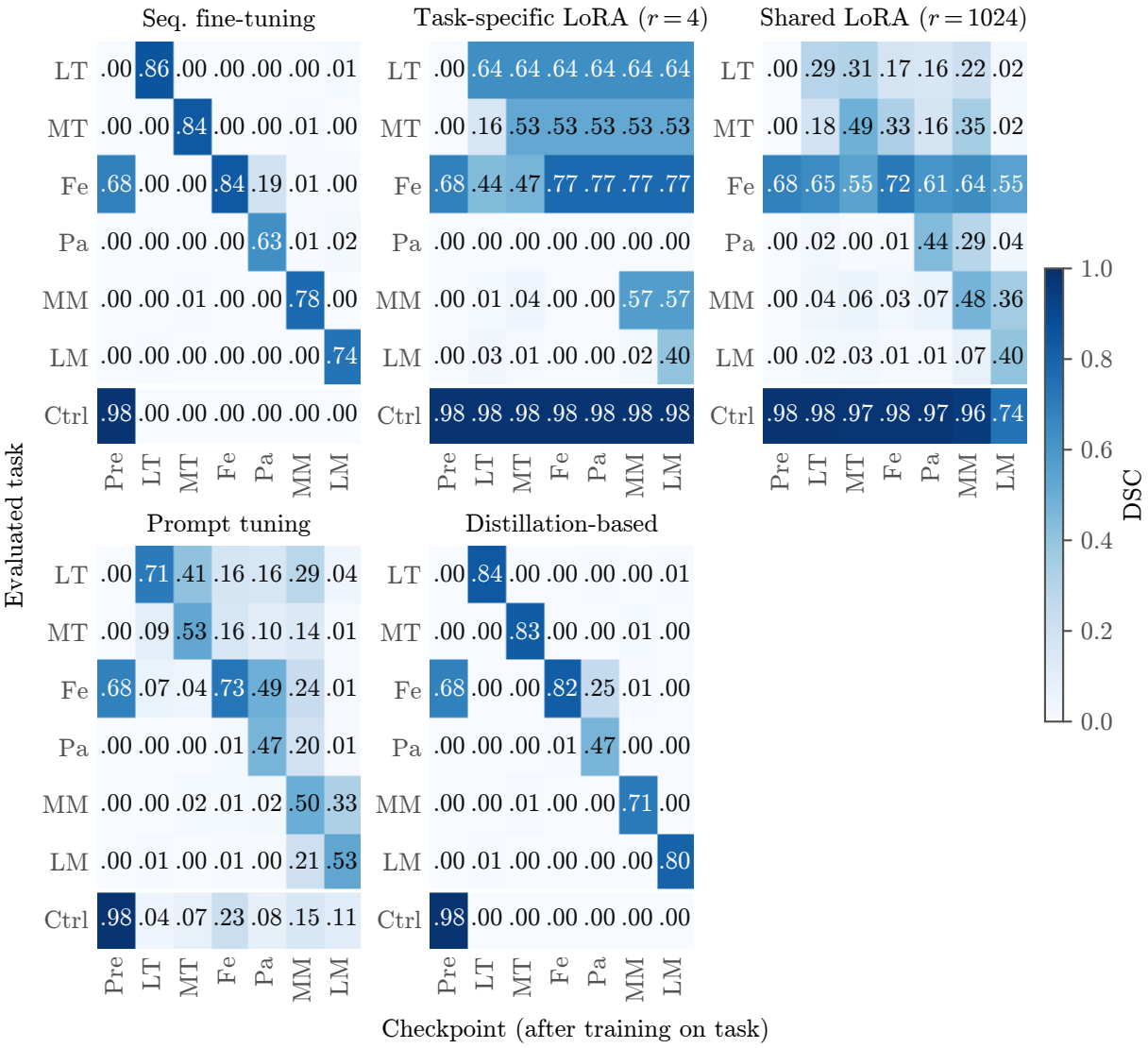



Figure 6.2: Evaluation matrices of the five strategies without replay: mean DSC of each task (rows) at each checkpoint (columns), from the pretrained model (Pre) to the model after the last task. LT, MT: lateral and medial tibial cartilage; Fe: femoral cartilage; Pa: patellar cartilage; MM, LM: medial and lateral meniscus; Ctrl: control task (lung, AeroPath).

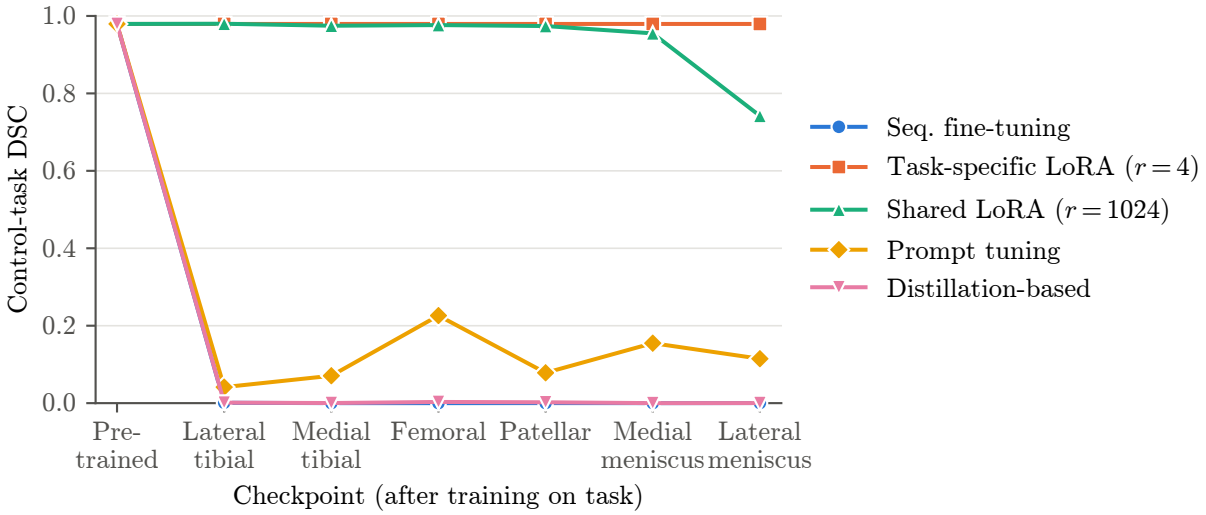



Figure 6.3: DSC on the control task (lung, AeroPath) at each checkpoint of the five strategies without replay. Task-specific LoRA evaluates the control task with the unchanged pretrained model. The curves of sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy lie on top of each other.

These differences are small against the gap to the LoRA strategies. They hold for the evaluated configuration, with a distillation weight $\lambda = 0.01$ that is much smaller than that of ZSCL and was not tuned, and with distillation on the current task's data (Section 5.4.4); they do not show that feature distillation cannot reduce forgetting more in this setting. The training logs record only the total loss, so we cannot determine how much the distillation term contributed to it.

defense: distillation weight lambda = 0.01 untuned; distillation term not logged separately; result holds only for this configuration

The prompt-tuning strategy keeps all pretrained weights frozen and trains 12.6 million parameters, a quarter of the 50.3 million of shared LoRA (Table 6.10). Against sequential fine-tuning, it forgot less, by 0.272 $[0.253, 0.293]$ in Final Forgetting, at an Adaptation lower by 0.201 $[0.185, 0.218]$, and its control-task drop was lower by 0.114 $[0.097, 0.137]$, but it still lost most of the control task. Because the learned prompt tokens and the meta-net change the keys, values and query for every text prompt, the frozen backbone does not keep the outputs for other text prompts unchanged (Section 5.4.5); whether this explains the loss was not tested (Section 7.1).

In Transfer, the LoRA strategies, with 0.129 and 0.174, stayed close to the pretrained model with 0.137, whereas sequential fine-tuning, the distillation-based and the prompt-tuning strategy reached 0.001, 0.002 and 0.043: before a task was trained, they segmented almost none of it, including femoral cartilage, which the pretrained model segments.

Replay lowered the forgetting of shared LoRA without changing its Adaptation. With replay, Final Forgetting was 0.046 instead of 0.289 ($-0.243$, $[-0.259, -0.226]$) and Final Performance 0.450 instead of 0.233 ($+0.218$, $[0.203, 0.231]$), while Adaptation differed by only 0.001 $[-0.002, 0.004]$. Its Final Performance is the highest of all strategies that use one parameter set for all tasks and is 0.034 $[0.011, 0.059]$ below that of task-specific LoRA, which needs the task identity at inference. At the end of the sequence, every structure was still segmented, with a DSC between 0.38 for medial tibial cartilage and 0.70 for femoral cartilage. Replay also lowered the control-task drop, from 0.237 to 0.138 ($-0.100$, $[-0.103, -0.096]$), although the memory holds no control-task samples (Section 5.4.3). As without replay, most of the drop arose in the last task, in which the DSC on the lung fell from 0.931 to 0.842, against 0.955 to 0.742 without replay. In that task, 55 of the 163 samples of an epoch came from the memory, so the adapter was trained on a mixture of structures; whether this is why it specialised less to the last task, and thereby lost less of the control task, was not tested. Because the drop is concentrated in the last task, this effect may also depend on the task order (Section 6.6).

defense: replay lowers the control-task drop although the memory holds no control samples; explanation (mixture of structures in the last task) not tested; may depend on the task order

Joint fine-tuning reached a Final Performance of 0.852, with a DSC between 0.834 for patellar cartilage and 0.873 for femoral cartilage. This is 0.367 $[0.345, 0.389]$ more than task-specific LoRA and 0.722 $[0.710, 0.734]$ more than sequential fine-tuning, and it shows how far all strategies remain from what the same model reaches when it sees all tasks at once. Joint fine-tuning lost the control task as completely as sequential fine-tuning, with a drop of 0.979, although it receives the same number of updates and is trained without a task sequence. The loss of the control task therefore comes from fine-tuning all parameters on the knee structures, not from training the structures one after another.

Table 6.5 shows the additional evaluations of Section 5.3. For sequential fine-tuning, the checkpoint with the lowest validation loss reached an Adaptation 0.059 lower $[0.053, 0.065]$ and a Final Forgetting 0.070 lower $[0.063, 0.077]$ than the parameters after the last epoch, at the same Final Performance; for the distillation-based and the prompt-tuning strategy, the two evaluations differ by at most 0.005. The checkpoint selection on a noisy validation loss (Section 6.1.3) thus lowers the Adaptation of sequential fine-tuning, and evaluating the last epoch avoids this.

The weight ensemble of the distillation-based strategy halved its Adaptation, from 0.747 to 0.376 ($-0.371$, $[-0.385, -0.356]$), lowered its Final Performance by 0.011 $[0.007, 0.017]$ and did not change its control-task drop. Its Final Forgetting is lower, 0.354 instead of 0.734, only because it learned less in the first place: right after training, its DSC fell from

0.828 on the first task to 0.219 on the fourth and to 0.002 and 0.000 on the last two. A possible explanation follows from the ensemble's definition: as the equally weighted mean of $\theta_0$ and all snapshots, with 100 snapshots per task, a snapshot taken in the last task enters with a weight of about 1/600, so the ensemble stays close to the earlier states and hardly follows later tasks. It does not protect the control task, because the student had already lost it after the first task (DSC 0.001) and the ensemble mainly averages such states. ZSCL updates its ensemble every 100 iterations and distils on a reference dataset (Section 5.4.4), so these results apply to our configuration only.

defense: weight ensemble with an interval of 10 and without reference dataset; explanation of the low Adaptation (weights of late snapshots) not tested

The per-task gradient scaling of the prompt-tuning strategy lowered its forgetting. At the best validation checkpoint of both runs, the run with scaling forgot 0.063 less $[0.052, 0.074]$, lost 0.117 less of the control task $[0.100, 0.139]$ and reached a Final Performance higher by 0.020 $[0.014, 0.025]$, at an Adaptation lower by 0.032 $[0.025, 0.040]$. Without scaling, the DSC on the lung fell to 0.019 after the second task and to 0.000 at the end; with scaling, it stayed between 0.04 and 0.23. Scaling the steps down in later tasks thus traded a little adaptation for retention, but it did not keep the control task.

No strategy combined the Adaptation of sequential fine-tuning with the retention of the LoRA strategies. The strategies that update all parameters reached the highest Adaptation and left a model that segments little beyond the last task and has lost the control task and femoral cartilage, abilities of the pretrained model. Joint fine-tuning shows that the loss of the control task does not require a task sequence: with the same number of updates on all six tasks at once, the model lost it as well, while it reached a Final Performance far above every strategy. The prompt-tuning strategy lies between the two groups, and gradient scaling moved it towards retention; freezing the backbone alone did not preserve the control task. Retention came with the LoRA strategies, at an Adaptation about 0.30 lower than that of sequential fine-tuning. Part of this gap comes from the training configuration rather than from the strategies, because the LoRA strategies were limited by the ten epochs per task (Section 6.4), so the trade-off is probably less steep than these runs show. If the task identity is available at inference, task-specific LoRA gave the highest Final Performance; without it, shared LoRA with replay came within 0.034 of it and kept most of the control task.

defense: one run per strategy; conclusion drafted from

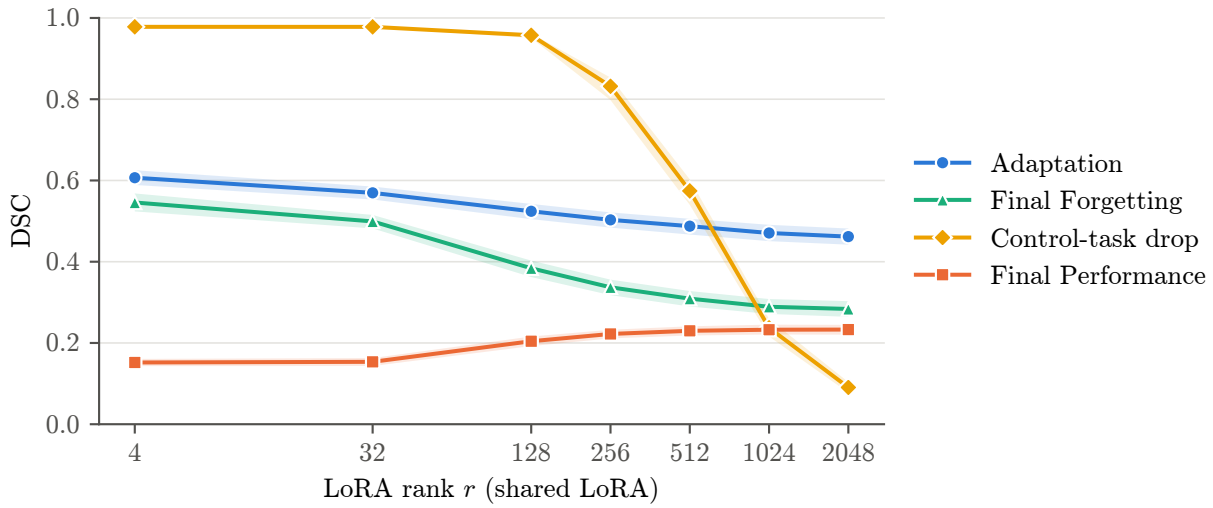



Figure 6.4: Metrics of shared LoRA over the rank $r$ (logarithmic axis). Shaded bands: 95 % bootstrap intervals over the test volumes (Section 6.1.4).

## 6.3 LoRA Rank

This experiment asks how the rank of the LoRA adapters affects adaptation and forgetting. We trained shared LoRA with seven ranks from $r = 4$ to $r = 2048$ and task-specific LoRA with $r = 4$ and $r = 8$, all on the full training split in the original task order (Table 6.1). In shared LoRA, $\alpha = 32$ is the same for all ranks, so the scaling factor $\gamma_r = \alpha/\sqrt{r}$ falls from 16 at $r = 4$ to 0.71 at $r = 2048$ (Table 6.3). Table 6.6 gives all metrics, and Figure 6.4 shows the trend for shared LoRA.

For shared LoRA, the metrics change monotonically with the rank. From $r = 4$ to $r = 2048$, Adaptation falls from 0.607 to 0.462, while Final Forgetting falls from 0.546 to 0.284 and the control-task drop from 0.978 to 0.091. Final Performance rises from 0.152 to 0.233 and stays at this level from $r = 512$ on, and Transfer rises from 0.045 to about 0.17 from $r = 128$ on. These changes are several times larger than the bootstrap intervals of the individual runs, which are about $\pm 0.02$ (Figure 6.4). The control-task drop changes most: up to $r = 32$, the lung is no longer segmented at all after the last task, and it is largely kept only at the two highest ranks.

The gain in Final Performance comes from two structures. Femoral cartilage, which the pretrained model already segments with a DSC of 0.684, is lost by the end of the sequence at low ranks but kept at 0.55 from $r = 512$ on, whereas lateral tibial, medial tibial and patellar cartilage end below 0.06 at every rank. The fall in Adaptation comes mostly from the first task, lateral tibial cartilage, whose DSC right after training falls from 0.69 at $r = 4$

to 0.28 at $r = 2048$; the other tasks lose at most 0.17. The weak first task recurs in the task-order experiment (Section 6.6).

For task-specific LoRA, $r = 8$ reached a lower Adaptation than $r = 4$ (0.404 against 0.485). The difference comes from lateral tibial cartilage (0.52 against 0.64) and lateral meniscus (0.12 against 0.40), while the other tasks differ by at most 0.05. Patellar cartilage was not learned at either rank (DSC 0.00 right after training). Each rank was trained once, so we cannot determine whether such differences between single tasks come from the rank or from the training randomness.

Because $\alpha$ is fixed, the rank and the scaling factor change together in the shared-LoRA runs, so this experiment does not separate the effect of the adapter's capacity from that of its scale, and we did not compare $\gamma_r$ with the scaling $\alpha/r$ of the original LoRA.

defense: rank and $\gamma_r$ confounded in the shared-LoRA rank ablation (alpha fixed); rsLoRA intends rank-stable training, not tested here

For shared LoRA, the rank sets a trade-off between adaptation and retention: higher ranks forget less, both of the trained tasks and of the control task, at a moderate cost in Adaptation, and Final Performance stops improving from $r = 512$ on. Why higher ranks retain more remains open. rsLoRA chooses the factor $1/\sqrt{r}$ so that the magnitude of the adapter's outputs and gradients does not depend on the rank [Kal23, Sec. 3], so smaller updates at higher rank are not what this scaling is meant to produce; this experiment cannot determine whether capacity, scale or both cause the trend. For the comparison of the strategies we use $r = 1024$. It has half the trainable parameters of $r = 2048$ (50.3 against 100.7 million) and the same Final Performance, and its Adaptation and Final Forgetting differ by less than 0.01. The control-task drop, however, still falls from 0.237 to 0.091 between the two ranks, so the comparison of the strategies understates how much of the control task shared LoRA can keep. For task-specific LoRA, doubling the rank brought no gain in this run.

defense: r = 1024 chosen for parameter count and saturation of Adaptation, Final

## 6.4 Diagnosis of the Patellar Failure

Task-specific LoRA did not learn patellar cartilage in the task sequence: the DSC right after training on it was 0.000 at both ranks (Section 6.3), although shared LoRA reached 0.44 to 0.51 on the same task. The pretrained model also segments patellar cartilage with a DSC of 0.000, and task-specific LoRA starts every task from this model, whereas the shared adapter has already been trained on three tasks when it reaches patellar cartilage. To find the cause, we trained task-specific LoRA on patellar cartilage alone, first with the settings of the sequence and then changing one setting at a time: the rank ($r = 16$), the learning

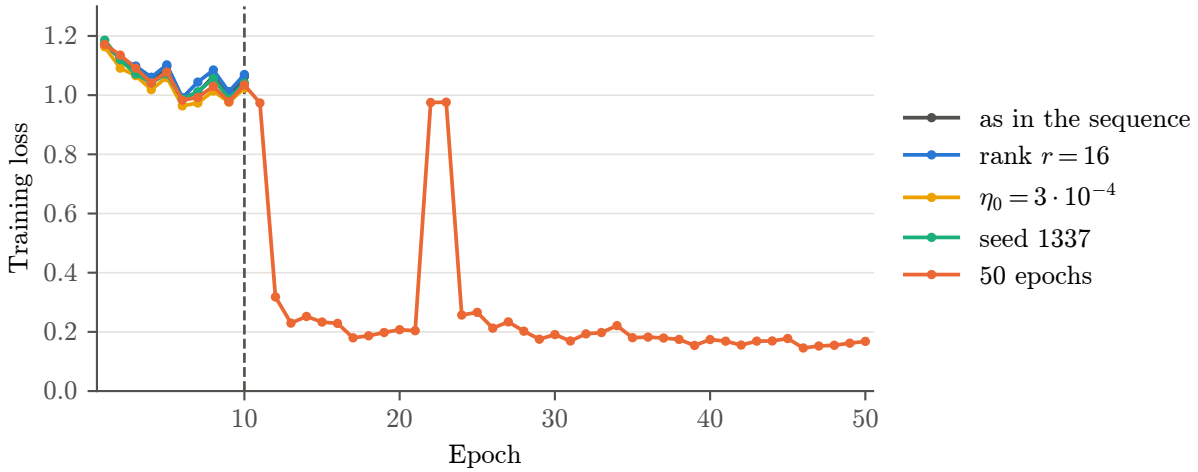



Figure 6.5: Mean training loss per epoch of the runs of Table 6.7. The four runs with 10 epochs lie on top of each other. Dashed line: end of training in the task sequence (epoch 10).

rate ($\eta_0 = 3 \cdot 10^{-4}$), the training seed and the number of epochs (50 instead of 10). Each change tests one explanation: too little capacity, too small steps, an unlucky initialisation or too little training. Apart from the changed setting and the single task, the runs use the configuration of the sequence. Table 6.7 gives the results and Figure 6.5 the training loss.

With 10 epochs, every run ended with a DSC of 0.000, whether with the settings of the sequence, a four times larger rank, a three times larger learning rate or another seed. With 50 epochs, the same configuration reached 0.839. The training loss explains the difference: it stays at about 1.0 during the first ten epochs in every run, close to its value for an empty prediction, for which the Dice term alone is 1; only in the 50-epoch run does it drop, from 0.97 at epoch 11 to 0.32 at epoch 12, and it then stays at about 0.2. At epoch 22, the loss of this run jumps back to about 1.0 for two epochs and then returns to its previous level.

Ten epochs were therefore too few for task-specific LoRA to leave the empty prediction on patellar cartilage, while capacity, step size and seed were not the cause in these runs. The 50-epoch run differs from the others in two ways, however: it has five times as many updates, and its learning rate decays over these 5,400 updates, so that at epoch 10 it is still at 80 % of $\eta_0$, while in the 10-epoch runs it has reached almost zero. The experiment does not separate these two effects. For the comparison of the strategies, the result means that the Adaptation of task-specific LoRA is limited by the training length of the shared configuration (Section 6.1.3) and not only by the strategy itself.

defense: shared training configuration (10 epochs)

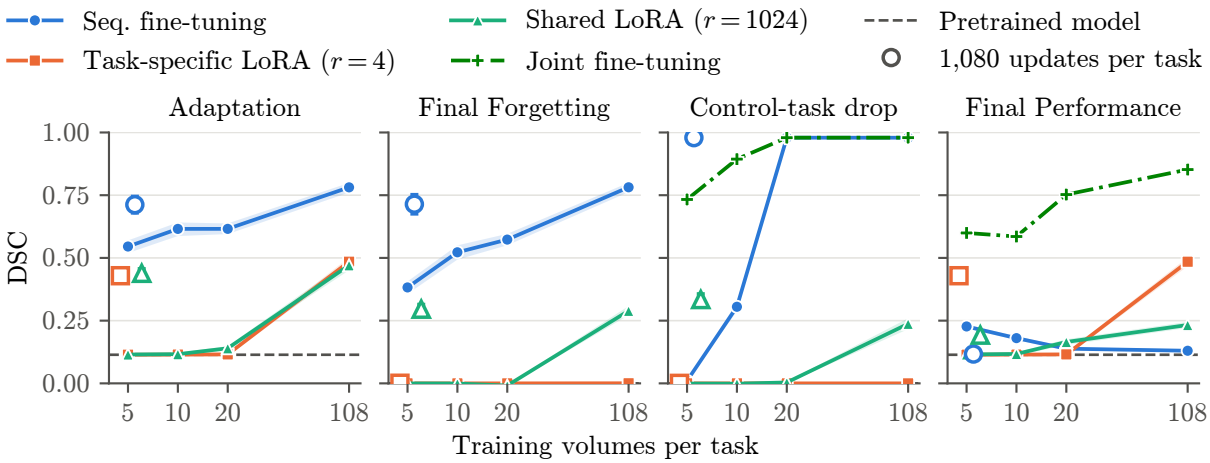



Figure 6.6: Metrics over the number of training volumes per task, with 95 % bootstrap intervals (Section 6.1.4). Filled markers and solid lines: ten epochs per task; hollow markers at 5 volumes: equal-updates runs with 1,080 updates per task, shifted slightly to the side for legibility. Dash-dotted line: joint fine-tuning, shown for the two metrics defined for it. Dashed line: pretrained model.

## 6.5 Amount of Labelled Data

This experiment asks how the amount of labelled data affects adaptation and forgetting. Sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) and shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) were trained with $k = 5$, 10 and 20 training volumes per task and compared with the same strategy on the full training split (Section 6.1.2). Because the number of epochs is fixed, the few-shot runs also receive fewer updates: 50, 100 and 200 per task instead of 1,080. The equal-updates runs with $k = 5$ and 1,080 updates per task separate the two factors for this setting, and joint fine-tuning with the same $k$ serves as the reference (Section 6.1.2). Table 6.8 gives all metrics and Figure 6.6 the main ones.

Sequential fine-tuning learned every task in all three few-shot settings, and with fewer volumes it forgot less. With $k = 5$, its Adaptation was 0.545, lower by 0.236 $[0.217, 0.255]$ than with the full split, while its Final Forgetting was 0.382 instead of 0.782 and it kept the control task, with a drop of 0.010 instead of 0.979. Its Final Performance was therefore higher than with the full split, 0.227 against 0.130 (difference 0.097, $[0.090, 0.104]$), close to the 0.233 of shared LoRA on the full split (Section 6.2), and it ended with a DSC of 0.42 on femoral cartilage, which the full-split run lost. With $k = 10$ and $k = 20$, the metrics lie between these two: Adaptation 0.616 in both, Final Forgetting 0.522 and 0.573, Final Performance 0.180 and 0.138. The control task was lost gradually with $k = 10$, down to

0.435 after the fifth task and 0.674 at the end (drop 0.305), and within two tasks with $k = 20$ (0.587 after the first, 0.005 after the second), as with the full split after the first task.

With 5 and 10 volumes per task, neither LoRA strategy learned any task. Their Adaptation of 0.114 to 0.116 equals that of the pretrained model (0.114), and the evaluation matrices show why: right after training, every structure except femoral cartilage has a DSC of 0.00, and femoral cartilage stays at the 0.69 to 0.70 that the pretrained model already reaches. Final Forgetting and the control-task drop are therefore zero for both strategies as well. With 20 volumes, task-specific LoRA still did not learn any task, while shared LoRA began to: its Adaptation rose to 0.140 and its Final Performance to 0.165, with DSC values of 0.12 for medial tibial cartilage, 0.09 for patellar cartilage and 0.07 for medial meniscus at the end of the sequence. Its Final Forgetting is slightly negative ($-0.009$), because these values rose further while later tasks were trained. With the full training split, the two strategies reached an Adaptation of 0.485 and 0.471 (Section 6.3).

The equal-updates runs show that the number of updates, not the number of volumes, explains most of this failure at $k = 5$. With 1,080 updates per task on 5 volumes, task-specific and shared LoRA reached an Adaptation of 0.429 and 0.438, higher by 0.315 $[0.293, 0.334]$ and 0.323 $[0.306, 0.341]$ than with 50 updates and lower by only 0.056 $[0.040, 0.073]$ and 0.032 $[0.025, 0.039]$ than with the full split. Task-specific LoRA again did not learn patellar cartilage (DSC 0.000 right after training), in agreement with Section 6.4, where 1,080 updates were not enough for this structure. With more updates, shared LoRA also forgot again: its Final Forgetting of 0.296 equals that of the full split within $[-0.007, 0.018]$, and its control-task drop of 0.334 is 0.097 higher. Sequential fine-tuning with 1,080 updates on 5 volumes reached an Adaptation of 0.712, 0.167 $[0.142, 0.190]$ more than with 50 updates, and forgot as much as with the full split: Final Forgetting 0.714, control-task drop 0.979 and Final Performance 0.117.

Joint fine-tuning reached a Final Performance of 0.600, 0.585 and 0.753 with 5, 10 and 20 volumes per structure, against 0.852 with the full split. Between $k = 5$ and $k = 10$, no difference can be detected ($-0.014$, $[-0.037, 0.013]$); with one draw of volumes per setting, we do not interpret this. With 5 volumes, joint fine-tuning ended 0.373 $[0.334, 0.406]$ above sequential fine-tuning and 0.170 $[0.131, 0.205]$ above task-specific LoRA with equal updates. Its control-task drop rose with the amount of training, from 0.733 with $k = 5$ over 0.894 with $k = 10$ to 0.979 with $k = 20$ and with the full split, for 300, 600 and 1,200 updates in total.

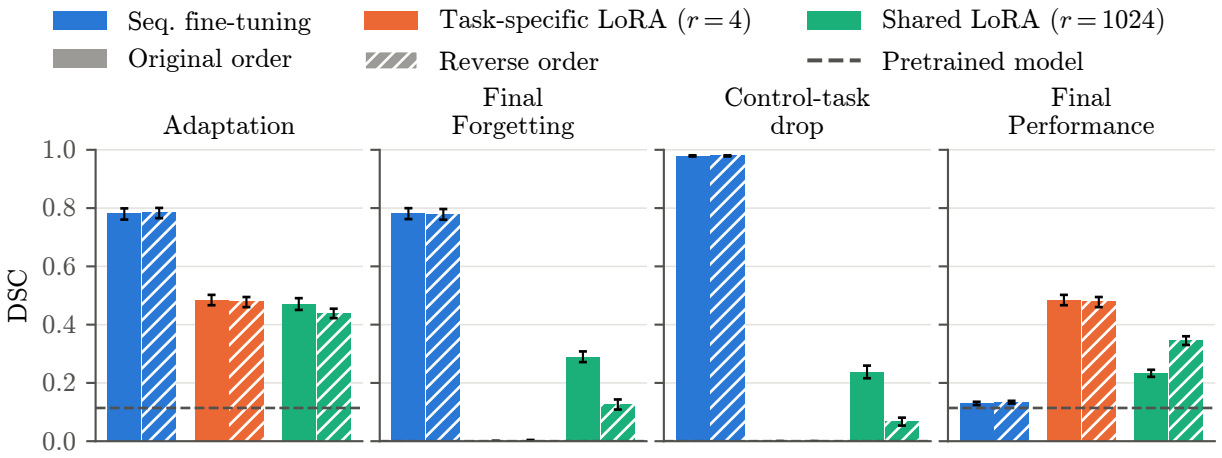



Figure 6.7: Metrics in the original (plain bars) and the reverse task order (hatched bars), with 95 % bootstrap intervals. Dashed line: pretrained model.

With ten epochs per task, sequential fine-tuning was the only strategy that learned the tasks under few-shot conditions, and the LoRA strategies did not move away from the pretrained model within 50 to 200 updates per task. At $k = 5$, the fixed epoch budget explains most of the failure of the LoRA strategies: with the update count of the full split, they came within 0.06 of their full-split Adaptation. For sequential fine-tuning, the lower forgetting and the kept control task with few volumes are consistent with an effect of the number of updates rather than of the amount of data: with 1,080 updates on 5 volumes, it forgot as much and lost the control task as completely as with the full split, and the control-task drop of joint fine-tuning also rose with the number of updates. With 5 volumes per task, sequential fine-tuning reached about the Final Performance of shared LoRA on the full split; we read this as a higher Final Performance of a less trained model, not as a benefit of less data. These conclusions rest on the separation at $k = 5$, with one draw of volumes, one run per configuration and a learning rate that was not tuned; for $k = 10$ and $k = 20$, data and updates remain confounded.

defense: data and updates separated only at k = 5; one support set; one seed; learning rate untuned

## 6.6 Task Order

This experiment asks whether the results depend on the order in which the structures are learned. Sequential fine-tuning, task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) and shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) were trained in the original and in the reverse task order on the full training split (Section 6.1.2). Table 6.9 gives all metrics and Figure 6.7 the main ones.

For sequential fine-tuning, no effect of the task order can be detected. In the reverse order, Adaptation was 0.003 higher $[-0.005, 0.010]$, Final Forgetting 0.002 lower $[-0.009, 0.005]$ and Final Performance 0.004 higher $[-0.002, 0.010]$; in both orders, it forgot almost all earlier tasks (Final Forgetting 0.782 and 0.780) and lost the control task after the first task (DSC 0.001 and 0.000). Only Transfer differed, 0.014 instead of 0.001 (+0.013, $[0.012, 0.014]$), which is small in absolute terms. Unlike shared LoRA, sequential fine-tuning learned the first task well in both orders, lateral tibial cartilage with 0.86 and lateral meniscus with 0.83.

For task-specific LoRA, the task order changes nothing in the training of a task: every task starts from the pretrained model with a new adapter, trained on the same data with the same settings, and the random seed is reset at the start of every task (Section 5.4.2). What does change is the state of the random-number generator when the adapter is created, because the adapter is initialised before the seed is reset, so each task gets a different random initialisation in the two orders; in addition, the training allows non-deterministic GPU operations. The two runs therefore show how much a single run varies with its initialisation. Five of the six tasks reached the same DSC within 0.01, while lateral meniscus reached 0.40 in the original and 0.34 in the reverse order, so that Adaptation differs by 0.006 (0.485 against 0.478). The paired bootstrap interval of this difference, $[0.004, 0.008]$, does not contain zero, although the difference comes only from the initialisation and the non-determinism of training. This illustrates the limit stated in Section 6.1.4: the intervals reflect the choice of test volumes, not the variation between training runs, and differences of this size between single runs should not be read as effects of a factor.

defense: paired intervals exclude zero for a pure re-initialisation difference (task-specific LoRA original vs reverse); training variability not covered

For shared LoRA, the reverse order led to clearly better retention. Final Forgetting was 0.124 instead of 0.289 and the control-task drop 0.067 instead of 0.237, and Final Performance rose from 0.233 to 0.345, while Adaptation was 0.032 lower (0.439 against 0.471); the paired intervals of these four differences are about $\pm 0.01$ to $\pm 0.02$ wide. In both orders, the first task was learned poorly: lateral tibial cartilage reached 0.29 right after training in the original order and lateral meniscus 0.01 in the reverse order, whereas the same structures reached 0.51 and 0.40 when trained later in the other order. At the end of the reverse sequence, every structure is still segmented to some degree, from 0.13 for lateral meniscus to 0.51 for lateral tibial cartilage, whereas in the original order three of the six structures end below 0.05. Transfer is about the same in both orders (0.169 and 0.174).

In the original order, most of the forgetting and of the control-task drop arose in the last step. Up to the fifth task, the DSC on the control task stayed between 0.955 and 0.980;

training on lateral meniscus lowered it to 0.742, and in the same step lateral tibial cartilage fell from 0.22 to 0.02, medial tibial cartilage from 0.35 to 0.02 and patellar cartilage from 0.29 to 0.04. In the reverse order, the last task, lateral tibial cartilage, lowered the control task only from 0.967 to 0.912, and femoral cartilage, which lost most in this step, from 0.65 to 0.50. Whether lateral meniscus causes this loss as a structure or through its position at the end of the sequence cannot be separated with two orders.

The training loss shows how the first task differs from the later ones. On the first task, the loss starts at about 1.0, its value for an empty prediction, and falls slowly: in the original order to 0.69 after ten epochs, in the reverse order only to 0.96. The second task starts much lower, at 0.81 and 0.86 in the first epoch, and falls to 0.56 in both orders, although in the reverse order the first task was hardly learned at all. With $r = 4$, by contrast, the loss of the first task falls to 0.74 within three epochs and to 0.38 after ten.

For sequential fine-tuning, the task order changed no metric beyond the bootstrap interval except Transfer, by 0.013, and it forgot almost everything in both orders. For task-specific LoRA, the task order has no effect beyond the variation between two runs, as its design implies. For shared LoRA, the task order has a strong effect: in the reverse order, the adapter kept clearly more of the earlier tasks and of the control task, at a slightly lower Adaptation. With two orders, we cannot determine which property of the order causes this difference in retention, and among the strategies tested, a strong effect of the order appeared only for shared LoRA. In both orders, the first task was learned poorly, and the training loss shows that its adapter had not left its initial state after ten epochs; a possible explanation, which connects this observation with the results of Sections 6.3 to 6.5, is discussed in Section 7.2.

## 6.7 Computational Cost

This section reports the measured cost of the strategies, which complements the complexity analysis of Section 5.5; the hardware is described in Section 6.1.3. Table 6.10 gives, for the runs of the comparison of the strategies, the number of trainable parameters, the time per epoch, the total time of the run, the evaluation time per volume and the peak GPU memory, all taken from the logs of the runs.

The two LoRA strategies and the prompt-tuning strategy took 18.1 to 19.8 minutes per epoch, 26 to 33 % less than sequential fine-tuning with 26.8 minutes, which agrees with their backward pass ending at the prompt decoder instead of reaching the image encoder

(Section 5.5). The earlier run of sequential fine-tuning with the same configuration took 23.7 minutes per epoch; we did not investigate this difference on the shared cluster. The distillation-based strategy took 37.1 minutes per epoch, 1.4 times as long as sequential fine-tuning, because every iteration adds a forward pass of the teacher and its transfer from CPU to GPU memory. A complete run, including its evaluations, took 20.8 and 22.6 hours for the two LoRA strategies, 24.0 hours for the prompt-tuning strategy, 32.5 hours for sequential fine-tuning and 47.1 hours for the distillation-based strategy, whose run includes three evaluations; all but the LoRA runs needed a second job. The peak GPU memory was 20.3 to 20.6 GiB for the parameter-efficient strategies, 31.4 GiB for sequential fine-tuning and 37.9 GiB for the distillation-based strategy, close to the 40 GB of the GPU.

For shared LoRA, the number of trainable parameters grows linearly with the rank, from 0.2 million at $r = 4$ to 100.7 million at $r = 2048$, while the time per epoch only rises from 18.9 to 21.0 minutes and the peak memory from 20.4 to 20.8 GiB. Replay increased the mean time per epoch of shared LoRA with $r = 1024$ from 19.8 to 26.4 minutes, because the replayed samples, up to 55 in the last task, add iterations to every epoch (Section 5.4.3). In the few-shot settings, an epoch of sequential fine-tuning took 3.1 to 6.5 minutes for $k = 5$ to $k = 20$, of which the validation on the 23 validation volumes, which does not depend on $k$, is a large part. The equal-updates runs, with 216 short epochs per task, took 18.4 to 24.3 hours of training, about as long as the full-data runs of the same strategies. Joint fine-tuning took about 2.3 hours per epoch with its 648 training volumes, about 23 hours for its ten epochs. After $T$ tasks, task-specific LoRA stores six adapters of 0.2 million parameters each, which is negligible compared with the model.

Evaluation took 7.7 to 8.8 seconds per volume in the runs of the task sequence, so that the 1,036 volume inferences of one evaluation of the protocol (Section 5.2) took about 2.2 to 2.5 hours. The forward pass has the same cost for all strategies (Section 5.5); the measured times also include loading the volumes and encoding the text prompts, and we did not investigate the differences between runs.

All strategies fit on a single 40 GB GPU. The parameter-efficient strategies are the cheapest to train, with about a fifth less time per epoch and a third less memory than sequential fine-tuning, and the distillation-based strategy is the most expensive in both time and memory. At inference, the strategies cost the same.

Table 6.1: Overview of the experiments. Each configuration was trained once. Training volumes per task: 108 is the full training split. Objective: number of the research objective in Section 1.3. All runs use the original task order unless stated otherwise.

| Experiment | Strategies and configurations | Training volumes per task | Objective | Section |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Comparison of the strategies | Seq. fine-tuning; Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$); Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$); Distillation-based; Prompt tuning | 108 | 2 | 6.2 |
| LoRA rank | Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4, 8$); Shared LoRA ($r = 4, 32, 128, 256, 512, 1024, 2048$) | 108 | 4 | 6.3 |
| Diagnosis of the patellar failure | Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4, 16$), patellar cartilage only; rank, learning rate, seed or number of epochs changed | 108 | 4 | 6.4 |
| Amount of labelled data | Seq. fine-tuning; Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$); Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 5, 10, 20, 108 | 3 | 6.5 |
| Task order | Seq. fine-tuning in original and reverse order; Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) in original and reverse order; Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) in original and reverse order | 108 | 4 | 6.6 |
| Replay | Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) with and without replay | 108 | 4 | 6.2 |
| Gradient scaling of the prompt-tuning strategy | Prompt tuning without per-task gradient scaling | 108 | 4 | 6.2 |
| Amount of labelled data with the update count of the full data | Seq. fine-tuning, 216 epochs per task; Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$), 216 epochs per task; Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$), 216 epochs per task | 5 | 3 | 6.5 |
| Upper reference: joint training | Joint fine-tuning | 5, 10, 20, 108 | 2, 3 | 6.2 |

Table 6.2: Training and evaluation settings shared by all runs (Section 5.3). Generated from the run configurations; code defaults checked against the code.

| Setting | Symbol | Value |
|---|---|---|
| Optimiser | | SGD, Nesterov |
| Initial learning rate | $\eta_0$ | $10^{-4}$ |
| Momentum | $\mu$ | 0.99 |
| Weight decay | $\omega$ | $3 \cdot 10^{-5}$ |
| Learning-rate schedule | | polynomial, exponent 1, per iteration, restarted for every task |
| Epochs per task | $E$ | 10; 216 in the equal-updates runs (validation every 24 epochs) |
| Batch size | | 1 |
| Patch size (voxels) | | $192 \times 192 \times 192$ |
| Foreground-centred patches | $\pi_{\text{fg}}$ | 0.85 |
| Loss | $\mathcal{L}_{\text{seg}}$ | binary cross-entropy + soft Dice, weights 1:1 |
| Deep supervision | | off |
| Data augmentation | | none |
| Random seed (training, split) | | 42, 42 |
| Sliding-window step | | 0.5 of the patch size |
| Gaussian weighting | | standard deviation 1/8 of the patch size |
| Probability threshold | | 0.5 |

Table 6.3: Parameters of the strategies (Section 5.4). Sequential fine-tuning has no parameters of its own. Bold: rank used in the comparison of the strategies; scaling factor $\gamma_r = \alpha/\sqrt{r}$ listed per rank. The weight ensemble of the distillation-based strategy is reported as an additional evaluation (Section 5.4.4); the run of the prompt-tuning strategy without gradient scaling has the same parameters with the scale inactive (Section 5.4.5).

| Strategy | Parameter | Symbol | Value |
|---|---|---|---|
| Task-specific LoRA | Rank | $r$ | **4**, 8 |
| | Scaling constant | $\alpha$ | 16 |
| | Scaling factor | $\gamma_r$ | 8, 5.66 |
| | Dropout (low-rank path) | | 0.05 |
| | Adapted projections | | $\boldsymbol{W}_q, \boldsymbol{W}_v$, cross-attention |
| Shared LoRA | Rank | $r$ | 4, 32, 128, 256, 512, **1024**, 2048 |
| | Scaling constant | $\alpha$ | 32 |
| | Scaling factor | $\gamma_r$ | 16, 5.66, 2.83, 2, 1.41, 1, 0.71 |
| | Dropout (low-rank path) | | 0.1 |
| | Adapted projections | | $\boldsymbol{W}_q, \boldsymbol{W}_v$, cross-attention |
| Shared LoRA + replay | Rank (otherwise as shared LoRA) | $r$ | 1024 |
| | Replay fraction | $\rho$ | 0.1 |
| | Maximum memory size | $M_{\max}$ | 200 |
| Distillation-based | Distillation weight | $\lambda$ | 0.01 |
| | Ensemble interval (iterations) | $I_{\text{we}}$ | 10 |
| Prompt tuning | Learned prompt tokens per layer | $m$ | 2 |
| | Prompted decoder layers | $L_p$ | 3 |
| | Gradient-scale lower bound | | 0.25 |

Table 6.4: Results of the comparison of the strategies (full training split, original task order, parameters after the last epoch). Mean DSC; ↑: higher is better, ↓: lower is better. For task-specific LoRA, Final Forgetting and the control-task drop are zero by construction (Section 5.2). Joint fine-tuning trains one model on all six tasks at once; Adaptation, Final Forgetting and Transfer are not defined for it (–).

| Strategy | Adapt.↑ | Forg.↓ | Ctrl. drop↓ | Final↑ | Transf.↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seq. fine-tuning | 0.781 | 0.782 | 0.979 | 0.130 | 0.001 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 0.485 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.485 | 0.129 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 0.471 | 0.289 | 0.237 | 0.233 | 0.174 |
| Prompt tuning | 0.580 | 0.510 | 0.865 | 0.155 | 0.043 |
| Distillation-based | 0.747 | 0.734 | 0.979 | 0.135 | 0.002 |
| Shared LoRA + replay ($r = 1024$) | 0.472 | 0.046 | 0.138 | 0.450 | 0.175 |
| Joint fine-tuning (upper reference) | – | – | 0.979 | 0.852 | – |
| Pretrained model | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |

Table 6.5: Additional evaluations and component ablations (full training split, original task order). Evaluation: parameters after the last epoch (main evaluation), the checkpoint with the lowest validation loss, or the weight ensemble of the distillation-based strategy (Sections 5.3 and 5.4.4). "No scaling": the earlier run of the prompt-tuning strategy with the per-task gradient scale inactive, evaluated only at the best validation checkpoint (Section 5.4.5). Mean DSC; ↑: higher is better, ↓: lower is better.

| Strategy | Evaluation | Adapt.↑ | Forg.↓ | Ctrl. drop↓ | Final↑ | Transf.↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seq. fine-tuning | last epoch | 0.781 | 0.782 | 0.979 | 0.130 | 0.001 |
| Seq. fine-tuning | best validation | 0.723 | 0.712 | 0.979 | 0.130 | 0.001 |
| Prompt tuning | last epoch | 0.580 | 0.510 | 0.865 | 0.155 | 0.043 |
| Prompt tuning | best validation | 0.576 | 0.505 | 0.863 | 0.155 | 0.039 |
| Prompt tuning (no scaling) | best validation | 0.608 | 0.568 | 0.979 | 0.135 | 0.043 |
| Distillation-based | last epoch | 0.747 | 0.734 | 0.979 | 0.135 | 0.002 |
| Distillation-based | best validation | 0.745 | 0.732 | 0.979 | 0.135 | 0.002 |
| Distillation-based | weight ensemble | 0.376 | 0.354 | 0.979 | 0.124 | 0.007 |
| Pretrained model | | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |

Table 6.6: Results of the LoRA rank experiment (full training split, original task order). Mean DSC; ↑: higher is better, ↓: lower is better. For task-specific LoRA, Final Forgetting and the control-task drop are zero by construction (Section 5.2).

| Strategy | Rank $r$ | Adapt.↑ | Forg.↓ | Ctrl. drop↓ | Final↑ | Transf.↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Task-specific LoRA | 4 | 0.485 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.485 | 0.129 |
| Task-specific LoRA | 8 | 0.404 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.404 | 0.172 |
| Shared LoRA | 4 | 0.607 | 0.546 | 0.978 | 0.152 | 0.045 |
| Shared LoRA | 32 | 0.570 | 0.499 | 0.978 | 0.154 | 0.114 |
| Shared LoRA | 128 | 0.524 | 0.384 | 0.957 | 0.204 | 0.170 |
| Shared LoRA | 256 | 0.503 | 0.337 | 0.832 | 0.222 | 0.173 |
| Shared LoRA | 512 | 0.488 | 0.309 | 0.574 | 0.230 | 0.175 |
| Shared LoRA | 1024 | 0.471 | 0.289 | 0.237 | 0.233 | 0.174 |
| Shared LoRA | 2048 | 0.462 | 0.284 | 0.091 | 0.233 | 0.175 |
| Pretrained model | | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |

Table 6.7: Task-specific LoRA trained on patellar cartilage alone, changing one setting of the sequence configuration per run ("none": settings of the sequence). Seed: training seed; the data split is the same in all runs. Updates: training iterations (108 volumes per epoch). DSC on the 24 patellar test volumes right after training, with the 95 % bootstrap interval.

| Changed setting | Rank $r$ | $\eta_0$ | Seed | Epochs | Updates | DSC [95 % interval] |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| none | 4 | $10^{-4}$ | 42 | 10 | 1,080 | 0.000 [0.000, 0.000] |
| Rank | 16 | $10^{-4}$ | 42 | 10 | 1,080 | 0.000 [0.000, 0.000] |
| Learning rate | 4 | $3 \cdot 10^{-4}$ | 42 | 10 | 1,080 | 0.000 [0.000, 0.000] |
| Seed | 4 | $10^{-4}$ | 1337 | 10 | 1,080 | 0.000 [0.000, 0.000] |
| Epochs | 4 | $10^{-4}$ | 42 | 50 | 5,400 | 0.839 [0.811, 0.864] |

Table 6.8: Results of the few-shot experiment (original task order, parameters after the last epoch). Vol. (updates): training volumes per task and updates per task; 108 is the full training split, and 5 (1,080) are the equal-updates runs. Joint fine-tuning trains one stage on $6k$ volumes, so it has no updates per task; Adaptation, Final Forgetting and Transfer are not defined for it (–). Mean DSC; ↑: higher is better, ↓: lower is better.

| Strategy | Vol. (updates) | Adapt.↑ | Forg.↓ | Ctrl. drop↓ | Final↑ | Transf.↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seq. fine-tuning | 5 (50) | 0.545 | 0.382 | 0.010 | 0.227 | 0.092 |
| Seq. fine-tuning | 5 (1,080) | 0.712 | 0.714 | 0.979 | 0.117 | 0.023 |
| Seq. fine-tuning | 10 (100) | 0.616 | 0.522 | 0.305 | 0.180 | 0.035 |
| Seq. fine-tuning | 20 (200) | 0.616 | 0.573 | 0.979 | 0.138 | 0.022 |
| Seq. fine-tuning | 108 (1,080) | 0.781 | 0.782 | 0.979 | 0.130 | 0.001 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 5 (50) | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 5 (1,080) | 0.429 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.429 | 0.059 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 10 (100) | 0.115 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.115 | 0.137 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 20 (200) | 0.116 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.116 | 0.138 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 108 (1,080) | 0.485 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.485 | 0.129 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 5 (50) | 0.115 | 0.000 | −0.001 | 0.115 | 0.137 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 5 (1,080) | 0.438 | 0.296 | 0.334 | 0.192 | 0.175 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 10 (100) | 0.116 | 0.000 | −0.001 | 0.117 | 0.138 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 20 (200) | 0.140 | −0.009 | 0.004 | 0.165 | 0.140 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 108 (1,080) | 0.471 | 0.289 | 0.237 | 0.233 | 0.174 |
| Joint fine-tuning | 5 (–) | – | – | 0.733 | 0.600 | – |
| Joint fine-tuning | 10 (–) | – | – | 0.894 | 0.585 | – |
| Joint fine-tuning | 20 (–) | – | – | 0.979 | 0.753 | – |
| Joint fine-tuning | 108 (–) | – | – | 0.979 | 0.852 | – |
| Pretrained model | | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |

Table 6.9: Results of the task-order experiment (full training split). The pretrained-model reference is computed for each task order. Mean DSC; ↑: higher is better, ↓: lower is better.

| Strategy | Task order | Adapt.↑ | Forg.↓ | Ctrl. drop↓ | Final↑ | Transf.↑ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seq. fine-tuning | Original | 0.781 | 0.782 | 0.979 | 0.130 | 0.001 |
| Seq. fine-tuning | Reverse | 0.784 | 0.780 | 0.979 | 0.134 | 0.014 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | Original | 0.485 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.485 | 0.129 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | Reverse | 0.478 | 0.002 | 0.000 | 0.478 | 0.132 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | Original | 0.471 | 0.289 | 0.237 | 0.233 | 0.174 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | Reverse | 0.439 | 0.124 | 0.067 | 0.345 | 0.169 |
| Pretrained model | Original | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |
| Pretrained model | Reverse | 0.114 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.114 | 0.137 |

Table 6.10: Measured cost of the strategies in the comparison (full training split, original task order, one NVIDIA A100 40 GB). Trainable param.: parameters set as trainable, in millions; of the 440.03 million of sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy, 339.29 million receive gradients (Section 5.4.1). Epoch: mean wall-clock time of one training epoch including validation. Wall-clock: total time of all jobs of the run, including the evaluation of the protocol and restarts after the 24-hour limit. Evaluation: median time per test volume, including data loading and text encoding. Peak GPU mem.: maximum over all jobs of the run.

| Strategy | Trainable param. (M) | Epoch (min) | Wall-clock (h) | Evaluation (s/volume) | Peak GPU mem. (GiB) |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Seq. fine-tuning | 440.03 | 26.8 | 32.5 | 8.8 | 31.4 |
| Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$) | 0.20 | 18.1 | 20.8 | 7.9 | 20.3 |
| Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$) | 50.33 | 19.8 | 22.6 | 8.5 | 20.6 |
| Prompt tuning | 12.60 | 18.9 | 24.0 | 8.0 | 20.3 |
| Distillation-based | 440.03 | 37.1 | 47.1 | 8.7 | 37.9 |

# Chapter 7

# Discussion

This chapter interprets the results of Chapter 6 across the experiments; the conclusion of each experiment is given in its own section and is not repeated here. Section 7.1 answers the research question objective by objective, Section 7.2 discusses a possible common cause of several results, Section 7.3 states the limitations and threats to validity, and Section 7.4 discusses how far the results generalise and how the work could be extended.

## 7.1 Answer to the Research Question

The research question asks how continual-learning strategies trade adaptation against catastrophic forgetting when a free-text promptable 3D segmentation model is adapted under few-shot conditions. In our runs, the strategies that update all parameters adapted well and forgot almost everything, the LoRA strategies retained much and adapted less, and the prompt-tuning strategy lay between them; replay brought shared LoRA closest to combining both without the task identity, and joint training showed that the loss of pretrained ability does not need a task sequence. With few labelled volumes and ten epochs per task, only sequential fine-tuning learned, but with the update count of the full split, the LoRA strategies learned from 5 volumes as well. We answer the objectives in the order of the experiments and end with the protocol.

The second objective compares the strategies in their adaptation and forgetting. Sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy reached an Adaptation of 0.781 and 0.747 but ended with a Final Performance of 0.130 and 0.135, barely above the 0.114 of the pretrained model, and lost the control task and femoral cartilage, which the pretrained model segmented (Section 6.2). After six tasks, these strategies leave a model that segments

author: confirm this overall answer; it condenses the conclusions of Sections 6.2 and 6.5

little beyond the last structure, so the universality that motivates adapting a universal model is lost rather than extended. Joint fine-tuning, with the same number of updates on all six tasks at once, reached a Final Performance of 0.852 but also lost the control task completely, so the loss of pretrained ability comes from fine-tuning all parameters on the knee structures, not from the task sequence; the loss of the earlier tasks, in contrast, comes from the sequence. The prompt-tuning strategy lay between the two groups, with an Adaptation of 0.580, a Final Forgetting of 0.510 and a control-task drop of 0.865, although its pretrained weights are frozen and it trains a quarter of the parameters of shared LoRA. Its learned prompt tokens and its meta-net act on the query, keys and values of every text prompt (Section 5.4.5), so a frozen backbone alone does not protect the outputs for other text prompts; shared LoRA also acts on every text prompt, however, and retained much more, so the number of trainable parameters and freezing the backbone do not by themselves explain retention in our runs, and we did not test which property does. The LoRA strategies retained more at an Adaptation about 0.30 lower, a gap that the shared budget of ten epochs per task probably widens (Section 7.2). Distillation from the pretrained model reduced forgetting only slightly in the configuration we evaluated, by 0.048 in Final Forgetting, with an untuned weight $\lambda = 0.01$, so this result concerns that configuration, not distillation in general. Replay was the only addition that moved shared LoRA towards both goals at once: with a memory of earlier tasks only, its Final Forgetting was 0.046 instead of 0.289, its Final Performance 0.450 instead of 0.233, and its control-task drop 0.138 instead of 0.237, at the same Adaptation (Section 6.2). In MedPEFT-CL, a framework for continual learning of a 2D text-prompted segmentation model with LoRA, replay likewise gave the largest gain of the components added one at a time [Gao+26a, Table 8]. In answer to the second objective, no strategy combined high adaptation with retention: the strategies with the highest Adaptation forgot almost everything, task-specific LoRA gave the highest Final Performance but needs the task identity at inference, and shared LoRA with replay came within 0.034 of it without that requirement; all strategies stayed far below the Final Performance of joint training.

check: MedPEFT-CL Table 8 numbers read from arXiv v1; bib cites the WACV 2026 version

The third objective concerns the amount of labelled data. With 5 and 10 volumes per task, neither LoRA strategy learned any task, and with 20 only shared LoRA began to, whereas sequential fine-tuning learned every task in every few-shot setting (Section 6.5). With fewer volumes, sequential fine-tuning adapted less and forgot less: with 5 volumes, it kept the control task and reached a Final Performance of 0.227, against 0.130 with the full split. Because the number of epochs was fixed, fewer volumes also meant fewer updates, 50

instead of 1,080 per task. The equal-updates runs separate the two at $k = 5$: with 1,080 updates on 5 volumes, both LoRA strategies learned the tasks, and reducing the data from 108 to 5 volumes at the same number of updates lowered the Adaptation by only 0.032 to 0.069 for the three strategies, while sequential fine-tuning forgot again as much as with the full split (Section 6.5). The control-task drop of joint training, which rose from 0.733 to 0.979 with the number of updates, points the same way. That LoRA can learn from 10 labelled volumes of a 3D model when the training budget is larger has also been shown by Silva-Rodríguez et al. (Section 7.2). In answer to the third objective, at $k = 5$ the amount of labelled data had a small effect on Adaptation once the number of updates was held fixed, and the number of updates decided whether the parameter-efficient strategies learned and how much sequential fine-tuning forgot; this rests on one draw of volumes and one run per configuration, and for $k = 10$ and $k = 20$ data and updates remain confounded.

The fourth objective asks how the task order, the LoRA rank and the components of the strategies influence adaptation and forgetting. The task order mattered strongly only for shared LoRA. For task-specific LoRA, the order changed nothing beyond the variation between two runs, as its design implies, and for sequential fine-tuning no effect of the order could be detected, with differences of at most 0.004 outside Transfer, whereas for shared LoRA the reverse order reduced Final Forgetting from 0.289 to 0.124 and the control-task drop from 0.237 to 0.067, at an Adaptation lower by 0.032 (Section 6.6). In the original order, most of this forgetting arose in the last step, when lateral meniscus was trained. The metrics of shared LoRA after the sequence are therefore a property of the strategy together with the order, not of the strategy alone, and with two orders we cannot determine whether lateral meniscus causes the loss as a structure or through its position. The Beyond Forgetting benchmark found that the task order affects the results of several strategies over ten random orders of 2D prostate segmentation tasks from different centres [Wan+26a, Sec. 4.4]; we observe the same for a free-text promptable 3D model with tasks that are structures, but with two orders only and for one of the three strategies we trained in both orders.

For shared LoRA, the rank set a trade-off between adaptation and retention: from $r = 4$ to $r = 2048$, Final Forgetting fell from 0.546 to 0.284 and the control-task drop from 0.978 to 0.091, while Adaptation fell from 0.607 to 0.462 (Section 6.3). Because $\alpha$ was fixed, the rank and the scaling factor $\gamma_r$ changed together, so we report this as a trade-off observed in this configuration, not as a rule for choosing the rank, and whether the capacity or the scale of the adapter causes it remains open (Section 7.2). For task-specific LoRA, $r = 8$ brought

no gain over $r = 4$, with one run per rank. Of the components of the strategies, replay lowered the Final Forgetting of shared LoRA from 0.289 to 0.046 at the same Adaptation and also lowered its control-task drop; the per-task gradient scaling of the prompt-tuning strategy lowered its Final Forgetting by 0.063 and its control-task drop by 0.117 at an Adaptation lower by 0.032; and the weight ensemble of the distillation-based strategy, in our configuration, halved the Adaptation without protecting the control task (Section 6.2).

In answer to the fourth objective, the task order, the rank and replay all shifted the balance between adaptation and retention of shared LoRA strongly, and gradient scaling shifted the prompt-tuning strategy towards retention, whereas task-specific LoRA did not depend on the order, by design, and did not gain from a higher rank, and sequential fine-tuning forgot almost everything in both orders.

The first objective was an evaluation protocol for this setting (Section 5.2). The protocol measures adaptation, forgetting within the task sequence and the loss of pretrained ability separately, with few-shot settings and two task orders, and two of its parts changed how the results read. The control task showed a loss that Final Forgetting does not capture: between $r = 1024$ and $r = 2048$, the Final Forgetting of shared LoRA differs by less than 0.01, whereas the control-task drop falls from 0.237 to 0.091 (Section 6.3). The reference row of the pretrained model showed that the LoRA strategies with 5 and 10 volumes per task did not change the model at all: their Adaptation of 0.114 to 0.116 equals that of the pretrained model, 0.114, and would otherwise read as weak learning (Section 6.5). The joint reference showed that the loss of the control task under full fine-tuning occurs without a task sequence, which the sequential runs alone could not show (Section 6.2). In answer to the first objective, the protocol separates these effects as intended, within the limits stated in Section 7.3: its control task is a single structure, its joint reference covers all six tasks together only, and its intervals cover only the choice of test volumes. It requires a pretrained free-text promptable model, a text prompt and labelled volumes for each task, and a held-out control task; whether it transfers to other models without changes was not tried (Section 7.4).

## 7.2 Training Budget as a Common Factor

Four results of Chapter 6 show the same pattern: under the shared configuration of ten epochs per task, a LoRA adapter often did not move the prediction away from that of the pretrained model. Shared LoRA learned the first task poorly in both task orders, whereas

the same structures were learned when they came later in the other order (Section 6.6). Task-specific LoRA did not learn patellar cartilage in ten epochs with any rank, learning rate or seed we tried, but did in fifty (Section 6.4). With 5 and 10 volumes per task, that is, 50 and 100 updates, neither LoRA strategy learned any task (Section 6.5). In the rank experiment, the Adaptation that shared LoRA lost at higher ranks came mostly from the first task (Section 6.3).

We propose a hypothesis that connects these results: an adapter that starts from zero needs many updates before it changes the output of the model, and ten epochs were not always enough. The hypothesis rests on how the adapter is initialised. Because $\boldsymbol{B}$ starts at zero (Section 5.4.2), the update $\gamma_r \boldsymbol{B}\boldsymbol{A}$ is zero at the start, and the model predicts exactly what the pretrained model predicts. The gradient with respect to $\boldsymbol{A}$ contains $\boldsymbol{B}$ as a factor and is therefore also zero in the first step, so at first only $\boldsymbol{B}$ changes, and the update grows from zero only as both factors move away from their initial values. For a structure that the pretrained model does not segment, the update has to grow large enough to turn an empty prediction into a non-empty one, and with a learning rate that decays to zero within the ten epochs of a task (Section 5.3), training can end before this point is reached. In shared LoRA, every task after the first starts from an adapter that has already moved. In the reverse order, the training loss of the second task started at 0.86, although the first task had hardly been learned (Section 6.6). This suggests that later tasks benefit from the adapter having moved rather than from what it learned about the earlier structure, but our runs cannot separate the two. The equal-updates runs test one part of the hypothesis. With the update count of the full split on 5 volumes, both LoRA strategies learned the tasks and came within 0.06 of their Adaptation with the full split (Section 6.5), so their failure with 50 updates per task came from the number of updates, as the hypothesis predicts. They do not test the role of the zero initialisation, because sequential fine-tuning, which starts every task from trained weights, also adapted more with more updates, and task-specific LoRA still did not learn patellar cartilage with 1,080 updates, in line with the 50 epochs it needed in the diagnosis (Section 6.4). No run tests the initialisation mechanism directly, so we present it as consistent with the observations, not as a finding.

Two observations do not follow from the hypothesis. First, it does not explain why the rank matters: with $r = 4$, the training loss of the first task fell to 0.74 within three epochs, whereas with $r = 1024$ it had fallen only to 0.69 after ten (Section 6.6). Because $\alpha$ was fixed, the scaling factor $\gamma_r$ changes with the rank, and the rank experiment does not show whether the capacity or the scale of the adapter causes the slower start (Section 6.3). Second,

author: confirm this reading of the equal-updates runs for the hypothesis

defense: adapter-from-

task-specific LoRA, which starts every task from zero, learned most structures within ten epochs, for example lateral tibial cartilage with a DSC of 0.64 and medial meniscus with 0.57 right after training; only patellar cartilage stayed at zero (Section 6.3). How quickly an adapter leaves the empty prediction therefore also depends on the structure, which the hypothesis does not predict. Neither does it explain why shared LoRA retained more of the earlier tasks and of the control task in the reverse order (Section 6.6).

A result of Silva-Rodríguez et al. is in line with the hypothesis, without testing it. In their few-shot adaptation of a 3D CT segmentation model to 16 structures that were new to the model, LoRA with $r = 4$ in the encoder reached a mean DSC of 38.49 % with 10 labelled volumes [Sil+25, Table 4], while our LoRA strategies learned no task with 10 volumes. Their adaptation ran for up to 200 epochs with early stopping, with AdamW and a learning rate chosen for each adaptation method by a grid search [Sil+25, Sec. 4.3.2–4.3.3]; ours ran for 10 epochs, with stochastic gradient descent and one learning rate for all strategies. The model, the data, the classification head and the place of the adapter differ as well, so the comparison shows only that LoRA can learn from 10 volumes with a larger budget, not that the budget is what limits it in our runs.

For the research question, the hypothesis matters because our comparison measures the strategies under one training budget, not each at its best setting (Section 5.3). The patellar diagnosis shows one case in which this budget limits the Adaptation of task-specific LoRA, and the equal-updates runs show that the few-shot results of both LoRA strategies were limited in the same way at $k = 5$. More updates also increased the forgetting of the strategies that share parameters across tasks: at $k = 5$, shared LoRA forgot as much with 1,080 updates as with the full split, and sequential fine-tuning lost the control task, which it kept with 50 updates (Section 6.5). A longer budget would therefore probably raise adaptation and forgetting together, and how the trade-off looks under a longer budget for the full split remains open. The answers in Section 7.1 hold for the budget of ten epochs per task.

## 7.3 Limitations and Threats to Validity

Three limitations affect the conclusions most: the shared training configuration, the single run per configuration and the narrow scope of the study. We discuss them first, then the control task, and then the remaining threats to internal, construct and external validity.

First, all strategies were trained with one configuration, and neither the learning rate nor the number of epochs was tuned per strategy (Section 5.3). Section 7.2 argues that this budget limits at least task-specific LoRA, so the comparison describes the strategies under ten epochs per task, not at their best settings. Three experiments also change a second factor together with the one they study. The few-shot settings reduce the number of updates together with the number of volumes, the shared-LoRA rank experiment changes the scaling factor $\gamma_r$ together with the rank, and the 50-epoch patellar run changes the learning-rate schedule together with the number of updates (Sections 6.3 to 6.5). In these experiments, a difference cannot be attributed to the studied factor alone; the equal-updates runs separate volumes and updates only for $k = 5$ and three strategies.

Second, each configuration was trained once, and each few-shot setting uses one draw of training volumes (Section 6.1.2). Our bootstrap intervals cover only the choice of test volumes, not the variation between training runs or between draws of training volumes (Section 6.1.4). The two task-specific LoRA runs show how large the variation between runs can be: they differ only in the initialisation of the adapters and in non-deterministic GPU operations, yet they reached 0.40 and 0.34 on lateral meniscus, and the paired interval of their difference in Adaptation excludes zero (Section 6.6). A second example are the earlier run of sequential fine-tuning and its rerun with the same configuration: the rerun was continued inside the last task and therefore drew its training samples in a different order from that point on (Section 6.1.3), and at the same checkpoint, the two evaluation matrices agree up to the fifth task but differ by up to 0.037 in single entries after the sixth. Differences of a few hundredths between single runs, especially on single tasks, should therefore not be read as effects of a strategy or a factor. The trend over the rank and the effect of the task order on shared LoRA are many times larger than the difference in Adaptation between these two runs (0.006), but one pair of runs gives only one example of the variation, and the variation between draws of training volumes in the few-shot settings is unknown. The intervals are also not adjusted for the 152 comparisons we read (Section 6.1.4).

author: confirm using this pair as an example of training variation

Third, the scope is narrow. We adapted one model, VoxTell, to six structures of one knee MRI dataset, in two task orders, with one fixed text prompt per structure that was used for both training and evaluation (Section 4.1.2). The distillation-based and the prompt-tuning strategies were run only with the full training split and in the original order, and the replay strategy only with the full split (Section 6.1.1), so the few-shot part of the research question is answered for sequential fine-tuning and the two LoRA strategies only, with joint training as their reference. Whether the results depend on the wording of the text prompt

was not tested. In SEER, VoxTell kept the highest DSC of five promptable models under rephrased requests, but its worst rephrasing still lowered the DSC on a pelvic-bone dataset from 97.59 % with the class-name prompt to 79.34 % [Zha+26, Table 1] (Section 2.1). Our evaluation uses only the wording seen in training, so it cannot show whether the adapted models still respond to other wordings of the same structure.

The control task measures the loss of pretrained ability with a single structure: the lung in four CT test volumes of AeroPath, which the pretrained model segments with a DSC of 0.979 (Section 4.2). One large, high-contrast structure in another modality cannot show how the strategies affect the many other structures and modalities that VoxTell was trained on, and unlike the control set of SPU, the control task is not sampled from the pretraining distribution (Section 3.4). That replay lowered the control-task drop although its memory holds no control-task samples arose in the last task of one task order, so it may depend on the order, and its cause was not tested (Section 6.2).

Further threats to internal validity come from differences between the runs other than the strategy. All strategies are evaluated at the last epoch; only the additional evaluation selects a checkpoint, by a validation loss computed on one random patch per volume, and this selection lowered the Adaptation of sequential fine-tuning (Sections 5.3 and 6.2). The prompt-tuning run without gradient scaling was evaluated only at that checkpoint, so the scaling ablation compares both runs at the selected checkpoint. The two LoRA strategies were run with different values of $\alpha$ and of the dropout rate (Section 5.4.2), no strategy used data augmentation (Section 5.3), the code version was recorded only for the reruns, and the software versions were not logged per run (Section 6.1.3).

Two threats concern what the measures and the strategies represent. The joint reference was trained on all six tasks together only, so Adaptation cannot be turned into the intransigence measure of Chaudhry et al., whose reference for a task is a model trained jointly on the tasks up to it (Sections 3.4 and 5.2). The distillation-based and prompt-tuning strategies are adaptations: the first distils on current-task data and updates its weight ensemble every 10 instead of every 100 iterations, and the second learns prompt tokens in the decoder together with a meta-net whose gradients it scales as well (Sections 5.4.4 and 5.4.5), so their results do not describe the original methods. Our distillation teacher is the pretrained model, as in ZSCL; PRIMED, in continual learning of a medical 2D classification model, reached a higher Last accuracy with the model of the previous task as teacher than with the initial model (82.1 against 78.2 %) [Che+26c, Table 4a], and we did not test this choice. For task-specific LoRA, Final Forgetting and the control-task drop are

zero by construction (Section 5.2); its costs are the task identity it needs at inference and one stored adapter per task, which the metrics of the protocol do not measure.

Finally, the external validity is limited by the data and by the strategies that were not evaluated. We used our own random split of SKM-TEA instead of the official one, so our numbers are not comparable with SKM-TEA benchmarks, and the SKM-TEA files store no orientation, so the volumes reach the model in their stored axis order (Section 4.5); whether this contributes to the low DSC of the pretrained model on SKM-TEA is unknown. Other strategies, such as elastic weight consolidation, mixture-of-experts adapters or the selection of adapters by the similarity of text-prompt embeddings as in MedCRP-CL [Gao26], were not evaluated (Section 5.4).

## 7.4 Generalisation and Extensions

The numbers of Chapter 6 belong to VoxTell, to six knee structures and to the training configuration we used, and we do not expect them to carry over to other models or data. What may carry over is the mechanism proposed in Section 7.2. It rests only on the standard initialisation of LoRA, in which the update starts at zero [Hu+22, Sec. 4.1], so other promptable segmentation models adapted with LoRA start from the same point; whether they also need more updates than a short schedule provides is a hypothesis that our runs do not test. For other anatomical regions and for CT tasks, we have no evidence either way.

The results also say nothing about structures that the model has never seen. The three cartilages other than femoral cartilage are in VoxTell's training vocabulary, whereas the menisci are not (Section 4.1.2), but in our evaluation the pretrained model segmented only femoral cartilage, with a DSC of 0.684, and none of the other five structures (Section 6.3). Our tasks are therefore structures that the model rarely saw or does not segment in this data, not structures of a kind that is absent from its training data, such as a new modality.

For use in practice, the strategies differ in what they assume at inference. Task-specific LoRA needs the task identity to select an adapter (Section 5.2). In our setting, the text prompt names the structure, so the identity is available as long as each text prompt maps to one trained adapter. This holds for a closed set of structures with fixed text prompts, but not for open use: a rephrased text prompt or a new structure has no adapter of its own, so it needs either the pretrained model or a rule that chooses an adapter, and our protocol defines only the first, for the control task. Each task also adds an adapter, about

0.2 million parameters at $r = 4$ (Section 5.4.2), so the memory grows with the number of tasks. The strategies with one parameter set for all tasks need no such mapping, but in our runs all of them forgot part of the earlier tasks or of the control task, from shared LoRA with replay, which forgot least, to sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy, which forgot almost everything (Section 6.2).

Four extensions follow directly from the open points of this chapter. First, the hypothesis of Section 7.2 can be tested by training the first task of shared LoRA at $r = 1024$ for more epochs, by starting a task from an adapter trained on another structure instead of from zero, and by varying $\alpha$ or the learning rate at high rank, which would also separate the capacity from the scale of the adapter. Second, repeating each configuration with several seeds and, in the few-shot settings, with several draws of training volumes would give the variation between runs that our intervals do not contain, and extending the equal-updates runs to $k = 10$ and $k = 20$ and to the other strategies would separate data and updates where they remain confounded (Section 7.3). Third, evaluating the adapted models with rephrased text prompts, for instance the clinical styles used by SEER [Zha+26], would show whether adaptation with one wording per structure changes how the model responds to other wordings. Fourth, more task orders would show whether the large loss when lateral meniscus is trained last in the original order comes from the structure or from its position in the sequence (Section 6.6). Beyond these, applying the protocol to other free-text promptable models would show which of our observations depend on VoxTell.

author: confirm the added extension (equal-updates runs for k = 10, 20 and the other strategies)

# Chapter 8

# Summary

A universal segmentation model is valuable because it segments many structures from a free-text prompt, but it still fails on structures that were rare in its training data, and labelled volumes of such structures are scarce. This thesis studied what happens when such a model is adapted to new structures one after another with few labelled volumes per structure: how much it learns of each new structure, how much it forgets of the earlier ones, and how much of its pretrained ability it keeps. We adapted VoxTell [Rok+26] to six structures of the SKM-TEA knee MRI dataset [Des+21], four cartilages and two menisci, which the pretrained model segmented with a mean DSC of 0.114, and used the lung in chest CT volumes of AeroPath [Stø+23] as a control task that is never trained on.

The strategies we compared are existing methods: sequential fine-tuning, LoRA [Hu+22] with one adapter per task or one shared adapter, replay, ZSCL [Zhe+23] and CPE-CLIP [DAl+23]. Our own work is threefold. First, we designed an evaluation protocol for this setting, which evaluates the model on every task and on a held-out control task after each task, reports the pretrained model and joint training as references, and covers few-shot settings with 5, 10 and 20 labelled volumes per task and two task orders (Section 5.2). Second, we adapted the strategies to a free-text promptable 3D model, with LoRA on the cross-attention of the prompt decoder, distillation of a voxel-wise similarity distribution at the coarsest decoder stage instead of ZSCL's image–text distribution, and learned prompt tokens in the cross-attention together with a meta-net that shifts the text query instead of CPE-CLIP's prompts in the encoders (Section 5.4). We compared them under one shared training configuration in 38 runs, with joint training as an upper reference (Chapter 6). Third, we analysed the factors that affect adaptation and forgetting in this setting, separating the amount of data from the number of updates, and diagnosed the

failure of task-specific LoRA on patellar cartilage, from which we proposed a hypothesis that connects several results (Section 7.2). All numbers below come from these runs.

The most important result is that no strategy combined high adaptation with retention (Section 6.2). Sequential fine-tuning and the distillation-based strategy reached an Adaptation of 0.781 and 0.747, but after six tasks their Final Performance of 0.130 and 0.135 was barely above that of the pretrained model, and the DSC on the control task fell from 0.979 to almost zero. Joint training with the same number of updates on all six tasks at once reached a Final Performance of 0.852, far above every strategy, but lost the control task as well, so this loss comes from fine-tuning all parameters on the knee structures, not from the task sequence. The prompt-tuning strategy, whose pretrained weights stay frozen, lay between the groups and still lost most of the control task, so freezing the backbone did not by itself preserve the other abilities of the model. The two LoRA strategies adapted less, with an Adaptation of 0.485 and 0.471, and retained much more; task-specific LoRA, which forgets nothing by construction but needs the task identity at inference, reached the highest Final Performance, 0.485, and shared LoRA with replay came within 0.034 of it without the task identity. The second result concerns few labelled volumes (Section 6.5). With ten epochs per task and 5 or 10 volumes, neither LoRA strategy learned any task, whereas sequential fine-tuning learned every task and, with 5 volumes, forgot less and kept the control task. With the update count of the full split on 5 volumes, the LoRA strategies learned as well, and reducing the data from 108 to 5 volumes at the same number of updates lowered the Adaptation by only 0.03 to 0.07, so at this setting the number of updates decided the outcome more than the amount of data.

The factors we varied changed the balance mainly for shared LoRA (Sections 6.2, 6.3 and 6.6). In the reverse task order, its Final Forgetting fell from 0.289 to 0.124 and its control-task drop from 0.237 to 0.067, whereas no effect of the order could be detected for sequential fine-tuning and none beyond run-to-run variation for task-specific LoRA. A higher rank lowered the forgetting of shared LoRA at the cost of Adaptation, from a Final Forgetting of 0.546 and an Adaptation of 0.607 at $r = 4$ to 0.284 and 0.462 at $r = 2048$, with the scaling factor changing together with the rank. Replay, with a memory of earlier tasks only, lowered its Final Forgetting from 0.289 to 0.046 and its control-task drop from 0.237 to 0.138 and raised its Final Performance from 0.233 to 0.450 at the same Adaptation. Per-task gradient scaling moved the prompt-tuning strategy towards retention, and the weight ensemble of the distillation-based strategy halved its Adaptation in our configuration.

The protocol separated effects that a single metric would have mixed (Section 7.1). The control task showed a loss of pretrained ability that Final Forgetting did not capture: between $r = 1024$ and $r = 2048$, the Final Forgetting of shared LoRA differed by less than 0.01, whereas its control-task drop fell from 0.237 to 0.091. The pretrained-model reference showed that the few-shot LoRA runs had not changed the model at all, which their Adaptation alone would have shown as weak learning, and the joint reference showed that the loss of the control task does not require a task sequence.

Several results point to the training budget as a common factor. Task-specific LoRA stayed at an empty prediction on patellar cartilage for ten epochs with every rank, learning rate and seed we tried, and reached a DSC of 0.839 with fifty (Section 6.4); shared LoRA learned its first task poorly in both orders; and the LoRA strategies learned nothing with 50 to 100 updates per task but learned from the same 5 volumes with 1,080 (Section 6.5). We proposed that an adapter that starts from zero needs many updates before it changes the output of the model; the runs with equal updates support the role of the number of updates but do not test the initialisation (Section 7.2). The conclusions are further limited by one run per configuration, one training configuration for all strategies, one model, one dataset and one text prompt per structure, a control task of a single structure, and a separation of data and updates at $k = 5$ only (Section 7.3).

Within this setting, the results suggest three points for adapting such a model. A parameter-efficient strategy needs enough updates per task, more than ten epochs gave for some structures and far more than the few-shot settings gave, although more updates also brought back forgetting in the strategies that share parameters across tasks. Where the other abilities of the model matter, sequential fine-tuning, the distillation-based strategy and the prompt-tuning strategy lost them in our runs, so a frozen backbone alone is no safeguard. For a closed set of structures with fixed text prompts, task-specific LoRA keeps every earlier structure by construction; without the task identity, replay brought shared LoRA close to it in our single run and is worth testing further, but one run does not support a recommendation.

Future work follows from these limits (Section 7.4). The training-budget hypothesis can be tested by training the first task of shared LoRA for more epochs, by starting a task from an adapter trained on another structure, and by varying the scaling factor or the learning rate at high rank. Repeated runs with several seeds and several draws of training volumes would give the variation between runs that our intervals do not cover, and runs with equal updates for 10 and 20 volumes and for the other strategies would separate data

author: check whether the re-run of replay changes this recommendation

author: confirm, as in Section 7.4

and updates where they remain confounded. Rephrased text prompts would show whether adaptation with one wording changes how the model responds to others, more task orders would show whether the loss at the end of the original order comes from the structure or from its position, and applying the protocol to other free-text promptable models would show which observations depend on VoxTell.

# Appendix A

# Additional Experimental Details and Results

This appendix complements Chapter 6. Section A.1 lists the volumes of the few-shot training sets and of the test sets (Sections 4.3 and 6.1.2), and Section A.2 gives the evaluation matrix of every run reported in Chapter 6, from which all metrics and all per-task values quoted there are computed.

## A.1 Training and Test Volumes

This section belongs to Sections 4.3 and 6.1.2. Table A.1 lists the SKM-TEA volumes of the few-shot training sets and the test volumes of both datasets. The few-shot sets are taken from the training logs of the runs: every run with the same number of volumes $k$ used the same set for all six tasks, and the sets are nested. The test volumes are the same in every run.

## A.2 Evaluation Matrices of All Runs

This section belongs to Chapter 6. For every reported run, the table gives the mean DSC on the test volumes of each task (rows, in training order) after each stage (columns): *Pre.* is the pretrained model, and the following columns are the stages after training on the task named in the header. The diagonal entries, right after a task is trained, are set in bold; the last row is the control task. Task abbreviations: LT lateral tibial cartilage, MT medial tibial cartilage, Fe femoral cartilage, Pa patellar cartilage, MM medial meniscus, LM lateral

Table A.1: Few-shot training volumes and test volumes. SKM-TEA volumes by their identifier, AeroPath volumes by their number. The full training split contains 108 SKM-TEA volumes (Section 4.3).

| Set | Volumes |
|---|---|
| SKM-TEA training, $k = 5$ | MTR_038, MTR_074, MTR_097, MTR_201, MTR_225 |
| SKM-TEA training, $k = 10$ | the 5 volumes above and MTR_118, MTR_154, MTR_188, MTR_207, MTR_219 |
| SKM-TEA training, $k = 20$ | the 10 volumes above and MTR_001, MTR_037, MTR_056, MTR_120, MTR_156, MTR_167, MTR_179, MTR_209, MTR_224, MTR_243 |
| SKM-TEA test (24 volumes) | MTR_005, MTR_015, MTR_016, MTR_018, MTR_045, MTR_046, MTR_049, MTR_052, MTR_066, MTR_079, MTR_098, MTR_104, MTR_105, MTR_107, MTR_110, MTR_115, MTR_129, MTR_130, MTR_190, MTR_191, MTR_199, MTR_215, MTR_227, MTR_248 |
| AeroPath test (4 volumes) | 1, 3, 6, 12 |

meniscus, Ctrl control task (lung in AeroPath). The runs are grouped by the experiment in which they first appear in Table 6.1; a run that belongs to several experiments is listed once. Joint fine-tuning has a single stage, *Joint*, after which all six structures are evaluated. All matrices are computed with the parameters after the last epoch, except that of the prompt-tuning run without gradient scaling, which was evaluated only at the checkpoint with the lowest validation loss (Section 6.2).

## Comparison of the strategies

Table A.2: Evaluation matrix: Sequential fine-tuning (full training split, original task order); run `exp_20261022_171452_a9f4ca56`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.856** | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.014 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.843** | 0.002 | 0.000 | 0.010 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.001 | 0.001 | **0.841** | 0.192 | 0.006 | 0.004 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.003 | **0.632** | 0.006 | 0.019 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.007 | 0.001 | 0.000 | **0.775** | 0.002 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.005 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.001 | **0.740** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |

Table A.3: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260816_155157_668e608d`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.635** | 0.635 | 0.635 | 0.635 | 0.635 | 0.635 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.163 | **0.527** | 0.527 | 0.527 | 0.527 | 0.527 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.440 | 0.470 | **0.774** | 0.774 | 0.774 | 0.774 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.002 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.012 | 0.042 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.572** | 0.572 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.033 | 0.006 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.020 | **0.401** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.4: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260926_095539_90e8b4e6`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.294** | 0.311 | 0.174 | 0.156 | 0.216 | 0.025 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.185 | **0.490** | 0.326 | 0.165 | 0.355 | 0.018 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.648 | 0.550 | **0.719** | 0.609 | 0.644 | 0.555 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.024 | 0.004 | 0.008 | **0.443** | 0.291 | 0.039 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.037 | 0.061 | 0.030 | 0.066 | **0.477** | 0.357 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.020 | 0.026 | 0.008 | 0.011 | 0.071 | **0.402** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.975 | 0.976 | 0.974 | 0.955 | 0.742 |

Table A.5: Evaluation matrix: Prompt-tuning strategy (full training split, original task order); run `exp_20261022_180923_7bcbb6cc`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.711** | 0.407 | 0.165 | 0.162 | 0.286 | 0.043 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.095 | **0.528** | 0.160 | 0.104 | 0.137 | 0.005 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.065 | 0.043 | **0.730** | 0.492 | 0.235 | 0.010 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.003 | 0.000 | 0.012 | **0.472** | 0.203 | 0.010 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.003 | 0.016 | 0.014 | 0.018 | **0.503** | 0.327 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.010 | 0.002 | 0.006 | 0.004 | 0.212 | **0.534** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.041 | 0.071 | 0.226 | 0.078 | 0.155 | 0.115 |

Table A.6: Evaluation matrix: Distillation-based strategy (full training split, original task order); run `exp_20261022_171452_65011743`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.841** | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.005 | 0.000 | 0.007 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.831** | 0.003 | 0.003 | 0.013 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.001 | 0.001 | **0.823** | 0.255 | 0.005 | 0.002 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.008 | **0.472** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.011 | 0.001 | 0.000 | **0.713** | 0.000 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.006 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.801** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.003 | 0.002 | 0.000 | 0.000 |

## LoRA rank

Table A.7: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 8$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260822_110320_530ca92a`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.515** | 0.515 | 0.515 | 0.515 | 0.515 | 0.515 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.273 | **0.516** | 0.516 | 0.516 | 0.516 | 0.516 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.601 | 0.488 | **0.748** | 0.748 | 0.748 | 0.748 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.006 | 0.002 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.021 | 0.077 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.526** | 0.526 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.040 | 0.008 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.033 | **0.118** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.8: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 4$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260924_202757_88afb75d`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.693** | 0.380 | 0.022 | 0.051 | 0.022 | 0.005 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.104 | **0.520** | 0.065 | 0.004 | 0.053 | 0.001 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.053 | 0.096 | **0.783** | 0.547 | 0.069 | 0.004 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.031 | **0.510** | 0.005 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.011 | 0.039 | 0.012 | **0.581** | 0.348 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.011 | 0.001 | 0.021 | 0.001 | 0.062 | **0.554** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.004 | 0.001 | 0.330 | 0.014 | 0.226 | 0.001 |

Table A.9: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 32$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260926_095635_1dd1adb4`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.650** | 0.427 | 0.140 | 0.100 | 0.195 | 0.010 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.175 | **0.515** | 0.158 | 0.038 | 0.201 | 0.004 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.458 | 0.183 | **0.751** | 0.504 | 0.439 | 0.018 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.003 | 0.000 | 0.014 | **0.492** | 0.179 | 0.016 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.024 | 0.025 | 0.082 | 0.029 | **0.517** | 0.381 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.031 | 0.002 | 0.012 | 0.003 | 0.103 | **0.493** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.708 | 0.193 | 0.880 | 0.106 | 0.080 | 0.001 |

Table A.10: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 128$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260816_124851_bc388139`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.453** | 0.316 | 0.102 | 0.111 | 0.242 | 0.015 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.241 | **0.531** | 0.164 | 0.058 | 0.289 | 0.010 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.633 | 0.417 | **0.732** | 0.630 | 0.639 | 0.358 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.014 | 0.001 | 0.008 | **0.484** | 0.230 | 0.024 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.034 | 0.044 | 0.071 | 0.034 | **0.490** | 0.363 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.029 | 0.009 | 0.002 | 0.004 | 0.101 | **0.455** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.969 | 0.791 | 0.937 | 0.672 | 0.434 | 0.022 |

Table A.11: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 256$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260817_172554_da49178a`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.361** | 0.309 | 0.142 | 0.121 | 0.247 | 0.014 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.223 | **0.522** | 0.223 | 0.085 | 0.343 | 0.012 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.646 | 0.468 | **0.726** | 0.634 | 0.664 | 0.478 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.023 | 0.002 | 0.008 | **0.478** | 0.243 | 0.014 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.042 | 0.056 | 0.053 | 0.045 | **0.489** | 0.373 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.026 | 0.014 | 0.004 | 0.005 | 0.089 | **0.443** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.945 | 0.968 | 0.918 | 0.772 | 0.148 |

Table A.12: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 512$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260924_163047_f4aa9c98`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.310** | 0.290 | 0.137 | 0.143 | 0.192 | 0.020 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.201 | **0.511** | 0.264 | 0.145 | 0.321 | 0.014 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.647 | 0.516 | **0.721** | 0.619 | 0.640 | 0.537 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.029 | 0.003 | 0.010 | **0.461** | 0.251 | 0.020 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.042 | 0.058 | 0.038 | 0.061 | **0.494** | 0.361 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.022 | 0.023 | 0.006 | 0.010 | 0.074 | **0.427** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.965 | 0.973 | 0.965 | 0.874 | 0.405 |

Table A.13: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 2048$, full training split, original task order); run `exp_20260927_213503_efa7a48c`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.280** | 0.326 | 0.208 | 0.185 | 0.230 | 0.038 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.180 | **0.473** | 0.342 | 0.208 | 0.346 | 0.023 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.648 | 0.571 | **0.720** | 0.630 | 0.648 | 0.550 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.026 | 0.003 | 0.005 | **0.447** | 0.326 | 0.047 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.040 | 0.047 | 0.023 | 0.081 | **0.464** | 0.352 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.019 | 0.025 | 0.008 | 0.014 | 0.068 | **0.388** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.977 | 0.978 | 0.978 | 0.968 | 0.889 |

## Diagnosis of the patellar failure

Table A.14: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, patellar cartilage only, settings of the sequence); run `exp_20260824_040750_012f67c8`.

| Task | Pre. | Pa |
|---|---|---|
| Pa | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.15: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 16$, patellar cartilage only); run `exp_20260828_041835_89e6de63`.

| Task | Pre. | Pa |
|---|---|---|
| Pa | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.16: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, patellar cartilage only, learning rate $3 \cdot 10^{-4}$); run `exp_20260828_045913_2e306fe6`.

| Task | Pre. | Pa |
|---|---|---|
| Pa | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.17: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, patellar cartilage only, seed 1337); run `exp_20260901_110801_d8b133c2`.

| Task | Pre. | Pa |
|---|---|---|
| Pa | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.18: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, patellar cartilage only, 50 epochs); run `exp_20260905_220334_6697f1c2`.

| Task | Pre. | Pa |
|---|---|---|
| Pa | 0.000 | **0.839** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 |

## Amount of labelled data

Table A.19: Evaluation matrix: Sequential fine-tuning (5 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20261023_212327_a67fb8c9`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.620** | 0.513 | 0.197 | 0.371 | 0.129 | 0.013 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.487** | 0.163 | 0.127 | 0.185 | 0.007 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.465 | 0.292 | **0.713** | 0.366 | 0.472 | 0.421 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.338** | 0.023 | 0.036 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.013 | 0.022 | 0.003 | **0.593** | 0.362 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.075 | 0.015 | 0.133 | 0.005 | 0.118 | **0.521** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.964 | 0.961 | 0.967 | 0.974 | 0.970 | 0.969 |

Table A.20: Evaluation matrix: Sequential fine-tuning (10 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20261023_234659_f041f82f`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.777** | 0.405 | 0.004 | 0.066 | 0.036 | 0.033 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.002 | **0.534** | 0.010 | 0.013 | 0.017 | 0.003 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.111 | 0.091 | **0.743** | 0.241 | 0.014 | 0.009 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.008 | **0.361** | 0.012 | 0.003 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.004 | 0.025 | 0.014 | 0.001 | **0.596** | 0.351 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.018 | 0.001 | 0.022 | 0.001 | 0.243 | **0.683** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.908 | 0.772 | 0.691 | 0.655 | 0.435 | 0.674 |

Table A.21: Evaluation matrix: Sequential fine-tuning (20 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20261024_001927_861cfa24`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.675** | 0.190 | 0.002 | 0.025 | 0.002 | 0.008 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.006 | **0.689** | 0.003 | 0.001 | 0.003 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.032 | 0.011 | **0.793** | 0.233 | 0.005 | 0.004 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.007 | **0.410** | 0.001 | 0.006 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.017 | 0.001 | 0.000 | **0.496** | 0.180 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.001 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.367 | **0.632** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.587 | 0.005 | 0.033 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |

Table A.22: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, 5 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20260926_120018_3ab58c90`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.685 | 0.685 | **0.685** | 0.685 | 0.685 | 0.685 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.23: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, 10 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20260926_184314_43a15eeb`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.686 | 0.685 | **0.688** | 0.688 | 0.688 | 0.688 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.24: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, 20 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20260926_105629_ba181db6`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.689 | 0.688 | **0.693** | 0.693 | 0.693 | 0.693 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.25: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, 5 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20260930_164451_55aada20`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.686 | 0.688 | **0.690** | 0.690 | 0.691 | 0.692 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.980 |

Table A.26: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, 10 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20260930_165220_b0c6c426`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.001 | 0.001 | 0.001 | 0.001 | 0.002 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.002 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.690 | 0.692 | **0.698** | 0.698 | 0.699 | 0.699 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.001 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.000** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.981 | 0.981 |

Table A.27: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, 20 volumes per task, original task order); run `exp_20260930_163605_91573278`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.002** | 0.005 | 0.005 | 0.012 | 0.020 | 0.028 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.016** | 0.016 | 0.039 | 0.092 | 0.117 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.695 | 0.699 | **0.705** | 0.701 | 0.692 | 0.683 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.002 | **0.067** | 0.081 | 0.087 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.001 | 0.003 | **0.047** | 0.073 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.001 | **0.003** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.980 | 0.981 | 0.980 | 0.978 | 0.976 |

## Task order

Table A.28: Evaluation matrix: Sequential fine-tuning (full training split, reverse task order); run `exp_20261022_171520_2dba6ff1`.

| Task | Pre. | LM | MM | Pa | Fe | MT | LT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LM | 0.000 | **0.830** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.004 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.826** | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.011 | 0.000 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.650** | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.001 | 0.002 | 0.190 | **0.822** | 0.001 | 0.004 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.006 | 0.000 | 0.002 | **0.780** | 0.001 |
| LT | 0.000 | 0.006 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.002 | **0.796** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 |

Table A.29: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, full training split, reverse task order); run `exp_20260822_123645_5b18bc03`.

| Task | Pre. | LM | MM | Pa | Fe | MT | LT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LM | 0.000 | **0.343** | 0.343 | 0.343 | 0.343 | 0.343 | 0.343 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.185 | **0.572** | 0.572 | 0.572 | 0.572 | 0.572 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.008 | 0.002 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.695 | 0.539 | 0.000 | **0.774** | 0.774 | 0.774 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.068 | 0.080 | 0.000 | 0.000 | **0.527** | 0.527 |
| LT | 0.000 | 0.041 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.078 | **0.654** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.30: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, full training split, reverse task order); run `exp_20260930_101141_5d80eb69`.

| Task | Pre. | LM | MM | Pa | Fe | MT | LT |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LM | 0.000 | **0.014** | 0.073 | 0.072 | 0.065 | 0.073 | 0.127 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.038 | **0.469** | 0.303 | 0.330 | 0.411 | 0.328 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.008 | **0.440** | 0.406 | 0.212 | 0.176 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.693 | 0.670 | 0.609 | **0.722** | 0.646 | 0.501 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.018 | 0.188 | 0.106 | 0.061 | **0.477** | 0.427 |
| LT | 0.000 | 0.017 | 0.012 | 0.090 | 0.035 | 0.118 | **0.510** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.972 | 0.978 | 0.975 | 0.977 | 0.967 | 0.912 |

## Replay

Table A.31: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, full training split, original task order, replay $\rho = 0.1$); run `exp_20261023_014438_55e6abcf`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.287** | 0.386 | 0.383 | 0.305 | 0.347 | 0.385 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.183 | **0.473** | 0.405 | 0.261 | 0.421 | 0.379 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.647 | 0.539 | **0.713** | 0.628 | 0.678 | 0.699 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.023 | 0.004 | 0.006 | **0.435** | 0.425 | 0.412 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.041 | 0.062 | 0.031 | 0.078 | **0.497** | 0.400 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.020 | 0.030 | 0.020 | 0.021 | 0.075 | **0.427** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.980 | 0.970 | 0.975 | 0.968 | 0.931 | 0.842 |

## Gradient scaling of the prompt-tuning strategy

Table A.32: Evaluation matrix: Prompt-tuning strategy (full training split, original task order, gradient scaling inactive, best validation checkpoint); run `exp_20260816_161201_b39ea60e`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.707** | 0.364 | 0.109 | 0.055 | 0.164 | 0.017 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.102 | **0.549** | 0.119 | 0.025 | 0.090 | 0.001 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.088 | 0.033 | **0.777** | 0.408 | 0.006 | 0.001 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.000 | 0.015 | **0.434** | 0.033 | 0.002 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.008 | 0.019 | 0.012 | 0.007 | **0.555** | 0.162 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.009 | 0.002 | 0.005 | 0.001 | 0.166 | **0.629** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.108 | 0.019 | 0.060 | 0.001 | 0.002 | 0.000 |

## Amount of labelled data with the update count of the full split

Table A.33: Evaluation matrix: Sequential fine-tuning (5 volumes per task, original task order, 216 epochs per task); run `exp_20261023_195739_6044ad8d`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.761** | 0.014 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.004 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.083 | **0.673** | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.007 | 0.000 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.000 | 0.006 | **0.797** | 0.079 | 0.002 | 0.002 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.002 | **0.756** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.007 | 0.002 | 0.000 | **0.676** | 0.086 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.003 | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.122 | **0.610** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.005 | 0.001 | 0.003 | 0.000 | 0.013 | 0.000 |

Table A.34: Evaluation matrix: Task-specific LoRA ($r = 4$, 5 volumes per task, original task order, 216 epochs per task); run `exp_20261023_195940_ea9221f2`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.601** | 0.601 | 0.601 | 0.601 | 0.601 | 0.601 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.121 | **0.528** | 0.528 | 0.528 | 0.528 | 0.528 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.089 | 0.230 | **0.751** | 0.751 | 0.751 | 0.751 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.002 | 0.002 | 0.000 | **0.000** | 0.000 | 0.000 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.011 | 0.033 | 0.001 | 0.000 | **0.466** | 0.466 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.001 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.000 | 0.017 | **0.229** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.979 |

Table A.35: Evaluation matrix: Shared LoRA ($r = 1024$, 5 volumes per task, original task order, 216 epochs per task); run `exp_20261023_200332_9840ab20`.

| Task | Pre. | LT | MT | Fe | Pa | MM | LM |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | **0.245** | 0.172 | 0.060 | 0.130 | 0.036 | 0.010 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.171 | **0.428** | 0.260 | 0.151 | 0.089 | 0.008 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.653 | 0.595 | **0.721** | 0.635 | 0.656 | 0.384 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.038 | 0.007 | 0.006 | **0.453** | 0.310 | 0.031 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.035 | 0.055 | 0.020 | 0.087 | **0.438** | 0.374 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.016 | 0.018 | 0.002 | 0.011 | 0.035 | **0.346** |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.979 | 0.971 | 0.977 | 0.978 | 0.951 | 0.645 |

## Upper reference: joint fine-tuning

Table A.36: Evaluation matrix: Joint fine-tuning (5 volumes per task); run `exp_20261024_002524_abc243ff`.

| Task | Pre. | Joint |
|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | 0.631 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.546 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.698 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.461 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.600 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.661 |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.246 |

Table A.37: Evaluation matrix: Joint fine-tuning (10 volumes per task); run `exp_20261024_014447_afb34098`.

| Task | Pre. | Joint |
|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | 0.550 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.470 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.775 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.498 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.582 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.637 |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.086 |

Table A.38: Evaluation matrix: Joint fine-tuning (20 volumes per task); run `exp_20261024_051245_f9067927`.

| Task | Pre. | Joint |
|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | 0.810 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.771 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.782 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.601 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.779 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.773 |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.000 |

Table A.39: Evaluation matrix: Joint fine-tuning (full training split); run `exp_20261022_171655_6a6e9cb5`.

| Task | Pre. | Joint |
|---|---|---|
| LT | 0.000 | 0.872 |
| MT | 0.000 | 0.847 |
| Fe | 0.684 | 0.873 |
| Pa | 0.000 | 0.834 |
| MM | 0.000 | 0.842 |
| LM | 0.000 | 0.845 |
| Ctrl | 0.979 | 0.000 |

# List of Abbreviations

**CT** computed tomography

**CTA** computed tomography angiography

**MRI** magnetic resonance imaging

**PET** positron emission tomography

**qDESS** quantitative double-echo steady-state

**DICOM** Digital Imaging and Communications in Medicine

**HDF5** Hierarchical Data Format version 5

**NIfTI** Neuroimaging Informatics Technology Initiative

**IQR** interquartile range

**DSC** Dice similarity coefficient

**SAM** Segment Anything Model

**IoU** intersection over union

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2.2 Position of this thesis relative to the closest works. Pretrained model: the continual sequence starts from a model pretrained on other data; few-shot: number of labelled samples per task; task identity: whether the task identity selects parameters at inference; pretrained ability: whether the ability of the pretrained model outside the task sequence is measured after the sequence. 26

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